

MONEY IS A DEMON; LAXMI IS A GODDESS

**A Plea for the
Reorientation of Economy**

VINOBA

**Edited and Translated By
Parag Cholkar**

PARAMDHAM PRAKASHAN, PAVNAR

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Preface

Acharya Vinoba Bhave (1895-1982) is undoubtedly one of the greatest personalities of the last century. Acclaimed as 'Gandhi's spiritual successor' he was, in fact, a successor to most of the ancient spiritual traditions of the world. Philosophy, metaphysics, sociology, political science, pedagogy, economics—there was hardly any subject that his genius did not touch and in which he did not contribute novel, original and insightful ideas. Those ideas assume more importance in the light of the fact that Vinoba was not only a theoretician, but he also practised what he preached, and demonstrated the practicality of what he conceived. The Bhoodan-Yajna, which he initiated and led, gave more than 2.5 million acres of land to the poor agricultural labourers. This has no parallel in the history of the world.

Vinoba's books, most of which are compilations on different subjects culled from his speeches and writings, have been, and are being, published in various Indian languages. However, only a few of them have been published in English. Hence most of his writings have remained inaccessible in English. This is a serious deficiency, when English is the most widely known international language and the perplexed world urgently needs to become aware of Vinoba's experiential wisdom.

This is what prompted me to resolve to prepare a few books in English by editing and translating Vinoba's thoughts on different subjects, which have not been covered in Vinoba's available literature in English, despite being fully aware of my incompetence to do the job, simply because it has not yet been attempted. The attempt is to give a broad outline of some of Vinoba's thoughts with the hope that they would motivate the readers to delve into Vinoba's timeless wisdom.

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Publisher's Note

Vinoba's sagacious words are a treasure-house for humankind. They were perhaps ahead of the times wherein they were uttered, but they are certainly relevant now, when the forces of what Gandhiji called 'a satanic civilisation' are seeking to overpower human spirit. These words can reassure humankind about the ultimate triumph of truth and inspire and guide it in the fight against those forces.

However, only a few of Vinoba's works had been translated in English, whose outreach is increasing in the present era. It is gratifying that Dr. Parag Cholkar has now edited and translated Vinoba's thoughts on some subjects, which have hitherto been unavailable in English, and presented them in the form of nine books. We are happy in publishing them in printed form, while Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan is publishing them as e-books.

We are thankful to Vidarbha Bhoodan-Gramdan Sahayog Samiti (Nagpur) and Bhoodan-yajna Mandal, Vidarbha for their financial assistance for this project.

Vinoba is better known as a sage and a saint. His scholarship and work are also fairly well known, and so are his pedagogical insights and literary excellence. However, it is a pity that his economic thoughts are not so known, for he was the one who initiated and led a novel moral movement (Bhoodan-Gramdan), which had its genesis in the most urgent economic problem of its time.

He did all kinds of manual labour for years to know first-hand the plight of labourers, the backbone of any economy. He carried out intensive experiments to explore how their lot could be improved. When the question of paying living wages to the spinners came up, he did not make calculations on paper; he spun daily for eight hours and lived on the wages prevailing at that time. It was this penance that resulted in increase, albeit insufficient, in the spinners' wages.

Another remarkable experiment was that of *kanchan-mukti* (freedom from artificial money). He and his co-workers farmed with their muscle-power only, without using bullocks or machines, and lived on what they could earn. The experiment demonstrated that such agriculture (which Vinoba termed '*rishi-kheti*') was indeed viable. Vinoba, so keen on gentle expression and so careful about the use of words, nevertheless has criticised artificial money mercilessly and in the strongest possible words!

As Vinoba has himself noted, he lived on two annas (one-eighth part of a rupee) a day, which was the average per capita income in India at that time, while studying economics; for, "I hold that we can only properly digest any subject when we adapt ourselves to it, and harness our senses and faculties accordingly." When he studied the Vedas, he had lived on milk and rice alone. In his words, "It is my custom to establish this kind of link between my lifestyle and my study, and it seems to me essential to do so."

This is what makes Vinoba's economic thoughts particularly worth treasuring.

Vinoba's economic thought, expectedly, fits in the broad framework of Gandhian economic thought. It can be said that it provides a spiritual basis to the Gandhian economic thought (as would be clearer from Vinoba's elaboration of the concepts of *samyayog* and *sarvodaya* in the book '*Strands of a vision*' in this series). Besides, Vinoba has explained, elaborated and even extended some of the Gandhian economic ideas and provided cogent arguments in support of some ideas. Thus, study of these thoughts is also useful for understanding Gandhian economic thought.

Yet no comprehensive book on Vinoba's economic thoughts has so far been published even in any Indian language. These thoughts have, however, been compiled in Vol. 18 of '*Vinoba Sahitya*' (Selected works of Vinoba in Hindi) (whose major part was edited by me). It is mostly on the basis of that volume that this book has been prepared.

I am happy that Sarva Seva Sangh Prakashan has taken initiative for the publication of this book as an e-book, while Paramdham Prakashan is publishing it in printed form. Vidarbha Bhoodan-Gramdan Sahayog Samiti and Bhoodan-yajna Mandal, Vidarbha have provided financial assistance to this project. I am grateful to them. Readers are welcome to point out errors and deficiencies and suggest modifications.

— Parag Cholkar

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1. Major Ideologies

Imported economics

Readymade Western economics has been imported in India, and that is taught in colleges. But that is old and worn out. Economics is not a science like mathematics, which can regulate human life. It is a science, which human beings need to regulate. Economics needs to undergo change in response to the changing conditions. Yet the economics of laissez-faire still holds sway here. As a result, brains of the ruling elite in India are muddled.

Adam Smith's¹ economics has penetrated the people's brains and has caused confusion. They evaluate everything in terms of money, and so do not understand the value of love. They believe that only competition can bring about desired results. This ultimately leads to faith in coercive power and the efficacy of competition.

What is competition? A new idea has been promoted: 'Survival of the fittest'. Only the fittest—the strongest, the most intelligent and the most skilled—have the right to live. That is what they believe; but their practice is contrary to it. The current wars result in the survival of the unfittest—young, strong and intelligent people are recruited in the army and sent to the front to get killed. This principle of 'Survival of the fittest' is absurd and immature. It leads to malice and hatred; it creates fissures even between brother and brother.

The worst part of the repercussions of this principle is the exploitation of the weak by the strong. The latter

become callous and stonyhearted.

Social order can be erected on the foundation either of competition or of compassion. But it is latter that is preferable. We want to build a society based on cooperation—a society wherein everyone gets an opportunity to serve others and has full scope to develop himself. We want to build such an integrated, nonviolent, sarvodaya society. Bhoodan is its foundation.

Three ideologies

Currently, three ideologies are prevalent in the world: capitalism, democratic socialism and communism. The last two profess to stand for equality.

Capitalism is an advocate of merit. It pins its faith upon individual self-advancement as the basis for incentive and claims thereby to promote competence and efficiency in society. It holds that some people have lesser ability; they should get less remuneration and the abler should get more. Remuneration should depend on capability. This is capitalism's device to increase efficiency. This has resulted in high standard of living for a few, but the majority has been left in abject poverty. Capitalism has no remedy for this state of affairs, nor is it concerned with finding a remedy. Rather, it holds that this is inevitable and appropriate. It has consequently made the world miserable, and its supporters are consequently few. It is going to crumble sooner or later.

Democracy gives voting power to all. But minority is at a disadvantage in it. Democracy has no remedy for it, nor has socialism. Democratic socialism claims that everyone would receive protection under it. But it has no remedy for curing the ills which democracy brings into being. So long as the protection of minority depends on the approval of majority, socialism cannot come into existence fully.

1. A British economist in the 18th century and author of the book 'An inquiry into the nature and causes of the wealth of nations', who propounded that an economic system based on individual self-interest would achieve the greatest good for all.

Communism maintains that the exploiter ruling class needs to be liquidated, and this can be done only through class struggle; only then would equality be established. Violence is considered legitimate and proper for it. But this cannot clearly bring about peace in the world, as violence is bound to promote a feeling of vengeance and consequently give rise to counter-violence. Not only this, this view also destroys the sanctity and value of human life.

2. Communism: a critique

What is communism? The word is derived from the Bible. The apostles of Jesus did not own any private property and lived together in a commune. The word 'communism' has its genesis in this experiment.

Reactionary thought

Capitalism arose in Europe and accumulated wealth from all over the world in Europe. Big cities and big factories sprang up. Capitalists oppressed labourers. That gave rise to conflicts between the capitalists and the labourers. Communism was born as a reaction to the oppression of labourers. A reactionary ideology is never a comprehensive theory of life. It keeps on changing.

Socialism also is not an independent ideology. While communism is a reaction to capitalism, socialism is a reaction to individualism.

Being reactionary in essence, both the isms lack complete vision. An ideology which arises as a reaction to some other ideology incorporates the faults in the latter. Capitalists hate labourers. So, communists hate the capitalists. Individualists do not care for society, so socialists call for submission of individual to society – forced if necessary.

Karl Marx gave an important idea to the world: the poor in the world are one; they can stand up together and can break their chains. No one before Marx had said so unequivocally. This had a dramatic effect. But it also perpetuated a wrong notion that the capitalists have no concern for humanity. This fuelled bitterness and drove the poor towards counter-violence.

The idea behind imperialism was certainly powerful. Imperialism spread because of the sacrifice and valour of the colonialists. But it had nothing that could lead to the

welfare of the entire humankind on a permanent basis. So it waned in about a hundred and fifty years.

Marxism inspired the world for about a hundred years. But in a hundred years, it has lost much of its sheen, as its lasting portion was less compared to the ephemeral portion. The ideas, which arise as reactions to the flaws and shortcomings in society, are very effective and influential in the short run. But they fade away as soon as the conditions change and the ideas they were opposing fade away. The ideologies, which arose as reactions to imperialism, are naturally fading away. Marxism is also getting weakened as capitalism and imperialism are getting weakened. It spread because imperialism and capitalism had spread. Marx's books attracted wide attention. His 'Capital' is so difficult to comprehend that one in a million Marxists might have been able to understand it. Yet it became popular, as it was the need of the hour. But Marx's prediction has proved to be wrong, because he thought, wrote and predicted in the context of the situation of his time.

Is mind a product of nature or vice versa? In Europe, there was a school of thought which held that nature was the product of mind. Marx countered it and propounded that mind was the product of nature. The fact is that both affect each other. But we are distinct from both of them. The Self is distinct from both the mind and the external creation. Marx is unaware of this third factor.

Socialism, too, is a reaction and is, therefore, undergoing change. Even in India, it has captured the imagination of some people. But the capitalists are not afraid of it, as they have been assured of the continuance of private sector. God knows what socialism really means! Even Hitler used to call himself a socialist! These days, socialism is taking the form of welfare-Statism. It believes in majoritarianism. It also relies on violence for its

protection. Capitalists also say that they want welfare of all. But neither a capitalist nor a socialist order can build people's power. Socialism is normally equated with nationalisation of key industries. But that is nothing but State capitalism.

The communism in Marx's literature is not there in Russia (1957). Policies of Lenin and Stalin differed from each other. Now the communists have started talking about world peace and co-existence. Communism in China is of a different variety. Indian communism works within the framework of the Indian Constitution.

Theory of dialectics

Communists use the principle of dialectics to bolster their ideology. Dialectical materialism is not really materialistic. For materialism, life is all about physical enjoyment. But dialectics is a mode of thinking. It can lead to either revolution or counter-revolution. I fail to understand how the process of thesis, anti-thesis and synthesis can enthuse one for revolution, and how it can lead to the conclusion that the rich should be exterminated.

The idea is that everything has both good and bad qualities. When a predominantly faulty thing is attacked by a thing having good qualities, a third thing gets formed, which has good qualities of both and does not have faults of either. It is now believed that everyone's earning should be in accordance with their abilities. This gives incentive to work. But it is unjust to a weaker man. So, the principle of equality stands in its opposition. But it encourages laziness. A third idea will, therefore, arise, which will have acceptable parts of both, but not the parts worth abjuring. This new idea will also have some defects and will subsequently be challenged. This process will continue. This is what dialectical materialism holds. It does not necessarily give rise to a particular course of

action. But Marx believed so. He held that the process would eventually lead to communism alone and nothing else. I do not concur with this conclusion.

Partial and one-sided

Except sarvodaya, all ideologies concern themselves with the welfare of only one or the other section of society, not the whole of it. Casteists are concerned with serving only a particular caste. Communalists are concerned with the good of only a particular community. Communists are in the same category. They believe that there are two classes in the society, support one class against another and work for the welfare of one class alone, to the exclusion of other.

There is a famous story of Emperor Akbar and Birbal. The emperor once ordered that all son-in-laws be sent to gallows. Birbal got prepared a lot of iron gallows, one silver one and one golden one. The emperor asked why the silver and golden gallows were there. Birbal replied that the silver one was for himself and the golden one was for the emperor, as both of them, too, were son-in-laws of someone!

Socialism believes that economic impulse is at the base of all human activities. It is an illusion. Economic impulse is a fact; and so is sexual impulse. But both of these impulses do not define humanness. The innermost impulse of a human being is something different.

Why hate?

Those who hate the propertied people also want to own property. Everyone clings to the property he owns, howsoever inconsiderable it may be. Those having considerable property are hated, but hatred does not generate strength. Instead, we should serve the rich and the poor alike.

How to serve the rich? By freeing them from their

possessions. If one is obese, his weight should be reduced. Communists say that we should hate the rich. But I say that to put them on a diet is a form of service to them. It is love; why do you call it hate?

Communism teaches the poor to hate the rich. But this cannot be the duty of the poor. What do the rich have that they should be detested? They have a few pieces of paper (currency notes) printed in the government security press and some pieces of yellow and white metals, which are called gold and silver. They approach the labourers with these and demand things produced by the labourers. It is not very different from demanding things at gunpoint. If we explain to the people that they have nothing to fear from either the guns or those metal pieces, what would the rich get? For, real wealth is with the producers. There is a difference between money and true wealth.

People sell their produce for the sake of money, because they do not produce all that they need. If they become self-sufficient, they would become rich in the true sense. Merely detesting the rich would not work. One would have to give up the fear of guns and craving for money. The moment the labourers realize that they possess real wealth, they would become rich and the rich would become poor. The latter would realize that they have to labour. Therefore, there is no point in teaching the poor to hate the rich. I am doing exactly what the communists seek to do; the only difference is that I prefer love instead of hate.

Classes and class struggle

In fact, no one in this world is really poor. Everyone has something or the other—it may be land, intellect, money or labour. Today everyone utilises what he has for his own benefit. Instead, they should dedicate what they have to the village community. Not only the rich, but the poor also

should dedicate what they have. A moral obligation is binding on everyone. If this happens, the classes will cease to exist. Elimination of classes is better than imagining class struggle. When you talk of class struggle, you bring together and unite different elements in the propertied class. Thus, the communists unite the rich and then try to finish them off. But we work with such skilfulness that the very idea of classes gets uprooted.

Europe had a developed industrial society and a particular social structure. The idea of class struggle originated in that context. That idea cannot be relevant here. In India, we have caste differences. Advocacy of class struggle here would fan the flames of casteism.

I do not think that there is a separate class of exploiters. Yes, exploitation is going on in the world, but everyone of us exploits someone and gets exploited by someone. To eliminate exploitation, the whole social structure would have to be radically transformed. That is what I aim for. Bhoodan is the first step in this direction.

There is absolutely no reason to imagine opposition between individual and society and between capital and labour. Interests of individuals and of society do not differ, nor those of different classes or countries. Interests of one lie in the interests of others. If the society is built on the assumption of conflict between interests, it will be an artificial arrangement.

Interests of capital and labour are supposed to be antagonistic with each other. But, what is capital after all? Labour in the past becomes capital in the present. There cannot be any antagonism between past labour and present labour. Labour in the past is concentrated in the hands of a handful of persons in the form of money. This is how centralisation proceeded in Europe. So, an ideology to fight for snatching capital for the betterment of labour came up. It was the specific situation in Europe, which gave rise to

communism. Social conditions in India are different. Ours is a predominantly agricultural society. The proletariat cannot be the vanguard of revolution in India. A revolution here has necessarily to be an agrarian one.

Blind adherence

One problem about the communists is that they are as jealous about their book as the Vaidiks² are about the Vedas. They blindly stick to every word of it. I have read the 'Capital'. A man who can comprehend it may well become the chancellor of a university! Marxists do not understand it, but still believe that revolution would take place exactly as laid down in that book. But, can a revolution always follow a set pattern? Revolution depends upon the context, the time and the situation. If we dogmatically cling to some texts or words, revolution would elude us.

For the communists, Marx's writings are as sacred as religious texts. But, was Marx a Marxist? He wrote in the context of the situation a hundred years ago. Had he been alive today in the era of atomic power, he would certainly have written differently.

Different streams of thought have been flowing in this country for ten thousand years. The communists are ignorant of them. They should study those thoughts, at least to know what is wanting therein. It is a major lacuna in their ideology. No one can bring about any lasting change here without understanding the Upanishadic philosophy. Creation of differences, bitterness and hatred will not work here.

Orthodox people say that there was *satyayug* (the era of truth and righteousness) in the past. The State was not

2. Those who believe in the authority and sactity of the Vedas and perform the rites prescribed therein.

needed, and it did not exist. The communists believe that such an era will dawn in the future. I say that neither the past nor the future is in our hands; so efforts to bring the era of truth must be undertaken in the present. There is not much difference between the picture of heaven of the orthodox and that of the ideal society of the communists' conception. One has to die in order to enter the orthodox's heaven; and one has to be ready to kill to establish the ideal society of the communists! But we are not ready either to die or to kill.

Ishavasya Upanishad says, the whole universe is pervaded by God, and one should enjoy only after sacrificing in His name. No scripture has given a loftier message. Such spirit exists in communism only in a small measure, as it does not believe in the existence of God. It, therefore, has the concept of expropriation instead of *dana* (charity). There is no question of dedication to God in it. This is what communism lacks. The communists want to expropriate the expropriators; we instead stand for the principles of non-stealing and non-possession and seek dissolution of ownership.

Faulty strategy

The communists say, 'The idea of dissolution of ownership is good, but it would not be materialized through individual sacrifice. We do not believe in individual efforts. We will relinquish our ownership when it ends in the whole society. We will try to eliminate private property through legislation after capturing power, and will hold on to our property till then.'

My complaint against the communists is that they have a theory, but they do not know the path. They have an idea of heaven, but do not have a staircase leading to it! In fact, they do not believe in having a staircase; they believe in soaring in the sky like a bird! This is a major difference between sarvodaya and communism. Sarvodaya

says that if a particular idea is good, if it has truth in it, we must implement it at once and then try to explain it to others. Beginning has to be made from our own selves. The communists want to begin with political power and legislation, and the question of relinquishing their own property comes in the end, while sarvodaya says that we should begin from our own selves and legislation should come in the end.

This is the difficulty with the Gandhian thought. In it, beginning has to be made from our own selves. For the communists, it is the State that would bring about change. Hence, for them, it is the job of the State to distribute the land. They personally do make sacrifices, become poor while working for the poor, but in their ideology there is no place for individual sacrifice.

The communists do not believe in the conversion of heart. They ridicule the idea. I say to them, 'Why do you doubt and disbelieve the possibility of peaceful conversion of heart when you yourselves have been converted to Marxism by reading Marx's books?' The communists certainly have no doubt about the primary goodness of human heart. Those who stand for the ultimate withering away of the State must necessarily have faith in the goodness of human heart.

The communists are concerned with social change. They hold that the efforts of the saints of yore to bring about conversion of heart of individuals have failed. They feel that individuals would change when society changes. They wonder how I would succeed when the saints have failed.

My answer is that the saints have not failed. Had they not tried, we would have remained in the stage of animals. It is because of them that we are now humans. Secondly, the saints used to ask people to renounce self-interest, ego and attachment for the sake of spiritual

progress. Spiritual progress was all right, but what about material progress? What I am saying paves the way for material progress as well. Thirdly, the saints did not have the benefit of scientific progress. Even Gandhiji did not have this benefit. He passed away when modern science had just made its appearance. But we are backed by modern science, and are therefore bound to succeed.

Our strategy

We consider capitalism an enemy. But our bodies are the first post of capitalism. The body is habituated to comforts. First of all, we have to fight it.

Communists accept capitalist path for production and seek equality in distribution. This can never happen. Such an attempt is fraught with risk.

We want the poor to rise, but we do not want them to bang their heads against the wall. We want to lead them from strength to strength. We divide the enemies of poor. Communists indiscriminately attack the rich; so both the good and the bad among them close ranks. The rich must be having at least, say 10% good people. If we disregard them, we lose their support. We, therefore, dissociate them from others in a nonviolent way.

I tell the communists that our process of transformation is not restricted to conversion of heart. The saints relied on the process of conversion of heart; the philosophers from Shankaracharya and Aristotle to Karl Marx believed in the process of conversion of thought; while you stand for the process of social transformation. The three together make the process of sarvodaya. I want to accomplish all the three tasks simultaneously. All of them are needed.

Those who are in the grip of attachment need conversion of heart, while the right-minded persons need change in their thinking. Our strategy is, therefore, two-

pronged. On the one hand, we go on explaining our viewpoint and on the other, continue our penance. When these two kinds of change take place, the situation will also change.

Those who hold that not conversion of heart, but class struggle would bring results have formed such an opinion on the basis of a certain line of thought and certain experiences. But the world is ever-changing. We must allow new experiences to reshape our opinions.

Struggle involves friction, which enfeebles both the parties. Thus, struggle results not in revolution but in wearing away. Yet, I would not hesitate to undertake struggle for the propagation of thoughts. Struggle has its own place; it may become necessary at times. But revolution can take place only through change in thinking. Besides, penance for conversion of heart is also a means available to us. We are moving from place to place on foot; it is also a form of penance. Our strategy includes non-cooperation and satyagraha; and legislation is also not ruled out. We do not block the way of legislation.

Violence can never bring about revolution. The means for revolution must be in accordance with the desired end. Violence brings about sudden change, which gives rise to several reprehensible things. When we take up arms, we implicitly adopt the aim of our opponents. To fight with the opponent with his weapons is plain naiveté. In that case, his victory is assured.

The communists believe that it is justifiable to force a good thing upon the people and it will have good results. I can understand that it may be so as far as physical ailments are concerned. Suppose a child is ill and is refusing to take the medicine. He will be cured even if he is forcibly made to gulp it down. But as far as mental change is concerned, force is totally out of place. Force has no place in the propagation of thoughts.

Land problem, Bhoodan and the communists

The communists here (Balai, 2-4-1952) have presented me with a scroll of honour. I am happy that they have expressed their good wishes for the success of Bhoodan. They have also said that they would be happy if the land problem could be solved peacefully.

I, too, believe that the communists do not like using bad means. The plight of the poor deeply moves them and drives them to improper means. That does not mean that they like such means. They will be happy if the path, which we hold to be right, is proved efficacious. I am not surprised that they do not readily repose faith in the right path. It is our job to prove that it succeeds. If we do not endeavour for it and merely express lip sympathy for the poor, it will not work. The hapless poor will not wait for long. It is, therefore, the duty of the protagonists of nonviolence to show that their way can succeed.

The communists have said in their scroll that the land problem could be solved only through the redistribution of land. I concur with this statement. But they have added that the landowners have come to possess lands because they were cronies of feudal lords. This statement is not entirely wrong, but not fully correct either. It is also true that some of the poor had lost lands because of their bad habits and wasteful expenditure; and some of the landowners have acquired lands because of bravery and good qualities.

But I go a step further. I say that irrespective of how landowners might have come to possess lands, concentration of lands in a few hands will not do in the present time. Land to man ratio is decreasing day-by-day. Village industries are in ruin. Therefore, those who want land must get it. I, therefore, tell the landowners that land does not really belong to them; it is God-given. Claiming right on what belongs to God is sacrilege. God's bequests

like air, water and sunlight are for all. Everyone is born in the same condition; it is not that the child of a beggar is born naked and that of a rich man is decked in fineries at birth. And everyone is reduced to ashes after death. It shows that God wants equality. Differences between the rich and poor, landlord and landless, high and low are against Divine Will.

It is neither necessary nor proper to go on harping that the ancestors of landowners were all rogues. We are out to accomplish an auspicious task. The communists try to fan hatred as much as they can. I do not concur with this approach. There is no point in digging out the past. But both the communists and the communalists revel in this. They fan hatred by refurbishing old memories. This is not the way history should be used. We hardly know real history. It is better to forget it and see what is fair in the present. What someone is at present matters, not what his ancestors were. If we keep this in mind, a number of conflicts will be averted.

The communists hold that the land problem would not be solved until the poor get organised. I accept that there is truth in it. But I would like to add that what I am doing is essentially for organising the poor. The poor are not only landless, they are voiceless too. I am pleading their case as best as I can. I do not beg for land, I ask for land-gifts as a matter of right. I refuse to accept nominal gifts from big landlords and accept the little that the poor offer. It is evident that this manner is organising the poor.

I have undertaken this work (bhoodan) for the labourers only. Normally, labour agitations take place in cities. Rural labourers are unorganised. They lack awareness and education. They do not have any livelihood apart from agriculture. The land on which they work does not belong to them. I have taken up their problem in the spirit of 'Unto this last'. We are working to empower the

labourers in all the respects, and eventually to obliterate the difference between masters and servants.

Bhoodan is often seen as a reply to communism. It is far from truth. We are not against anybody, although bhoodan did begin in Telangana (on the backdrop of communist insurgency). Our work is based on an independent philosophy of life

The synthesis

In spite of all my objections, I hold communism to be the 'next best'. Status quo is not the next best.

We should have the intense compassion that the communists have. But we should work nonviolently.

There cannot be any compromise between sarvodaya and communism, although there can be cooperation to a considerable extent. Sarvodaya is an integrated philosophy of life. It is not a reaction to any ideology. It is consistent with the cultural traditions of this country. There is no scope for much change in it. Communism, on the other hand, will go on changing. It will change because it is not firmly anchored in any sovereign fundamental principle. Ultimately, the river of communism will merge into the ocean of sarvodaya, just as the rivers of other ideologies too will. In the language of the Marxists, I will say that peaceful status quo is the thesis, revolutionary violence is the anti-thesis and revolutionary nonviolence is the synthesis.

It is with communism that sarvodaya will have to fight the last battle. All other forces that are active in the world today will not last long. Capitalism lacks any sound theoretical foundation and so cannot solve the problems of the world. And communism has no future in the atomic age. So, we will have to come into the field, raising the banner of sarvodaya. If we fail in this, capitalism will again raise its head.

3. Gandhiji and Communism

(Preface to Kishorlal Mashruwala's book, 'Gandhi and Marx', written in 1950)

1. Present period of suffering

That the creation is without beginning is universally acknowledged. Even the Earth which we inhabit is, according to both the ancients and the moderns, not less than 2,000 million years old. It is believed that in the beginning there was no life on the Earth. It was, like the sun, a globe of fire. Then it began to cool down until it became sufficiently cool to enable life to subsist on it. Thereupon life sprang up on it. In course of time, Homo sapiens appeared. Even human life, say the scientists, must be about a million years old by now. What are a mere hundred or two hundred years compared to this long period of human existence? Yet the last one to two hundred years have come to assume so much importance for us that we tend to think that they cover more than half of human history!

The present, of course, has always a special importance. For, it is the fruit of the past and seed of the future. Whichever way you look at it, it has a distinction all its own. Being the meeting point of the past and the future, it is, by its very nature, a period of revolution, of whatever kind it may be—life-giving or life-destroying. It is always unique, as it has never existed before and would never exist again.

In short, the present is not only a period of revolution; it is a period of unprecedented revolution. The other day, a gentleman said to me, "We have no use for that old *mantra*, शांतिः शांतिः शांतिः (Peace, Peace, Peace); our chant will now be, क्रांतिः क्रांतिः क्रांतिः (Revolution, Revolution, Revolution)." I said, "It would be better if you utter क्रांतिः

once only. If you do it thrice, it may push you even farther back than your original place. Peace is free from any such risk. But revolution goes stale with age. There is thus no point in chanting 'Revolution' thrice. Say it once, and then never think of it."

How can the past ever have the importance of the present? It might have unprecedented importance in its own time; that is a different matter. Moreover, the present becomes immeasurably important when it is a time of suffering. The period of suffering is always long. A single unpleasant incident makes us forget many happy incidents and remains fresh in memory. Many of the happy moments of life are easily forgotten, but suffering is forgotten only when it is overshadowed by greater suffering. Happiness does not have the power to obliterate suffering. On the contrary, happiness often refreshes the memories of past sorrows. Only a more acute suffering may wipe out smaller ones. The past one hundred or one hundred and fifty years, which constitute our present, have been a period of suffering. No wonder that, for us, it has as if covered the entire human history.

2. Exploration of the path

What has happened that makes us brand the present as a period of suffering? It is the enormous increase in means of comfort and pleasure, which has bred appalling misery. Pleasure and pain are considered opposites, but the truth is that they beget each other. Pleasure begets pain and pain begets pleasure. It is the first happening that we are witnessing today; when the second happening would occur is a moot question.

Pleasure brings in its wake the problem of its sharing. Pain is free from this difficulty. Anyone can have the whole of it, without any competition. It will not arouse anyone's jealousy. Only a rare *mahatma* (great soul) or an utter fool may be the exception.

Our age has produced tons of means of pleasure, and has crushed under their weight the mass of humanity all the world over. Bags of sugar are carried by the bullock on its back to make their way into the belly of the master; the master's stomach gets upset, while the bullock's back is broken. This is the miracle wrought by sugar, an article which is sweet beyond dispute.

When it came to the sharing of pleasure, one claimed the lion's share, another that of the jackal. Nothing was left for the poor lamb. Rather, it itself came to be shared between the lion and the jackal! This is an ironic tale of the present age, which has made countless people cry. The question before us is how to extricate ourselves from this situation. Much of the turbulence and turmoil and many of the agitations have arisen to address this question.

Indian jails were filled with satyagrahi prisoners in 1930-32. There is a story in the Bible that a mob released a thief and crucified Jesus. Similarly, the Government had at that time released criminals from the jails to make room for the satyagrahis. Heaven alone knows all that happened in those overcrowded barracks! Many immersed themselves in the study of astrology, and predicted the day of our release, one after the other, despite recurrent failures of their predictions, and continued their studies even more assiduously. But their despair could not remain concealed for long. Indeed, we had read of Hundred Years' Wars in history, but every month became nerve-wrecking for us. Some of us took to religious observances, some to experiments in cooking, and some combined the two. Others too explored different avenues to engage themselves in. Nevertheless, some were still left idle. They began to reflect, with the earnestness of Buddha, on the way to end the sorrows of India and the world.

Those who had come to believe firmly that the Gandhian way alone was the solution, began the exercise

to purge themselves of the faults in them. They thought, "This surely is the way. But we are not following it properly. We have come here as satyagrahis, yet we send secret messages outside and surreptitiously obtain the articles that we need. This is how we observe *satya* (truth)! And as to *agraha* (persistence), we find even the few months' incarceration difficult to bear. Such is the reality behind our being satyagrahis! How can we hope to achieve success with such weak practice? Let us, therefore, make the best use of this opportunity of having solitude for developing our character." So they began to practise self-discipline. They would complete the jail tasks and then busy themselves in carding, spinning, weaving and even scavenging. But some others did not approve of this self-searching attitude. They argued, "You demand meticulous observance of truth and nonviolence in a political fight. But, tell us where in the whole history you find an example of a political fight, where the participants practised self-discipline more than us. If a nonviolent struggle needs transformation of the ordinary human nature for its success, then it would prove to be a mirage. How long will you go on developing character and exhort the people to sacrifice? When will the evil-minded have change of heart? When will the people's suffering end? Will this happen in the near future? We took to Gandhiji's way because we did not see any alternative to it. The way is certainly good, but should we follow it merely because it is good, even though it is not going to take us to our destination? On the other hand, look at Russia! What a great revolution has taken place there before our eyes!³ It has changed that country beyond recognition, and now they (the Russian revolutionaries) are out to take the whole world under

3. Reference is to the communist revolution in Russia in 1917.

their wings, while we are bound by truth, nonviolence and the discipline of jail rules! What is the use of this? You taunt us for being unable to endure a few months' jail. But to have all the workers in the country behind bars for months on end is no small matter. It would have been a different matter, if some agitation were going on outside. But it is all quiet outside, while we (in jails) are required to adhere to self-discipline. Will the quiet outside and our discipline inside the jails together lead to swaraj? Let us, therefore, realize that the path we have been following is wrong, and instead of soul-searching let us start searching for the right path. Nothing is wrong with our souls; they are just what they always have been!" These people then started the study of the communist and socialist literature. It is said that at the time of Deluge, when all land was submerged under water, sage Markandeya alone kept swimming in it. In the seclusion of the gaols, these young men began swimming in the vast expanse of socialist literature.

And really this literature is deep in some places and shallow in some, but is as fathomless as the sea. A few began to delve deep into Marx's Capital. But many immersed themselves in the shallow propagandist literature that was streaming in from Russia. Since the Puranic Age (the age of ancient Hindu mythology), perhaps none except the communists have shown boundless zeal for propaganda, regardless of the amount of repetition. The authors of the Puranas and the modern Russians, both share the belief that howsoever forgetful a listener or a reader may be, some impression is bound to be left on his mind, if a statement is constantly repeated. The readers of the Puranas believe that there is a Heaven, where it is possible to go after death; our young friends in the jails undertook the labour of reading the vast socialist literature in the faith that some sort of Heaven has already descended in Russia.

During my incarceration in connection with the 'Individual satyagraha' of 1940, a communist friend advised me to read communist literature. I requested him to read it to me while I span. He agreed and read to me what he thought to be the essential in Marxist literature. I had already read Marx's Capital, which is their basic text, some years ago. So it was not difficult for me to grasp what he read to me. This went on for a few months. It was selected material that he read to me; yet the amount of repetition had considerable impact on me. No wonder that the minds of our young men, instead of getting fed up, got considerably impressed.

3. Individual development and social order

Development of virtues in individuals and the building of a social order are the two ideals, which have been common from the beginning of history. The advocates of the first doctrine maintain that the world and the human life go on because of moral qualities. The social structure changes in accordance with the development of virtues. Hence, all good people should concentrate their attention on the development of moral qualities. Attempt to change the social structure would only boost our ego. The aphorism जगद्-व्यापार-वर्जम् defines the limit for a devotee.⁴ All that we need to do is to strengthen our faith in the rules of spiritual and moral discipline such as nonviolence, truth, self-control, contentment and cooperation and try to follow them in our day-to-day life. Let us do this and all else will follow as a matter of course. No mother needs to be told that she should feed her child. No child needs to be told that

4. A devotee can attain all the powers of God except the creation, sustenance and dissolution of the world (Brahmasutra, 4.4.17).

it should cry if it is hurt. Let love be there; then the child will be fed. If there is pain, crying will follow.

This faith is innate in the saints. It is at the root of the elucidation by Jnanadeva (in 'Jnaneshwari', his commentary of the Gita) of the divine qualities and the characteristics of Self-knowledge listed in the Gita.

The communist doctrine is the very opposite of this. They say, "What you call the development of moral virtues takes place in the mind, but that is not the creation of mind. It is the result of environmental factors. The mind itself is the product of its material environment. A child gets afraid at the sight of a bearded man, because its mother has no whiskers. Had the mother been moustached and bearded, the child would probably have got afraid at the sight of a clean-shaven man. You say that crying follows pain, but pain is also a result of material factors like the pricking of a needle. Mind is not something independent of matter. It is just a reflection, an image of the world outside. An image cannot govern the substance; it is the latter which governs the former. A good night's sleep makes the mind fresh, happy and reposeful—that is the manifestation of *sattva*⁵. After a while, when one feels hungry, *rajas* takes over. And after the meal, *tamas* becomes dominant. It is unnecessary, therefore, to give much importance to these three qualities. Create the right conditions and they will inevitably give rise to the right set of qualities. Hence, change the environment as rapidly as you can and by whatever means available, and do not waste your time in weaving

5. According to the *Sankhya* philosophy, *Prakriti*, or the Nature, is constituted of three *gunas*, which can be called essential qualities or modes: *Sattva* is the principle of equilibrium and harmony; *rajas* is the principle of passion, restlessness, endeavour and initiation; and *tamas* is the principle of ignorance and inertia.

fantasies. The mind of man will remain what it is. It will neither become brutish, nor like an imaginary god. It remains within its limits. With the improvement in the environment, it shows a little improvement; with its deterioration, it too deteriorates a little. Do not worry about it. If violence has to be committed to change the social order, do not bemoan the death of virtues. It is the end of evil order, which is important. The violence that has to be employed for this purpose is not ordinary violence; it is on a higher level. It is really a virtue. If you can understand this, virtues will automatically get developed in you."

These are the two extreme doctrines. The rest have to take—and they take—their place between these two, as per their convenience.

Some say, "Changing the social order is also important. But the change should go hand in hand with the development of moral attributes. There are certain abiding moral values in the society. If we lose them in our haste for the creation of a new social order, disregarding the means, it will be tantamount to losing the capital in the greed for interest. Social order is not something permanent. It will, and should, change according to time and place. We cannot create a particular social order once and for all, and then go to sleep. It is no good making a fetish of a particular order. After all, it is the people, who make society. As the people are, so will the society be. Therefore, social order should be changed without transgressing the limits of goodness; goodness should rather be enhanced and the change should be brought about through the power of goodness. We need not worry if it takes place gradually and at a slow pace. The food which is leisurely masticated is well digested. And the slow pace will in the end prove to be the most hectic. When we talk of enhancing goodness, we are not seeking to become angels. We do not want to be so conceited. As

we are human beings, there is no fear of our turning into angels, no matter how good we become. Therefore, let us achieve, without any apprehension, as much development of goodness as we possibly can. It is true that a good social order assists moral development. But it is truer still to say that we can have a good social order only when there is adequate development of virtues in individuals. Steadfast faith in moral values is the foundation on which a social order is built. How can you hope to have a strong edifice if you dig up the foundation?"

To this some others say, "We agree that a change in the social order should be brought about while preserving eternal values. Faith in virtues should remain steadfast. It is right that what is transient should not be preferred over what is eternal. But one should not forget that exigencies of situation may necessitate abandonment of a regular duty. You consider prayer a regular duty. But if fire breaks out while you are praying, will you not rush to extinguish it? You will resume your prayer after putting out the fire. Such discretion is essential everywhere. Communists believe that violence is essential and inescapable for a revolution. We do not agree with them. We believe that in a country like India, and in a democratic country, it is possible to bring about a revolution through the ballot box without resorting to violence. We do not mind if it takes a few years to create public opinion to that end. We will patiently continue the work of creating public opinion. But if the party in power does not maintain the sanctity of elections and abuses its position of authority, and you still insist on the purity of means, you will always take a beating. Hence, we do not regard it wrong to resort to other than nonviolent means in particular situations, if it cannot be helped. You may call it an excusable action in an emergency, but do not call it a sin. Such acts in an emergency need not destroy eternal values. Occasional lapses can be set right

afterwards. Eternal values would be made stronger, the moment transfer of power is achieved. This is like shaking a peg to drive it deeper and make it firmer. This temporary recourse to violence is in the interest of nonviolence itself. If we do not do that, nonviolence may recede farther away from us. Do we not prune a plant so that it may grow more swiftly? You have to make a distinction between striking the axe at the root of a tree and pruning its branches. Capitalism, imperialism, fascism—all strike at the root of nonviolence. Because of indiscriminate practice of violence, communists also strike at the root of nonviolence. Although it is not their intention, the result is the same. We cannot give consent to such practice. But we feel that to block social progress and let the miseries and suppression of the poor continue in the name of moral values is to take the faith in virtues to the extreme. Besides, we hold that the use of arms against a foreign aggression or an internal disorder is not violence, but a part of the duties of a State. Barring such exceptions, we agree with you in your insistence on nonviolence for all other purposes.”

The standpoints of the saints and the communists are based on their fundamental convictions. The last two positions are what may be called ethical approaches. The former has been espoused in this country most effectively by Gautam Buddha and Gandhi. Some founders of religions also have held this position. We find only a few sayings in the Smritis (social codes) in favour of this position. Most of the Smritis have adopted the second ethical position. Most of the Congressmen and patriotic socialists seem to belong to this school. Several of those who call themselves Gandhians tend to converge to this position. According to this analysis, we can say that Kishorlalbhai's book compares Gandhiji's satyagrahi ethical stand and the communist faith in revolution for changing the social structure.

4. Marxism and Gandhian philosophy

What can be a more fascinating subject in the present age than a comparison between the thoughts of Mahatma Gandhi and the great sage Marx? If the human life in the last hundred and fifty years is distilled, we will perhaps be left with only these two names. When Marx's name is taken, Lenin's name need not be taken separately; and when Gandhi's name is taken, influence of Tolstoy on him is tacitly acknowledged. The two ideologies are confronting each other, each bent on swallowing up the other. Superficially, it appears that the communists led by Russia and the capitalists in the garb of democracy under the leadership of U. S. A. are the two main contestants on the world stage. But ideologically, the latter has lost all vitality and though it may be flaunting its military strength, I do not think that capitalism stands up to communism. On the other hand, though Gandhian ideology appears nowhere in an organized form, yet I believe that as it has an innate vigour because of being right and righteous, ultimately it will be Gandhian thought with which communism will have to fight, and none else. These are the two powerful ideologies, which Kishorlalbhai has compared in this small book. His exposition of Gandhian thought will be regarded as authoritative, since he is the author of 'Gandhi-Vichar-Dohan' (Digest of Gandhian thought). And though his treatment of Marxism may not be considered equally authoritative, he has taken enough care to see that no injustice is done in presenting it.

At least in India, comparison of Gandhian thought and communism is a topic of everyday discussion. Everyone evaluates both in his or her own way. Gandhian thought has spiritual halo around it, while communism is strongly backed by scientific terminology. Having earned the credit of securing swaraj for India, Gandhian thought can no longer be dismissed as impracticable. And

communism, too, has shown its current vitality by rejuvenating the grand old China.⁶ This tempts some workers to seek reconciliation between the two ideologies to the extent possible; and this leads to the enunciation of formulae like 'Gandhian thought is communism minus violence'. But, in fact, these two ideologies are irreconcilable; the differences between them are fundamental. And they are deadly opposed to each other.

Once in a discussion, someone opined that Gandhian thought and communism differ from each other on the point of nonviolence only. I said, "Two persons were so physically alike that one could have well served as the double of the other in a political fraud. The only difference was that one was breathing, while the other one was not. The result was that dinner was being prepared for the former and funeral was being arranged for the latter." Such is the 'nominal' difference between the two! Kishorlalbhai has shown that even their physical features differ from each other. That is natural; for how can the living and the dead look alike?

Communism being obviously an ideology of attachment (*aasakti*), I never considered it worthy of a philosophical examination. Although its votaries have erected an imposing philosophical edifice around it, it has hardly any worth as a philosophy. It is so, because it is not an edifice at all; it is a web of words to mesmerize the gullible. Their vision is jaundiced. For example, they believe that conflict is the supreme principle; there is nothing else in the world except conflict. How does a child get milk from his mother's breasts? How does this miracle happen? From their point of view, it is the result of a conflict between the breast of the mother and the

6. Reference is to Chinese communist revolution of 1949 led by Mao Zedong.

mouth of the child! I have said this in a lighter vein, but these people will accept it in all seriousness. In short, what we regard as cooperation is also a conflict for them. How great a conflict must actual resistance be in their eyes! How can one argue with those who are under the spell of this principle? One can only admire their steadfastness. For them, practice is not to be devised in accordance with the theory; theory is to be built in tune with the practice.

They also vehemently argue whether mind has emanated from matter or vice versa. None but a lunatic will say that mind is not the creation of matter. Had mind been the creator of the universe, there would not have been any need for the Creator God. But though mind is the product of matter, the Self (*atman*) remains a separate entity beyond both mind and matter. But the Self is nowhere to be found in communism. And if anyone were to put any evidence before them, they will immediately reject it. Shankaracharya has said to such a man, "Friend, I have no quarrel with you. For you, who deny the Self, are yourself the Self. If you accept it, it will be proved by your acceptance; and if you deny it, it will be proved by your denial." The man who says that he is awake proves that he is awake; and the man who says that he is asleep also proves that he is awake. Those who did not take into account the Self, the third factor which shapes both mind and matter, and then got involved in the reordering of society, naturally cared little for virtues. What to us are spiritual qualities are to them merely the product of economic conditions.

A soulless ideology has no place for the freedom of the individual. Who cares to count the number of hairs which the barber snips off from one's head? Individuals come and go, society abides; therefore, it alone truly exists; the individual counts for nothing.

These thinkers have traced the whole course of human history, and they have arrived at the conclusion that just as an arrow cannot deflect from its path and is bound to follow a particular path, so also it is with mankind. Its history has decided once for all its future course. There is no freedom of action left for us. Rivers of blood will flow first, then will follow the rivers of milk and honey and in the last, the river of water will flow to quench the thirst of all. Everything is predetermined. Their examination and research of history has provided them with a science of revolution as exact as Euclidian Geometry. Marx foretold even the order and sequence in which revolutions would take place in different parts of the world. Although this prophecy has not exactly come true, the discrepancy should be regarded as an inadvertent error in astrological prediction; it does not prove that the science of astrology itself is wrong. Revolution is as inevitable as the call of death. Under the circumstances, all that a man can do is to participate in it and contribute to its success; and that is what he should do.

5. Independent thinking necessary

It is said that sage Valmiki wrote the Ramayana first, and Rama conformed to every word of it during his life; so, he had no difficulty. He had only to consult the book and act accordingly! Since the consequences had also been noted, there was no question of worries on that account. So is the case with the communists. Lenin followed what Marx had written; we, too, have merely to follow him to reach the goal. If there appears any discrepancy between the words of Marx and the actions of Lenin, the contradiction needs to be resolved. But that is not difficult. As Smritis are supposed to conform to Shrutis—practice is supposed to conform to theory—and practice is clearer, theory needs to be adjusted accordingly. If you do this, there is no problem.

It is quite the opposite case with the Gandhian ideology. If communism is a solid and concrete superstructure, Gandhian thought is like a disorderly basement. If we examine Gandhiji's ideas, we find that they have gone on developing. Gandhiji has himself said that if there is any inconsistency between his earlier and later pronouncements, we need not attempt their reconciliation; we should take the later ones and ignore the earlier ones. His greatest campaigns had no previous planning, no settled strategy, no organisational arrangement. When one says, "One step is enough for me", why should the Lord show him two steps? And, should the later statements be considered authoritative? "No", he says, "Do not consider any statement as final and binding. Use your own intelligence. You may consult me so long as I am here. Thereafter everyone is free to decide for himself." That is why there is no unanimity even among his closest followers. A gentleman once remarked in a lighter vein, "Gandhiji was a devotee of the Gita and so were his close associates. All of them have written something on the Gita. But each one has a different interpretation!" This comment proves nothing except that the words of the Gita have immense capacity to hold wide array of meanings. But the fact remains that there is not a single issue, not even khadi, which is a fundamental issue in sarvodaya, on which all the close associates of Gandhiji will speak with one voice. That is why someone had suggested to Gandhiji that he should set forth his ideas in a systematic manner in scientific terminology. But Gandhiji refused, saying, "For one thing, I have no time; for another, I am still experimenting. The science will, if it has to, develop gradually out of it." Of course, he was right. The reasons he cited were all pertinent. But his response appealed to me for another reason. What is the use of a systematic exposition? It can only counter the exposition of the opponent. But just as

armaments cannot neutralize the armaments of the rival—rather, they induce growth of the latter and create many problems in its wake—the war of words between two systems, rather than clarifying issues, adds to the confusion. Therefore, it is better to allow thought to remain free than to straitjacket it into a rigid system. It may lead to discordance, as happened in the case of Buddha's disciples, who took different paths. The only right thing to do in such a situation is to follow one's judgement, as Gandhiji prescribed.

6. Three Gandhian principles

Kishorlalbhai has tried to systematize Gandhian thought, keeping intact its openness and lack of rigidity. He has sketched its outline, consisting of three concepts: (i) *varna* system,⁷ (ii) trusteeship and (iii) decentralization. Let us briefly consider each.

(i) Gandhiji has adopted the old traditional concept of *varna* system after infusing new meaning in it. Or one may say, after realizing the rightness of the basic idea behind it. I think, this is his experiment in nonviolence. It is the mark of a nonviolent process not to refute established and revered words and ideas, but to accept them and widen their meanings, develop them and give them a new life. The whole idea of synthesis in the Indian tradition has arisen from this process. In this process, there is not even the awareness of infusion of new meaning into the word. It appears that the old meaning has only been refurbished. The Gita has laid down this way by developing the meanings of many

7. According to the Hindu scriptures, society is divided into four divisions or *varnas*: *Brahmin* (teachers, priests, intellectuals), *Kshatriya* (warriors, administrators, rulers), *Vaishya* (those engaged in trading, farming, animal husbandry) and *Shudra* (artisans and those doing menial work).

words like *yajna*. No doubt, there is a danger of distortion in the meanings of words in this process. If this happens, it will be an experiment in untruth, rather than in nonviolence. Only when the meaning of a word is not too stretched and new meanings are derived from it gently and reverentially, can the process be called a nonviolent one. Gandhiji was born and brought up in Indian culture, and he spoke mostly to the people steeped in that culture. I think that is the reason of his acceptance of the idea of *varna*. Had he been born elsewhere and addressed a different society, it cannot be said the word '*varna*' and the idea behind it would have occurred to him as an essential component of a nonviolent social order. But he would still have been obliged to accept the essence in the concept through some other word. What I mean to say is that those who dislike the words '*varna*' and '*varna* system' need not be alarmed at Gandhiji's use of them. We are not concerned with words, but with their content.

The *varna* system, in essence, comprises of three factors: (a) parity in wages for all kinds of work, (b) absence of competition and (c) a system of education which takes the fullest advantage of hereditary training and learning. When we talk of a nonviolent social structure, we have these three elements in mind as its essential ingredients.

(ii) It is the same with the theory of trusteeship. Like the *varna* system, this word is also disliked by many. There is no doubt that *varna* system, in its origin, conveys a right idea and wise planning. Perhaps, the same cannot be said with certainty about the theory of trusteeship. The word has been abused right since its inception. But it has a good connotation in law; and as Gandhiji was a student of law, he took up the word. And as he was also a votary of truth, he associated with it only the original pure meaning. As I have not been a student of law, the

word has failed to attract me despite its use by Gandhiji. But that does not prevent me from appreciating what Gandhiji meant by this word. Concepts like non-possession, *samabhaava* (sense of equality) etc., found in the Gita, had taken a strong hold of Gandhiji's mind; and when he began to reflect on how he could give practical shape to them, he found this term useful. Gandhiji has stated in his autobiography that the study of the Gita illuminated the meaning of the word 'trustee' and the word, in its turn, showed how the riddle of applying the principle of non-possession in the society could be solved. In short, Gandhiji held that the only practical method of practising non-possession in the society, not only in the present condition of society, but in any circumstances, for a human being encased in the body, is to use one's powers and capacities as a trustee. Kishorlalbhai has explained the concept so thoroughly that even a layman can easily understand it; there is no room left for any misunderstanding.

Even if inequality of wealth is left aside as being the result of an unjust social order, the inequalities of intellectual and physical endowments cannot be fully averted. We may assume that through education and regulation these inequalities can be reduced to some extent. Still, even in an ideal condition, we cannot conceive of their total absence. This being so, it has to be realized that whatever intelligence, physical strength and wealth a person has come to possess, he possesses them for the benefit of all. This is what trusteeship is in a good sense. But evil-minded people have so debased the word that it seems nearly impossible to restore it to its pristine meaning. I have, therefore, used the word '*vishwasta-vritti*' (attitude of trust), which has a positive meaning. As a general rule, we accept the principle of self-reliance—that no one should be dependent on another. But if no one trusts another, life would veritably be hell. Mutual trust is

the foundation of human relationships—between parents and children, between neighbours, and even between nations. If we consider such mutual trust risky, it means that we are thinking on a sub-human level. The feeling of mutual trust can be fostered by education. If instead of doing it, we believe that it is better to bundle all the people into a single uniform entity to obviate any need for mutual trust, it will be nothing but intellectual indolence.

A social order based on mutual trust implies that the capacities of all its members are used in a planned and harmonious manner. This idea is well expressed by the word *lok-samgraha*. Individual non-possession is a fundamental principle of *lok-samgraha*. It means that individuals should use their capacities for the good of all. We may not use the word 'trusteeship', but we must not reject this principle of mutual trust.

(iii) Decentralization, however, is in a different category. Since the word is of recent origin, it has not yet gathered any good or bad associations. Both the word and the idea behind it are new. But one may ask, 'Was it not all decentralized before the advent of the machine age? What is new in it then?' Yes, everything was decentralised before the machine age. But the fact that industries were carried on in villages in a decentralised manner does not, in itself, constitute decentralization. Decentralization means that besides decentralised industries there should also be an integrated and comprehensive plan. In the absence of such a plan, they are merely scattered industries. Such scattered industries were there before the machine age. But they inevitably broke down with the first blow of the machine age. A genuine decentralization is not such a brittle one; on the contrary, it is capable of breaking down the machine age. The present machine age is so only in name; actually it is uncontrolled unlike a machine. Communists want a well-controlled machine age. But

although machines, like weapons, are invented by man, they are inherently non-human. Hence, they cannot be humanized beyond a certain point. On the contrary, they make man their plaything. Here I mean by 'weapons' the destructive weapons, and not the beneficial tools in the hands of a surgeon. In the same way, by 'machine' the machines which snatch work from man's hands and make them unemployed, idle and dull are meant; not those which rush to man's help, aid his limbs, and have been 'humanised' due to their association with human beings. A wheel-barrow is an example of a tool of the latter kind. We are at present engaged in digging a well, and I see how greatly it helps us in removing rubble. It is also a gift of the machine age. So, when I say that decentralization will destroy the machine age, I mean that it will destroy the machine age only after deriving whatever benefit it could provide. Indeed, the machine age will not be destroyed without this. The old scattered industries lacked such power. This is the fundamental difference between purposely decentralized industries and the old un-centralized industries. Thus, both the word 'decentralization' and the idea which it expresses are new. If this distinction is borne in mind, most of the objections against decentralization will be blunted like a sword struck against a rock.

But the idea of decentralization is not confined to industries. The process of decentralization applies to the State as well. Even those who call for a nonviolent social order at times lose sight of this fact. They support industrial decentralization; but at times demand a strong central political authority (normally for the transition period) for the preservation of the former! Communists also envisage ultimate withering away of the State like *ghee* (clarified butter) in summer heat; but until then they want it to be solid and robust, not only like the solidified *ghee* in winter, but as the iron hammer—their adored

ensign—which smashed Trotsky's head!⁸ Almost all 'responsible' worthies, right from the earliest times down to the present, have been planning for such somersault during the 'transition period'. Gandhi alone has envisaged decentralization of political power in all the times—the present, the transition period and the future. But our friends say that we may put the idea aside as an idea fit either for the golden age in the past or for the future Utopia of sarvodaya; such talk, they contend, is irrelevant in the present.

7. Mother and preceptor

Although there are differences on many points between Gandhian thought and communism, some elements are common in both, and these are also important. How could it be otherwise, as both of them have originated from good intentions and a desire for the welfare of the people? Both are champions of the poor. So wretched is the condition of the poor throughout the world that whoever takes up cudgels for them and has the courage and longing to not only console them but also to lift them up with the intensity of a mother's love, can be said to have a quality that can neutralize all his faults.

Both Gandhian thought and communism seek uplift of the poor with the intense love of a mother. However, a mother's blind love often disregards long-term effects and gets enmeshed in immediate results. This is the case with communism also. Intense love of a mother cannot, in itself, solve the child's problems. That intensity gives rise to keenness to seek their solution. But the solution needs the skill of a preceptor.

8. Leon Trotsky, a prominent leader of communist revolution in Russia, was banished from Russia by Stalin, Lenin's successor, who had him murdered in 1940 in Mexico.

I was having a discussion with a communist, who was ardent, yet had not lost his power of independent thinking. I asked him, "Can violence be regarded as the weapon of the masses?"

He said, "Not as a general rule. But in particular circumstances and with special efforts, the masses can be prepared for using the weapon of violence."

I observed, "Granted that the masses can be so prepared in particular circumstances, but what is the use of it? Surely, what you gain once will not last forever. We may pretend to have the capacity for violence, which is not in our nature; but the power of violence will ultimately be in the hands of those who have this capacity ingrained in them. And if you seek to change the nature of all the people, in the first place that is not possible; and even if it becomes possible—that is, the whole society becomes cruel—it would be a great calamity, whose consequences would be far beyond even your expectations or imagination."

He said, "Let that be so. But present condition should change. That is what matters."

I said, "It may momentarily appear that the present condition has changed. But we will soon revert to it with double the force."

"Let it be so," he said, "We will tackle that situation when it arises."

I said, "This is the comment of a bewildered mind, not of a scientific one. Communists lay claim to scientific thinking."

"Yes", he said, "They do make such a claim as they talk of changing the order permanently after the conquest of power. I do not subscribe to this position; nothing is permanent in the world. Yet the rich must be expropriated now. Future generations will solve the problems in future."

Communists will regard this man half-baked. I think, he is in his senses despite being hallucinated. Communist philosophy talks of a permanent order of society, but it is nothing but opium. Most of the communists are concerned with immediate results. It shows the intensity of a mother's love, but not the preceptor's calm and enlightened concern for the well-being of the pupil.

8. The only way for deliverance

Be that as it may. The illiterate people of India are in an extremely pitiable condition, even after the attainment of Independence. They long to be rescued and do not care how. They have neither capacity nor time to examine various ideologies. Whoever fulfils their desire will be their God. Hence, denouncing communism, refuting it by philosophical arguments or suppressing it by force will be of no avail. Just as in the monsoon, waters of all rivers and streams flow towards the ocean, so in swaraj all the workers should rush towards the rural and the distressed people to serve them.

Fortunately, the heart of the masses is still sound in spite of adversities. The village folk still believe that if they are ever to be saved, it will be through the Gandhian way alone. The present Government is constituted of Gandhiji's colleagues. Congress, the biggest organization in the country, has also been nurtured by Gandhiji. The sarvodaya constructive workers are avowedly Gandhians. Indian Socialists are also Gandhiji's progeny. Establishment of satyagrahi socialism in this country is their declared aim. If all these, with their varied capacities and with their distinctive outlooks, apply themselves together to the service of the people, how could poverty and misery survive? But these four have taken four different ways. And the result is that a fifth one is rushing in. Who is this fifth one? In the language of the Upanishads, it is death: मृत्युर्धावति पञ्चमः.

I do not blame anyone for this state of affairs, nor do I despair. I blame no one, because ours is a big country with big problems, and no wonder, differences of opinion are also great. And I do not despair: why should I when I have a pickaxe in my hands?

In the course of a discussion at our Ashram, someone suggested that if wells were dug at various places, production would increase and starvation would be averted, so Government should take steps in this direction. I said, "We are the Government. Who else? Come, let us begin to dig." We began to dig. The diggers had absolutely no previous experience. But the pickaxe went on digging. Eventually water appeared. People of surrounding areas came to visit our well and drank its water, considering it holy. A village headman started digging a well in his village. And the young boys of Sargaon did a remarkable thing. They decided to spend their winter vacation working on our well. They came without notice, put up four hours' labour and returned without any fanfare. When God is arousing such divine inspiration in the hearts of the people, why should anyone despair? Let us worship the goddess of labour and seek her favours. She is saying, "Ask and you will get, seek and you will find."

To me at least, it appears that salvation of India lies in freedom from the lure of money and in performance of bodily labour. In it I see the essence of Gandhian thought, its meeting point with communism; and an antidote to both communism and capitalism.

4. Dignity of Labour

Parity between intellectual and physical labour

Presently, people believe that intellectual labour should get more remuneration and physical labour should get less. We have to remove this misconception and establish samyayoga. In fact, intellectual or moral labour should not be measured in terms of money.

Any person, who puts in honest labour for the society, becomes entitled to bread. A person with only one eye may render less service than one with two eyes, but if he does it to the best of his ability, he deserves fulfilment of his basic needs. Service is in the category of moral acts, while fulfilment of basic needs is a physical requirement. A moral matter cannot be evaluated in terms of a physical matter, just as a banana and a stone cannot be compared with each other. What can be the monetary value of the act of saving a person from drowning? A mother serves her child. Some persons serve the society. Can such service be measured in terms of money? It is invaluable.

I have worked as a teacher, a judge, a farmer, a writer, an editor etc., but I never felt that one kind of work is superior to other kinds. I experienced mental joy in all of them in equal measure. Labour may differ from work to work, but that need not affect the mental joy.

Value of labour should be the same in the realm of economics, just as it is in the realm of moral acts. There is no basis for considering intellectual work more dignified and worthy of more remuneration. Samyayoga does not accept this, as it is based on the idea of spiritual equality. The service that one is capable of rendering may differ from person to person, but all must be cared for equally.

Everyone should get full opportunity to get educated and develop himself. He may then join any field

depending on his competence. But difference in remuneration is totally unacceptable. If remunerations differ, there will be undue competition in some sectors, and development will be skewed.

The Gita has said that if a person performs his duties sincerely and diligently, he becomes entitled to spiritual liberation (18.45). We have to imbibe this teaching.

Decline of the country

But, in the course of time, a hierarchical structure emerged. Some people proclaimed that they were superior to others and extricated themselves from physical labour. Physical labour lost dignity. If this happens in any country, history testifies that this sets in motion the degeneration of that country. This happened in Rome, and this happened in India also. The hierarchical structure resulted in the decline of the country. In the ancient times, intellectual pursuit was associated with voluntary poverty. But now the educated feel that they should get more money. This is a dangerous idea. Society cannot become strong without unity and integrity in economic and social life, without being egalitarian.

Now the situation is that those engaged in the most essential enterprises get less. Agriculture once had the most prominent place in society. Now it has become unviable. Peasants are living only because they cannot commit suicide.⁹ Rural life has lost charm and vitality. How to make it beautiful, enjoyable and worth living is the main problem.

When we think over it, it occurs that unless physical labour is accorded moral, social and economic dignity,

9. Vinoba wrote this in 1958. Farmers' suicides were evidently rare at that time. Now it has become a disquieting phenomenon. Thousands of farmers have committed suicide in India in recent times.

rural life will continue to be shunned. In India, we committed a grave sin in denying dignity to physical labour. British education aggravated that sin. It made the bodies of the educated incapable of doing physical labour, and the educated also began to look down upon such labour. Physical labour lost both economic and moral dignity. Problems before the country cannot be solved unless this injustice is removed.

Righteous life

An individual who earns his bread by the sweat of his brow rises in moral stature. Sin cannot easily gain access into his life. Physical labour throughout the day leads to sound sleep in the night. There is no time to sin during the day, and as the tired body seeks rest, there is no question of entertaining impure thoughts in the night. A life devoid of any space for sin is a truly righteous life.

But actual condition appears to be different. It is observed that sin has intruded into the lives of not only those who do not perform physical labour, but also of those who perform it. Labourers have also fallen victim to addictions and debauchery. Evidently, physical labour in itself does not make one a *karmayogi*.¹⁰ Sin enters labourers' lives because they do not look upon work as worship; they work because they have to.

Identification with the poor

Our main drawback is that we have failed to identify with the poor around us. And we will not be able to do so until we cast aside the support of money and earn our livelihood by the sweat of our brows. It is not that we do not put in physical labour, but what we do is not

10. One who works selflessly and without desire for the fruit of work.

sufficient. We should vow to earn the bread through physical labour and extricate ourselves from the clutches of money. Only then will the power of nonviolence become manifest. I fully believe in what Jesus had said: a camel may pass through the eye of a needle, but a man infatuated with money cannot realise the power in nonviolence. It makes me urge my co-workers to give up money and engage in productive labour. Unless one becomes committed to productive labour, Bhoodan-yajna would not reach its fruition, nor would the differences between the rich and the poor be erased and the poor rise. Establishment of sarvodaya would then be far-off.

Productive labour necessary

I am pained to find that the educated people have as if vowed not to undertake productive labour. Everyone needs exercise. So, gyms are opened in cities. But nothing is produced there except sweat! And such exercise is considered prestigious. What is the harm if exercise is productive? The country needs increase in production. You can grind grains or grow kitchen garden. And, of course, ply the spinning wheel.

*Shramadan*¹¹ is being talked about, but often it is restricted to labourers. This is wrong. It should be sought from all. We want to eliminate difference between masters and servants. Enhancement in the dignity of labour is what is needed. Gandhiji carried out many kinds of work including those considered menial. He spun regularly. This was to impress upon the world that everyone who eats must contribute to production. Why should white-collared persons—and even ministers and the prime minister—not work for an hour daily?

11. Literally, gift of labour. The term is used for voluntary unpaid labour undertaken for some work for the benefit of the whole community.

It is said that Vinoba should better enlighten people rather than spending time in spinning. But it is not said that it would be better if Vinoba does not eat and sleep and spend the time so saved in enlightening the people! Intellectual labour is considered superior. Of course, some would put in such labour more and some would put in more physical labour. But all should undertake both kinds of labour in some measure. I have put in various kinds of physical labour for 4-6 hours daily for many years; not less than the time spent in study. And it is my experience that it has added lustre to my intellect, rather than dimming it.

Had God willed that some persons should do intellectual labour and some physical labour exclusively, He would have given some persons only heads and some persons only hands! Surely, this was not impossible for Him. But He has given intellect to everyone and also stomach with hunger in it. It is wrong to expect some people to engage in only physical labour for hours. They should also have opportunity to do some intellectual work. Is it possible that some only eat food and some only drink water? One needs both, food and water. Social order should be such as to facilitate full development of all. For this purpose, everyone should feel that labour and contemplation are equally dignified.

Question of incentive

Today, value of knowledge and service are judged in terms of money. This is utterly nonsensical. Why should one earn more, when everyone's stomach has the same size? Some difference in remuneration may be put up with, looking to the condition of society and differences in habits. But then one who receives more would be sorry and apologetic about it.

How can people be motivated to work? It is a problem before sociologists and economists. Currently,

monetary incentives are offered. But can a true writer write for money? Did Tulsidas write the Ramayana for an award? Monetary incentive for work is really dishonourable to the one to whom it is given. But today it is considered honourable. We have to change this mindset. That is what revolution in value system is about.

The exponents of the theory of incentives forget that if higher gains induce me to greater efforts, it may also tempt someone else to rob me. This theory is bound to create inequality and conflicts.

Remedy for conflicts

One of the main reasons for the present turmoil in the world is the attitude to shirk physical labour. Some people avoid physical labour. Those doing such labour do not have high regard for it; they also want to avoid it. They desire that at least their children should be freed from it. This is adversely affecting production, and on the other hand, needs are spiralling. What can the result be except turmoil and conflicts?

People want to live on the exploitation of others. This is horrendous. Wild animals prey on other animals. Should the human society emulate them? We must find a way to live without exploiting others. Our source of livelihood should not be antagonistic to others. The only way is to undertake productive labour for livelihood.

In fact, all the conflicts in the world have arisen because human beings have substituted money for labour and struggle for love. Money and struggle are at the root of problems, whatever form they may take—it may be Hindus versus Muslims, India versus Pakistan, brahmins versus non-brahmins, capitalists versus labourers. These different problems are but different forms assumed by the same demon. Productive labour is the only way to end all kinds of conflict.

When the educated start doing productive labour, that would result in the conscientization of labourers, their remuneration would increase and an egalitarian society would take shape. That would also change the manner of working and also the outlook of labourers.

My movement (Bhoodan-Gramdan) is basically a labour movement. It is for the uplift of labourers. Agricultural labourers are the lowest on the social ladder; they are voiceless and unorganised. I have taken up their cause. I consider myself a labourer. I have spent the best years in my life in manual work like spinning, sanitation, weaving, carpentry—the kinds of work which are considered inferior. Had Gandhiji been alive, I would not have come out of the Ashram and would have happily continued these activities.

I want to build the power of labourers. They have strength, but they are not aware of it. They should gain confidence. They should help each other. They should care for each other. They should learn to sacrifice for each other. They should purge themselves of their vices and discard meekness. Purity is the key to enhancement in strength. They should work honestly. Just as it is necessary to raise the moral level of the rich, as they have become selfish, it is also necessary to raise the moral level of the poor.

5. Power of Non-possession

Non-possession: Meaning and Implications

Non-stealing

The principle of non-stealing regulates the method of earning, and the principle of non-possession regulates the amount of earning. Non-stealing implies that physical needs should be fulfilled mainly through productive manual labour. When we consume something without putting in labour for it, that raises a risk. Many of the inequalities, sorrows and sins in the world have arisen because of the tendency to avoid physical labour. The person with such a tendency is, in reality, stealing, overtly or covertly. Non-stealing, therefore, demands that wealth be created through physical labour.

To consume food or use cloth etc. without participating in their production is also a kind of stealing. Non-stealing does not only mean not taking anything from anyone unless offered by him; taking something from someone without giving anything in return is also a kind of stealing. Stealing means consumption without sacrifice.

Violation of vows

If we decide to consume only that which has been produced through our physical labour, the principle of non-possession will automatically be followed to a large extent, as one cannot produce so much with physical labour that one could accumulate it. But although physical labour cannot produce too much, it can produce much, and if it is enjoyed without sharing with others, the risk is not fully averted. In childhood, we have received help from many individuals. To repay that debt, it is necessary to give a share of what we have earned through physical labour to the society. It appears like charity; but in reality,

it is the repayment of debt.

In nature, we do not find accumulation for the next day. That is what a human being should follow. If I accumulate things to provide for the next twenty-five days, it means that I have deprived twenty-four persons from their rightful needs. Secondly, such accumulation necessarily involves unfair means. Moreover, the effort of accumulation creates tension and saps my vitality. The worry about protecting the possessions takes hold of me; so my mind cannot remain open and relaxed. Thus, the single act of accumulation violates five vows: truth, nonviolence, non-stealing, non-possession and brahmacharya. One should, therefore, accumulate strictly what is required for subsistence, and refrain from accumulating what is not necessary for the purpose. With this approach, one should go on reducing one's needs and try to make life simpler day by day.

For truth and nonviolence

Lord Buddha, Mahavir and many other sages have prescribed non-stealing, non-possession and restraint besides nonviolence. Neither nonviolence nor social order can be sustained without these—that was their firm belief. As I think more and more about it, their far-sightedness strikes me. If we do not restrain ourselves, the world will face grave problems. Human beings will kill one another. Now people are killed in war, but tomorrow a doctor may prescribe fresh human flesh for nutrition, and people may start eating human flesh! Hankering after consumption can have no other effect. Restraint is, therefore, essential for nonviolence.

We follow the principle of non-stealing to a certain extent. We put thieves in jails. But we do nothing about that theft, which is not legally prohibited. Excessive salaries, excessive profit, interest, brokerage—what are these if not forms of theft? We should get rid of them too. Nonviolence is inconsistent with unbridled accumulation.

Non-possession should be coupled with truth and nonviolence and specific planning should be done for implementation of this principle. Non-possession is a fundamental concept, which needs to be practised. Truth and nonviolence can be established in the realm of economy only through non-stealing and non-possession. Purity of life depends on the purity of the means of livelihood.

Wealth belongs to the Lord

We have always looked upon wealth as a divine thing. The first *mantra* in Ishavasya Upanishad, which Gandhiji has extolled, teaches the same ideal: ईशावास्यमिदं सर्वं यत् किं च जगत्यां जगत्, तेन त्यक्तेन भुञ्जीथाः (All the life in the world is pervaded by the Lord. Therefore, enjoy whatever you get after sacrificing in His Name). Laxmi and Vishnu are our mother and father and we are their children: that has been the ideal before us.

The *mantra* in Ishavasya further says, मा गृधः कस्य स्विद्धनम्. It appears to mean that we should not covet others riches. But Shankaracharya has interpreted it in a wonderful way: स्वस्य परस्य वा—Do not covet your own riches and do not covet others' riches also. It is wrong to consider that particular wealth is yours and particular wealth is someone else's. All wealth belongs to the Lord, and all of it should be used for the service of society. Wealth belongs neither to me nor to anyone else.

Accumulation is sinful

In an Upanishad, a king says, न मे स्तेनो जनपदे न कदर्यः—there are neither thieves nor misers in my kingdom. Misers are responsible for thefts. The attitude to accumulate is sinful.

In Sanskrit, there is a saying, दानात् देवः रक्षणात् राक्षसः—those those who give are deities and those who keep what they have with themselves are demons. Attitude of giving is the essence of all the virtues, and attitude to accumulate is the

essence of all the vices. Accumulation breeds laziness and motivates one to rob others.

To have wealth is thus a great tragedy; accumulating wealth is like contracting a disease. In elephantiasis, legs get swollen. Such is the condition of the rich. I, therefore, feel pity for them and implore them to abandon greed.

To the extent we increase our possessions, our essence as a human being gets eroded correspondingly. When possessions increase, time is wasted in looking after them, and the intellect gets eroded. Possessions become our master; we become their slaves. Possessions are problematic whatever we do—whether we take care of them or neglect them.

Jesus has said that a camel may pass through the eye of a needle, but a rich man can never enter the kingdom of God. Riches have perhaps never been so unambiguously censured. It is generally accepted that stealing is bad. But the basic reason for theft is accumulation at some places. As long as the latter is not touched, thefts are not going to stop.

If we retain possessions, stealing in some form or the other is inevitable. You may not accept what is normally called stealing, but you will have to accept legal expropriation, which is also a kind of theft. That is why I exhort the people to accept non-possession and surrender individual ownership to the society. That will result in the manifestation of great spiritual power. There will be upsurge of compassion in society.

One-sided morality

Today, there is a strange practice in society. Ordinary thieves are looked down upon, while the bigger thieves—the accumulators—are honoured. George Washington had written a sentence in his diary, 'Fence is a temptation to jump'. Fence tempts people to jump over it. If we want to

get rid of thefts, society would have to be purified. For this purpose, land will have to be equitably distributed, and work will have to be provided to everyone. It is impossible to give work to all except through village industries. That is why I talk of land distribution and village industries together.

There is legal sanction for accumulation. It is not considered unethical. This will have to be changed. Society is unhappy because of the one-sided conventional ethics. We have accepted non-stealing and non-possession as religious duties, but so far we have understood only one aspect of this religion. But religion can never be one-sided. Miser is the father of the robber. Theft is, in fact, an external manifestation of the greed lying within ourselves. If I restrain my greed, it will not take the form of a thief. I do not understand this and erect an elaborate structure to deal with theft: police, courts and jails. But I do not think of anything for getting rid of my greed. As long as greed exists, theft will continue to exist in spite of police and jails. Jail is not the way to stop stealing. For that purpose, accumulated wealth should be evenly distributed.

Many people do not steal today, not because of the law against it; they do not, because they believe that stealing is morally wrong. When people come to believe that accumulation is also morally wrong, many of the present difficulties will be solved. Both the beliefs together will constitute a single complete thought. Then the health of society will improve. When non-possession becomes the foundation of society, need for coercive power of the State will be reduced to the minimum.

A question has been asked, "You ask the rich to renounce their wealth, but why don't you ask the poor not to covet riches of the wealthy? Isn't it proper for the poor to live on their own labour?"

The questioner says that the poor covet riches of the

wealthy. But are not all of us covetous? That is why we accumulate things. I will certainly ask the poor not to covet others' riches. But the rich also are possessive about their riches. How can they ask others not to be covetous? I tell the poor that they have the capacity to labour; they should dedicate that capacity to the society. I tell the rich that they have wealth; they should dedicate that wealth to the society.

If we ask the poor to rely on their labour and efforts, we should say the same to the rich. The rich use their intellect to exploit the labour of others, and still believe that they are earning through their own efforts. This is wrong.

Giving is beneficial

You gave us a heap of lemons today. If I eat all those, I would become ill and if I keep them, they would dry out and go to waste. Both these options are not desirable. So I distributed those lemons to the people. We should give the thing that we do not need to someone who needs it without delay. What I did about lemons, should be done about wealth also. When I impart knowledge to others, that does not lessen my knowledge; rather it becomes more deeply rooted. People accept that this is true about knowledge. But as regards wealth, they do not think so. They think that their wealth will be reduced if they share it with others. But this is wrong. We have to understand this.

If I deposit my money in a bank, do I lose it? The money in bank, in fact, grows. When I deposit some money in a bank, money in my home is reduced, but my money in the bank is also in my name. What do I lose then? Similarly, there is no loss in keeping money in society, which is also a kind of bank. It will be employed in the fields and industries. An ordinary bank may become bankrupt and I may lose my money deposited in

it. But the bank in the form of society can never become bankrupt. If I sacrifice all in service to others, I can get service from others when I need it. When I serve the society, I become entitled to get service from the society. When I share wealth with others, my wealth is not reduced; rather, my worries get reduced.

Society should have everything. But an individual should take only that much, which he needs for the current day. He should not worry about the future. One who cares for the society in one's youth is looked after by the society in one's old age. Intellect of the one who steers clear of accumulation gets sharpened in old age. Such old men are not considered burdensome, they are not shabbily treated; rather, they are respected. People feel obliged to them. What is the use of money earned at the expense of love? Does it lead to happiness? Both the rich and the poor are unhappy; albeit for different things. I tell the rich, "You accumulated wealth in your home and banished love thereby; you set fire to your house. How can happiness be there? Love and money do not stay together."

Expropriation vis-à-vis dissolution

There is an ideology, which is opposed to my ideas. It is called the ideology of expropriation. It believes that expropriation of individual for the sake of society is justified, there is nothing wrong in it; in fact, not to expropriate the rich is morally wrong. My idea of non-possession is opposed to this ideology. Through the principle of non-possession, I seek to save the society from expropriation. Expropriation can be done in many ways. Tax is a covert form of expropriation, while robbery is an overt form. Any kind of expropriation is wrong. It neither purifies the hearts of individuals nor makes the society healthy. Non-possession should, therefore, take the place of expropriation. Of course, non-possession is not to be taken superficially. It is a view of life.

What do the rich have that we should want? They have a few wads of paper and a few pieces of stone with different colours. Mahmud of Gazni invaded India seventeen times and looted so-called precious stones. He piled them up in the rooms of his palace. At the time of death, the thought of leaving all those behind made him weep. At the time of death, no one can take anything with him.

The ideal in Indian tradition

The whole social structure in India is erected on the foundation of non-possession. The idea may not have been implemented in the way it should have been, but the sages have always put emphasis on non-possession in individual and social life.

Look at our ashram system¹². In three out of four ashrams (*brahmacharya*, *vanaprastha* and *sannyasa*), possessions are completely ruled out. Only in *grihasthashram*, contact with money is involved. But *grihasthashram* is not the ultimate ideal; it is a phase in life, from which one is supposed to advance to *vanaprastha*, and finally to *sannyasa*. We may keep aside the concept of *sannyasa*, which is too lofty an ideal for ordinary individuals. But every *grihastha*—householder—should have his eyes on *vanaprastha*.

Look at the varna system. For the brahmin, voluntary poverty has been prescribed. Why we deviated from that

12. Indian tradition prescribes four stages of life: *Brahmacharya* (roughly, first 25 years of life when one is supposed to remain celibate and concentrate on studies), *Garhasthya* (next 25 years of life when one is supposed to carry out the duties of a householder), *Vanaprastha* (next 25 years of life when one is supposed to retire from the family responsibilities and become a hermit) and *Sannyasa* (when one should renounce all and become a wandering ascetic). Vinoba wanted the *vanaprasthis* to advise and guide others.

ideal is a matter I would not go into here. The point is that a brahmin was venerated because of the regard for the ideal of non-possession.

Shudras, like brahmins, were also not supposed to own anything. Thus, at both ends of the spectrum of varna system, non-possession was prescribed. Kshatriyas had power and vaishyas had wealth. But they, too, were supposed not to possess anything in three-fourth period of their lives.

The ideal is for all

People say that non-possession is too high an ideal; it is not for ordinary individuals. When pitted against the greedy, many would approve of accumulation. Many would feel that a certain amount of possessions is necessary, if we have to survive in the world. This has led to the present state of affairs.

So, possessions are now ruling the roost everywhere. Laws have been framed in their favour. They are considered a key to success.

But, the principle of non-possession is not only for *sannyasis* (renunciates) only; it is applicable to ordinary citizens also. We should surrender all that we have to the society, and take only what we need. If we surrender everything to the society, what we receive from the society will prove to be a life-giving elixir for us.

By establishing such non-possession in the society, I want to make it wealthy and glorious. I aim at establishing a grand social order on the foundation of non-possession.

I want to make non-possession the foundation of society. We have to convince people about the potency in non-possession. So far, people have considered it a virtue; but it is to be demonstrated that it has potency too. People are not as yet aware of it. They have realized that

non-possession frees you from worries, therefore spiritual aspirants are supposed to be free from possessions, so as to be free for meditation. It is accepted that if the house is crammed with things, one's whole time will be spent in cleaning it and there will be no time left for meditation. Thus, we expected non-possession to give us freedom from worries and nothing else. But I want to demonstrate the power in non-possession.

Our bodies provide an example of such power. Blood is distributed throughout the body. If it accumulates at a single place, it will give rise to diseases. Accumulation weakens; it does not add to strength.

Grandeur of a non-possessing society

I do not want to make people ascetics. In fact, I want everyone to be wealthy, but I certainly hold that wealth should be evenly distributed. People are presently hankering after accumulation. But what is the result? It is doubtful whether the society has grains enough for a year. But in the non-possessing society of my conception, there will be stock of grains sufficient for two years. In that society, every home will have grains in sufficient quantities. A hungry man will be able to go to any house and will be entitled to be fed there. A thirsty man asks for water from any house, and he is given water without demanding money. Similarly, a hungry man will be given food in every house. There will be sufficient grains in every home to make this possible. Such is the non-possessing society of my conception.

What I am saying is not something new. Upanishads have enjoined us to grow food in large quantities: अन्नं बहु कुर्वीत, तद् व्रतम् (Take a vow to grow food as much as possible). Then food will be in such abundance that no one will measure its value in terms of money. You will say, 'Where is non-possession in this?' Non-possession, in fact, means vast possessions; but they will be distributed,

not concentrated.

In my scheme, not a pie will remain idle. What is the use of gold if it is in the form of ornaments, and is not used for production?

If I read a book and it then lies in my almirah for ten years, what will the world gain by it? After reading, I should pass it on to someone; and after his reading, he should pass it on to someone else. This way, the book will pass through many hands and will get ultimately torn, but it will have served its purpose. Wealth should be used in the same way. This will increase production immensely, besides resulting in the distribution of wealth. Moreover, this process will bring about equality and equanimity and love and remove antagonism and hatred.

Non-possession also implies that useless things will never be accumulated. Liquor bottles and cigarette packets do not constitute wealth.

Proper sequence

Another thing in our scheme of non-possession is that accumulation will be done in a proper sequence. Today, little attention is paid to this factor. The proper sequence will be as follows:

1. Nutritious food.
2. Necessary clothes.
3. Good houses.
4. Implements necessary for work.
5. Means of knowledge, i.e. books etc.
6. Means of entertainment i.e. music etc.

Things should be accumulated in this order.

A gentleman once remarked that people are found in good clothes in meetings, which means that they are not poor. But the fact is that they are poor, and also stupid.

They dress nicely even if they do not have adequate food to eat. People should be aware of the proper order for accumulation. Non-possession can, therefore, be defined as accumulation done in a particular sequence.

Characteristics of a non-possessing society

In a non-possessing society, money will be as less as possible. Money and wealth are two different things. Food grains and fruits are the real wealth. Money can be printed in a mint, but wealth has to be produced through labour. As a saying goes, उद्योगिनं पुरुषसिंहमुपैति लक्ष्मीः—one who exerts oneself gets wealth. Laxmi resides in our fingers. God has given us ten fingers to work. If we work with them, we will get wealth. In a non-possessing society, therefore, money will be as less as possible.

Theft becomes easier because of money. It is not then necessary to commit it in the night. Money has caused widespread delusion. A wealthy individual is considered poor and a poor individual is considered wealthy.

Thus, a non-possessing society will be characterized by five features:

1. In such a society, real wealth will be in abundance.
2. That wealth will be evenly distributed.
3. There will be no accumulation of worthless things.
4. Accumulation will be done in a proper sequence.
5. Money will be as less as possible.

Simple living

Restraint is extremely necessary in social life. Restraint implies fixation of the level of consumption. If consumption is not kept within bounds, conflict with others is inevitable. Everyone should come to believe firmly that he is not entitled to any consumption to which all do not have access. It has been said in (the Tamil epic) Kural that when we cannot restrain consumption, we start committing theft.

If we observe our own lives, we would find how we are participating in a number of thefts. Consumption should, therefore, be gradually reduced. We should gradually get rid of unnecessary possessions. Our consumption should be on a par with others; it is better if it is less than others, but it should never be more than others.

Simple living means to have the standard of our living in accordance with the general standard of living in the society. An individual lives in accordance with the condition of his family. It does not happen that one member of a family is deprived of his/her needs while another member wallows in luxury. Society is also a family. Our standard of living should be in accordance with the standard prevalent in the society. This is what I mean by simple living. I do not mean that people should live on the level they were on in the past. What have become necessities in the present era should be fulfilled, but the condition in the country must not be overlooked.

Today, people talk of increasing the standard of living. That is what economics dictates. It means that life should become more comfortable. People are not getting adequate food; they should get it. They are not getting sufficient milk; they should get it. They are not getting adequate clothing, they should have it. That is all okay. The point is, which things should be made available more? Which things should be consumed more? Fruits or cigarettes? We will have to decide in this regard.

Secondly, to which extent even a good thing should be accumulated is also a matter of deep reflection. Milk is good; but if we consume it more than necessary, it proves to be harmful. So, one should shun bad things and possess and consume good things within limits. Air, water, sunlight and sky are the most important things, which should be consumed in abundance.

Thus, we should get some necessary things, which we

are not getting presently. At the same time, consumption of certain things, which we are consuming more than what is necessary, should be reduced.

In India, where even basic necessities of life are not available to all, it is certainly necessary to increase the standard of living. But we must remember two things: (i) It is wrong to think that my own pleasure should increase first. Increase in my pleasure should be in proportion to the increase in the pleasure of society as a whole. It may lag behind the latter, but never exceed it. (ii) Pleasure does not depend on possessions.

We should be more concerned with increasing the standard of reflection rather than the standard of living. One can reflect deeper only when one's life is simple. When material comforts increase excessively, standard of reflection falls down.

I do not want India to copy other nations in material aggrandizement. In U.S.A., there is abundant wealth. But are the people there happy? Are they contented? They have more suicides. Every moment is taken up by the struggle for survival. Wealth needs to be increased up to a certain point, as poverty acts as a deterrent in the way of spirituality. And one cannot also delve deep into one's Self, when one is wallowing in abundance. There should be balance. There should be simplicity in life. But simplicity is not synonymous with poverty.

Let the Stream of *Dana* Flow

Practical wisdom

Kabir had said that he was not preaching asceticism; he was educating the people about worldly affairs. He said, पानी बाढ़ो नांव में, घर में बाढ़ो दाम; दोनों हाथ उलीचिये, यही सयानो काम. (If water in a boat and money in a home increase, to throw them away with both the hands is a sign of wisdom.) A boat will capsize if water accumulates in it.

Likewise, there is risk in the accumulation of wealth in individual homes. A boat needs water to sail along; but water should be below the boat, not within it. Likewise, wealth is needed, but it should be in the society, not in individual homes. If wealth accumulates in individual homes, there is the same risk of capsizing. Therefore, that wealth should be thrown out with both the hands, like the water accumulating in a boat. Kabir says, this is how you should behave in the world.

In the game of football, I kick the ball towards another player, the moment it comes to me. If I keep the ball with me, the game will be immediately over. The game goes on only if I kick the ball towards others, and every player does the same. The same treatment should be given to wealth. The moment it comes to me, I should direct it towards another person, and he should direct it to the third one. Only then the game of life will go on. This is not asceticism; this is practical wisdom. When you give with two hands, you receive from innumerable hands, as you have only two hands, but society has innumerable hands. If you do not give with your two hands, you will not receive anything.

Dhan* should become *dravya

Non-possession means directing the wealth towards another, the moment it comes to us. *Dhan* should become *dravya*—solidified wealth should become liquid; it should begin to flow. Flowing water remains pure. A river continues to flow; water in it moves ahead, but its place is taken by incoming water. We should likewise keep giving, and what we give will be continuously replenished. When wealth continues to flow, it serves its purpose. Once we understand these two words, *dhan* and *dravya*, we understand the essence of economics. *Dhan* should become *dravya* as soon as possible. Only then will it be of service to society, otherwise it will spell doom.

Just as blood should flow uninterruptedly in the body—if it does not, a surgical operation will be necessitated—*dhan* should flow in the society continuously.

Definition of *dana*¹³

Some people object to the word '*dana*' in 'Bhoo-dan'. Those who grasp the essence of the words do not abandon current words; they impart new meanings to them. If we abandon such words, we will lose our weapons, and coining equally good new words is not easy. We should, therefore, infuse new appeal in old words, while keeping intact their present strength.

We find this skill in the commentators in the past. They have augmented the potency of old words. Shankaracharya has defined '*dana*' as दानं संविभागः—*dana* means proper distribution. Shankaracharya was no economist, but his definition of *dana*, made 1300 years ago, will be acceptable to any of the present economists. Proper distribution means equal distribution.

Shankaracharya has defined *dana* on the basis of the wisdom received from the ancestors. *Dana* has been considered a moral duty in India. So, there is really no question of infusing any new meaning in the word *dana*. But we lack intellect and education. We have not adequately studied our culture. Hence we find the word '*dana*' derogatory.

Etymologically, the word '*dana*' is derived from the root '*da*', which has two meanings: one is to give, and the

13. Normally translated as 'charity'. The word smacks of obliging somebody, doing him a favour by giving something. When Vinoba sought land-gifts for the poor, using this word (*bhoo-dana*, that is *dana* of land), an objection was raised that he was making the poor objects of pity. Vinoba had to explain repeatedly the correct meaning of *dana* in this context.

other is to cut. Taking both the meanings together, '*dana*' means cutting something from us and giving it to others.

'*Dana*' does not imply obliging anyone. We owe a lot to others. We have to repay their debt. Society has done so much for us—it has fed us, given us knowledge, produced many things for our use. So there is no question of our obliging anyone; in fact, we are—and should feel—obliged to the society. *Dana* should be done in this spirit. We are entitled to consume anything only when we have shared it with the society.

Necessity of *dana*

The world, however, has taken another route. Everyone is hankering after accumulation irrespective of the means. But now time to give has come. The world is afflicted with conflicts only because we want to take, not to give. But consumption without sacrifice results in a disease. Not only individuals, but society at large is afflicted by that disease. To go on giving is the only antidote to consumption. Sharing makes consumption a source of well-being to all, instead of being harmful.

Nature is teaching us to give. Our mothers taught us the same in our childhood. The process of giving is in tune with the nature, although people think that this is against the current. In fact, that which is going on presently is unnatural.

Some accumulation is inevitable in the course of day-to-day life. Sharing it with society is the only thing which can neutralize the sin so committed. *Dana* becomes a sacred duty when you come to possess and enjoy something. It is not a one-time duty, but a regular one.

Some people ask, 'You ask for one-sixth of land. Is that all? Would it suffice?' This is not a right approach. If we eat once, it is not that we do not have to eat again. We have eaten yesterday, we will eat today, and

tomorrow also we will like to eat. As long as the body is there, we will go on providing food to it.

We eat daily, we bathe daily, we sleep daily. *Dana* is also a thing to be done daily. Daily *dana* is as much joyful as daily eating or daily bathing. We bathe daily to remove dirt from the body. We have to give to remove the dirt that accumulates inevitably when we consume. If we have no need to consume, then only can we be absolved of the duty to give; not otherwise.

All should give

I want that the spirit of giving strikes roots in society. When something is looked upon as a regular duty, that does away with any sense of obliging others. It is regular *dana*, which can bring about equal distribution.

Regular giving can keep equilibrium in the society. This idea of regular *dana* has been there in Indian sociology; it has not yet been accepted by Western sociology. What they give is called charity. But it is given either for a religious purpose—to the church etc.—or for the service of the sick and the miserable. These two kinds of *dana* are there in every religion. But our *bhoo dan* and *sampattidan* are for social change. Their main purpose is to keep equilibrium in the society, bring equality in society and establish *samyayoga*.

People have all along been giving donations. *Bhoo dan-yajna* is of a different kind. It calls upon all to give. Individual donation is a different thing, and the collective donations that are being sought are a different matter.

The present age demands that all should produce wealth collectively and enjoy the fruits of their labour collectively. All together have now to pursue the higher goals in life. When production and enjoyment, both are collective, that gives a special kind of joy. No one has

then the vanity of having made a sacrifice. When I am breathing for twenty-fours a day, and so is everyone else, where is the question of my being proud about breathing? The greatest risk accompanying a good deed is that it makes the doer conceited, and it is very difficult to get rid of that conceit.

Social significance of *dana*

Suppose, you have a piece of sweet in your hand. If your hand becomes selfish and keeps on holding the sweet instead of putting it in your mouth, will you enjoy it? But the hand is not selfish, it does not keep the sweet to itself, but passes it on instantly to the mouth. If the mouth keeps it selfishly, enjoyment of sweet will be incomplete. But the mouth chews the sweet and passes it on to the stomach. If the stomach keeps the sweet with it, surgical operation will become necessary. But the stomach does not act selfishly; it converts the piece of sweet into blood and sends the blood to the whole body. Thus no organ in the body is selfish; every organ looks after the interest of the whole body. If any organ becomes selfish, the process of eating will not happen at all. This is how everyone should behave in the society. If wealth gets accumulated at someone's place, it makes him lazy and arouses envy in others, resulting in thefts. One should, therefore, enjoy only a part of one's wealth and pass on the rest to the society, so that it could be fruitfully utilized. This is the social significance of *dana*.

My hand does not work for its own benefit. It works for the whole body; and feels having served its purpose in doing so. If a thorn pricks the foot, the hand immediately volunteers to pluck it out. It does not think that it has a higher status than the foot. It realises that it can have no existence apart from the body. Similarly, whatever I have is because of my association with society.

If water is poured on a hilltop, it flows downhill.

Water everywhere flows towards the lower level. Every river flows towards a sea. The miserable in the world are like a sea. All others in the society, on whatever level they may be, should rush to the miserable. Only then can the world be saved. Self-centred thinking will destroy us all. Hence, the stream of *dana* should go on flowing continuously.

Greed is not natural

The spirit of giving is not against human psyche. Greed is not a natural, innate tendency like hunger. Why would anyone accumulate if he is assured of the fulfilment of his daily needs? If you have a substantial amount of money, you keep it in a bank. The bank gives it for other uses, but its return when you need it is guaranteed. If society offers such guarantee, there would be no need for accumulation. Warped social structure puts considerable responsibility on people, which makes them accumulate money. Suppose, society arranges for the medical treatment of all. Would the people then make provision for it? In fact, it is human nature to love and share with others. Greed and accumulation have their roots in the social structure.

When I ask the people to donate or sacrifice, people listen to it attentively and are pleased. They find it difficult to practise, yet they come to hear me in large numbers. Had I told them to revel in the enjoyments of the flesh, they would have hooted me off. *Dana* and sacrifice do appear difficult, yet people have faith in them. This shows how human nature is.

***Dana* and sacrifice**

A good thing is meant to be given, not the rubbish. The latter needs to be thrown away. Both *dana* and sacrifice have their place. *Dana* is like payment of interest; sacrifice is like repayment of principal. *Dana* is like cutting the branches; sacrifice is like cutting the roots.

Equation of water is H_2+O ; likewise, I have proposed an equation for life: S_2+E . S stands for sacrifice and E for enjoyment. Life should have sacrifice in double the measure of enjoyment.

Sampattidan-yajna

The origin

The idea of bhoodan struck me on 18 April 1951. The idea of introducing sampattidan (gift of wealth) also had been on my mind. But land problem was a fundamental problem which, if not solved, could pose a danger to the country. So, I thought it better to concentrate on the land problem first. Moreover, it was easy for the people to comprehend that land was a gift from God. Land is a basic means of production. So, it was better to concentrate on the land problem in the beginning. Advancing gradually towards the goal is in keeping with nonviolence.

But when bhoodan work advanced, it became dear that complementing bhoodan with sampattidan (gift of wealth) was necessary. The idea is that wealth does not really belong to us, even though we may have earned it through our enterprise; it has been entrusted to us by God for using for the benefit of all. After all, our enterprise and our capacity of exerting ourselves are also gifts of God.

The scheme

I had said repeatedly during my walking tour that I did not want money. But now I am asking for a portion of wealth also. How can this be reconciled with my earlier stand? The answer is that I am not going to collect money, nor I am undertaking the responsibility of looking after it, spending it and keeping the accounts. Money will remain with the donor. I will take only a letter of undertaking from the donor that he would give a portion

of his wealth every year to the society. The donor will spend the money donated by him mainly according to his conscience. This is my strange way. If I were to collect a fund, I will be required to keep the accounts, and that will take all my time. But I want to bring about a revolution. I desire that everyone in India should give one-sixth of his wealth. How can I keep accounts on such a massive scale? The donor will, therefore, be accountable for his donation. I do not intend to follow the current practice of collecting a fund and administering it through public societies. This is the difference between a fund and the sampattidan scheme.

Sampattidan is as profound as Bhoodan-yajna. Not everyone possesses land, but everyone does possess some wealth. In wealth I include intellect, money and talents also. That is why I ask for donation of bullocks, seeds, wells etc. also and do get the same at times. But I thought that it was insufficient; everyone should give something; everyone should get an opportunity to offer something.

I tell the donors that I do not want their money only; I want their talent and intellect too. By offering sampattidan, you will be bound by your promise. If I collect a fund, I get bound; but I want to bind you and remain free. I may give you suggestions or ask you to spend the promised money in any sacred work according to your light, and give me particulars thereof at the end of the year.

If there is difficulty in computing income, I will be happy if one-sixth portion of the total expenditure is given in sampattidan. Whatever amount may be in one's bank account, if one is withdrawing for household expenditure, say fifty thousand rupees in a year, let one-sixth of that amount be given.

There will be a bank in every house, and only

accounting will be done at a central place. It will be noted there what part of one's donation is still lying with him. People ask, "You will take a portion of the food grains also; will you not keep it somewhere?" My reply is, "No. We will have only papers, wherein it will be noted that a certain person has ten kgs of the donated grains in his house and certain another person has twenty kgs. When the village committee will need ten kgs, it will inquire who could give it, and someone will volunteer to give. It will be noted that we have ten kgs less in that person's house. Thus, we will not have to worry about the protection of grains. If rats eat grains in a house, they will eat the grains belonging to the resident of the house, not the donated grains, which belong to us!

On a land-gift declaration, the donor signs, two witnesses attest to it, and I too sign on it as a mark of acceptance. Thereupon the government accepts that declaration and makes changes in records (of land rights) accordingly. Such formal procedure is not there in sampattidan. Sampattidan does not involve donating once only, like bhoodan. One has to give every year. That needs an inner conviction

I am putting entire responsibility on the donor and trusting him. Sceptics may object to it. But moral judgements depend on trust. Trust is more effective than any legal measure.

Those desirous of participating in sampattidan-yajna should first consult their family members and pledge themselves only if all of them give their consent.

Upanishad says, तेन त्यक्तेन भुञ्जीथाः (Enjoy anything only after sacrifice). Tulsidas said the same thing: सब संपत्ति रघुपति कै आही (All wealth belongs to God). Therefore, giving one-sixth portion of the wealth is secondary. In fact, we should give all that we have to the society and take back only the

little that is needed for sustenance of the body. But this cannot come about in a short span. Therefore, a beginning may be made with donation of one-sixth portion; and it should be followed by regular giving irrespective of any consideration of what others are giving.

Necessity and consequences

We are getting gifts of thousands of acres in bhoodan. To make land on such a scale productive, money is needed. Thus, sampattidan has become necessary for the success of bhoodan. Besides, wealth is produced through cooperation of all and should, therefore, be owned by the society—or in other words, God. Without sampattidan, bhoodan will not attain success, nor will our programme of economic equality and economic freedom succeed.

Once the flow of *dana* starts, the climate in the country will change in no time.

So far, we collected money for our institutions. Now sampattidan will teach us how to establish institutions on the foundation of non-possession. When sampattidan spreads, people will realize the inherent potency in non-possession.

The scheme will have purifying effect on the climate in the country. Every child will learn about sharing. It is in childhood that deep impressions are etched on the mind.

A person who joins sampattidan will not earn through undesirable means; it is not possible that he would earn through unfair means and donate from such earning. He is bound to realize that he should earn through fair means alone. No such thought can occur while donating to a fund. Sampattidan thus opens a way for the purification of hearts.

Sampattidan is a yajna

Let it be clearly understood that there is no idea of

collecting a fund through sampattidan. Had it been there, I would not have used the term 'yajna'. The word 'yajna' has been used purposely. Everyone is supposed to make an offering in this yajna. A righteous action is supposed to be done by all; it is the duty of everyone.

Some people apprehend that I will be taken for a ride. I hold that one should not distrust anyone. If one distrusts, one is not worthy of being a part of society. Nothing is being forced legally. The scheme is to be implemented through love. Why should then I distrust the donors? Muslims offer namaz five times a day. Does anyone stand guard over them to ensure that they do so? People carry out religious duties of their own accord. Sampattidan is in the same category.

Sampattidan given by labourers will not amount to millions of rupees. It will be meagre. But that is like the seed of a banyan tree. It has immense potentialities. Armed with their sampattidan, I will approach the rich, who will have to give then—if not with love, then from a sense of honour.

Even children can join and give token sampattidan, say in the form of a self-spun hank of yarn.

Life-long obligation

Many find difficult the idea of giving one-sixth portion throughout the life. But do they not bind themselves for the whole life by marrying? Giving is not something to be avoided. Binding of a life-giving and beneficial thing is not something to be avoided. Such binding agreeable; one does not want to be freed from it.

This is a life-long obligation. If one decides to donate a particular sum every year, this may not be possible for him, in case his financial position deteriorates. But one can easily give a fixed portion of the earning.

Different from a fund

Sampattidan differs markedly from fund-collection. It differs from charity and also from humanitarian service—though such service does take place in its course. It seeks to convert the whole society into a family.

Those who collect a fund keep money in their hands. We do not do so. Fund-collectors approach the rich first. We approach all. Fund-collection does not take the form of a mass movement. Sampattidan is a mass movement. In a fund, particular sum is taken. In sampattidan, a fixed portion of income or expenditure is promised. One contributes to a fund and there ends the matter for the donor, while the collector is bound by attendant responsibilities. In sampattidan, the donor binds himself; we do not bind ourselves and, therefore, remain free from worries. Responsibility of spending the fund lies with the collector; in sampattidan, it lies with the donor. He is supposed to take guidance from our committee. A donor asks the fund-collector about its expenditure. In sampattidan, we ask the donors how they have spent the promised amount. People are little aware of how a fund is utilized; but in sampattidan it will be fully known to the people, as it is spent locally and openly. Donors to a fund are supposed to oblige society. In sampattidan, the donor feels that he has been obliged, as he has got an opportunity to utilize a portion of his wealth in the service to society. The idea of sampattidan thus drastically differs from a conventional fund. I have aversion for funds. Sampattidan is different.

The idea behind sampattidan is that what we earn is not because of our efforts alone; it is because of co-operation from the society. It is, therefore, our duty to help those who have helped us in earning what we have. Our wealth should, therefore, be spent primarily for the service of society.

Normally, a family has five members. Society should be considered the representative of *Daridra-narayan* (God in the form of the poor) and given the portion due to it. One-sixth of our total expenditure should go to serve the poor.

Employment of sampattidan

The promised amount will be spent by the donor himself. We will advise him, taking into account his wishes and inclinations. I will not impose my will on the donors. But I will like the money to be spent for the poor or for the servants of the poor. The latter make sacrifices, but they do need something for the sustenance of body. I, therefore, want the money to be utilized either for helping the poor directly, by giving them bullocks or ploughs, through digging wells for them, or by providing education to their children. And the servants of the poor should also be given something, so that they can continue their work free from worries. Sampattidan may also be utilized for reducing prices of sarvodaya literature. Donors, particularly the poor, may purchase products of cottage and village industries, which is a form of secret donation.¹⁴

Why should sampattidan be used for the sustenance of workers? For, if workers are not there, the work will come to an end. But this does not mean that sampattidan is just a scheme to provide for workers. We want one-sixth portion from every household, and there will not normally be more than one worker in every village. So, only a small portion of sampattidan will be utilized for workers. The rest will be spent for the poor in the village.

A gentleman, who has pledged sampattidan, has written to me, "I have Rs. 2500 belonging to you. You

14. As the prices of these products are more than mill-made goods, the purchaser has to give extra money. Vinoba suggests that this extra amount be considered as a donation.

have said that the donor could spend one-third of the amount in the way he likes. So, I will spend Rs. 800 as I want, and submit the details to you. I have kept Rs. 1200 for one worker. I have also chosen the worker. If you give consent, I will give Rs. 100 p.m. to him. I have kept Rs. 400 for giving help to the poor, and set aside Rs. 100 for propagation of sarvodaya literature. I will spend that amount for distributing literature free of cost to the interested students." Thus, he has not left anything to me; he has chalked out a plan and chosen a worker also. All I have to do is to give my approval. The fellow has thus not only given a share in his money, but has also given a share in his intellect. This is exactly what I want.

Some people fear that provision for workers through sampattidan would create inferiority complex in the workers. But there is no such risk. The donor would feel humbly that he himself could not participate in the work actively and is, therefore, donating to make up for it. There are people who feel this way. This adds to the stature of both, the donor and the recipient.

The provision that the donor has to spend the donated amount as per our advice is a safeguard in the scheme. But when millions will be donated, it will be impossible to give advice. Promised amounts will be utilized without our intervention. Eventually a situation will come when any needy person will ask for the thing he needs from anyone, and his need will be fulfilled. For, the giver's needs, when they arise, are going to be fulfilled. Wealth will be distributed in different homes only for the sake of convenience. We want to bring about such a state of affairs.

A bridge

Religion is a kind of bridge between two points: the point where we are at present and the point where we want to go; that is, between the life of sensual enjoyments

and spiritual liberation. The idea which seeks to take the society from the present condition to the ideal condition is a kind of religious thought. Sampattidan falls in this category. It is a relative, and not an absolute thought. In an ideal condition, there will be no wealth; therefore, there will be no question of giving it.

I ask for one-sixth portion; does it mean that I accept ownership of the donor on the remaining five-sixth portion? That is absolutely out of question. The fellow is under the impression that the whole wealth is his own. I strike at this assumption by demanding one-sixth portion. I set him thinking. It has been said that once a person takes the Name of the Lord, he sets out on the path of spiritual liberation. When a person undertakes to give one-sixth of what he has to the society as a matter of sacred duty on a regular basis, he sets out on the path of total sacrifice, total surrender to the society. This is what sampattidan-yajna envisages.

The ultimate objective

Do not get confused by the work 'sampatti' (wealth) in sampattidan. There is absolutely no question of giving respectability to money. In fact, I feel that to break the institution of property is the *raison d'être* of my life. And that is what the present age demands. Therefore, even those whose expropriation is being talked about will run after you to give sampattidan. But this will happen only when thousands of ordinary persons have given sampattidan. Then the rich will not be able to remain untouched by it. This is a nonviolent process.

I am asking for a portion of wealth for the sake of equality. I want to remove attachment in the people's minds so that they could accept and follow the principle of non-possession. Therefore, we do not have to approach the rich only. Everyone is in the grip of attachment. Everyone has to be approached to explain our thought

and obtain declarations of gift. The number of letters pledging sampattidan signify agreement with our thought.

The main object behind sampattidan is voluntary dissolution of private property. Sampattidan is just the beginning. It gives us access to the homes of the donors; and will eventually give access to their hearts and lives. Sampattidan is an undertaking about relinquishing property, a resolve to become a trustee of Gandhiji's conception. What we seek is not charity, but atonement of the sin of accumulation.

Shramadan: true sampattidan

In one village, the villagers have given in sampattidan the production obtained through labour for twelve days in a year. It appears a minor event. But I feel this is a subject worthy of writing poetry! Shramadan (gift of labour) is a very pure form of sampattidan, as money that is received may have a portion earned through unfair means. Labour is true wealth. It is labour that gets converted into wealth. So, gift of labour is the true sampattidan. I will, therefore, ask the people to produce their basic necessities, and gift a portion of it for the service of society.

Dissolution of Private Property

In sampattidan, I ask for one-sixth portion as a matter of right. This is a wedge. It is not a problem to receive one-sixth portion. What we are really concerned about is the remaining five-sixth portion. Even today, people do give donations. They will not find it difficult to give one-sixth portion. Through that, we will gain access to their enterprises and will eventually transform them.

Need for trusteeship

Trusteeship does not only mean that the wealth owned by us should be held as a trust on behalf of the society. It covers many aspects like the way the enterprise

should run, partnership between the owners and the labourers, rightful share of the latter, relations of the enterprise with the people in the neighbourhood, the level of reasonable profit etc.

In the society, the intelligent and the skilled persons will have to bear to some extent the responsibility of protecting the unintelligent and the unskilled, whatever may be the condition of the society. Some people do presently need the guidance of others. Howsoever we may transform the social structure, parents will continue to be the trustees of their offspring. All this is covered under trusteeship. As people become competent, need for trusteeship will be reduced.

As many enterprises are centralised today, the idea of trusteeship comes up as the first step towards establishment of the principle of non-possession. One may ask whether trusteeship would be unnecessary in a decentralised self-sufficient order. It will be necessary therein too, but its form will be different. Trusteeship will be necessary forever as levels of intelligence, physical strength, worthiness and experience differ from person to person, from society to society and nation to nation. And it will not be a one-way affair. Persons, societies and nations will be trustees of each other. Thus, ultimately trusteeship will cease to be a system and will remain only in the form of the quality of trust.

Gandhiji and trusteeship

‘Trusteeship’ is a strange word. It has become so sterile that it is impossible to infuse new meanings in it. Yet, we should accept old words, which reflect good intentions. This is what nonviolence demands. Gandhiji has, therefore, used the word in a positive sense.

Gandhiji used to say that we should become trustees of our wealth. He belonged to the legal fraternity and

therefore had attraction for the word ‘trustee’. I do not have such attraction for the word. Moreover, the word has been much misused, and therefore I avoid using it.

Gandhiji’s basic idea was that the whole creation belongs to God; it is the abode of God. He often used to refer to the first *mantra* of Ishavasya Upanishad, ईशावास्यमिदं सर्वं यत् किं च जगत्यां जगत् (Whatever exists in the world is pervaded by God), which expresses this idea. He pinned hope on the rich in India, expecting them to use their riches as trustees. Once he had seriously discussed the matter with a few close colleagues, and a draft outline of the scheme of trusteeship had been prepared on that basis. Pyarelalji has told the whole story in his book ‘The Last Phase’. This draft was given to Ghanashyamdas Birla for consideration. Birla promised to discuss the matter with other businessmen. But, as Pyarelalji notes, nothing came out of it. Yet I feel that as the age of science is advancing, humankind’s capacity is also increasing.

Some people are completely misinterpreting Gandhiji’s concept of trusteeship. Some Gandhians aver that Gandhiji was not against ownership and he stood for trusteeship, but Vinoba is going against Gandhiji, and they object to my stand (about the dissolution of private property).

The heart of trusteeship

But what does trusteeship mean? The first principle of trusteeship is that a trustee should look upon himself as the guardian of society. A father should look after and care for his child more than himself. That is what a trustee is expected to do. But this is not the be-all and end-all of trusteeship. Its second principle is that the trustee should behave like a father, who wants his son to become independent and competent as early as possible and looks forward to entrusting the reins of his business to the son as soon as possible. That is exactly what I am preaching. There is no question of an owner continuing as an owner and a

labourer continuing as a labourer. In fact, the difference between them should be wiped out. Gandhiji's conception is thus profound and far-reaching.

A father who bequeaths property to his son is, in fact, the son's enemy. He should educate his son properly and ask the latter to earn livelihood through the service of society.

'Trusteeship' is an English word. I do not fully know its import. I prefer Sanskrit words. Sanskrit word for trust is '*vishwas*', which is formed from '*shwas*' (breathing). People should have trust for industrialists and businessmen. '*Vishwas*' is as much important for society as '*shwas*' (breathing) is for the individual. An individual will die without breathing; society will likewise die if there is lack of trust between its members. When there is mutual trust among different sections of society, that trust becomes its protective shield. That is why I desire that there should be trust between the people and the businessman, and the power of businessmen (*mahajan-shakti*) should be built up.

Trusteeship in practice

No estate should be looked upon as privately owned, and there should be some rules about its administration. If the trustee fails in following these rules, people should have authority to annul his trusteeship. If the trustees do not use their property for the benefit of community, they should be removed from their position as trustees. I believe that all this is implied in the concept of trusteeship. But there should not be a place for violence in this process.

When people consider themselves owners of their properties, clash of interests becomes inevitable. But the concept of trusteeship brings about radical transformation in thoughts. The very idea of ownership is wrong. Whatever capacities we have are there for the service of society, not for the pursuit of our self-interest. True self-

interest lies in sacrifice for the service to society.

We need to do two things for the establishment of a sarvodaya society. The first is that we should consider ourselves trustees of what we have, not owners. Therefore, I should be ready to give my share to the society whenever it needs it. Whatever I have is for the use of all. I have a watch. If someone proves that he needs it more than me, he is entitled to ask for it, and it will then be my duty to give it to him. I am not the owner of the watch. I need it, and therefore I keep it, but I keep it as a trustee. I am ready to share it with others when they need it. This spirit should be infused in the society. This is what the concept of *dana* implies.

I had entertained the hope that just as one Ramchandra Reddy stood up and gifted one hundred acres of land and I took up the idea and toured the country asking for bhoodan and gramdan¹⁵, some capitalist would volunteer to become a trustee of his property. That would have created the power of businessmen and I would have brought about a revolution on that basis.

Dana and nyasa

Complete dissolution of ownership is what is intended. This is the envisaged culmination of Bhoodan-yajna. In geometry, a line joins two points. The two points in sarvodaya are *dana* and *nyasa* (sacrifice). The line joining them defines the path of righteousness. The purpose of human life is *nyasa*—to become merged in

15. Vinoba, during his walking tour of the Telangana region, ravaged by communist insurgency, was offered the gift of 100 acres for the local landless harijan labourers by Ramchandra Reddy on 18 April 1951. Thus began the Bhoodan (land-gift) Movement. Vinoba thereafter toured the country on foot for thirteen years. Gramdan means voluntary surrender of ownership of land. For details of the concept of gramdan, see Vinoba's 'Gram-swaraj' (Village self-rule).

society, to relinquish private property and surrender everything to the society. A river, while flowing, nurtures trees in her way; a righteous man likewise goes on giving in the course of his life. But if you ask the river what is her object, she would reply that it is to merge into the sea, not to nurture the trees. The object of human life is to merge into the society, to dissolve private property and take refuge in the collectivity. *Dana*, on the other hand, means giving a part of what one has, while continuing to enjoy the rest. Both *dana* and *nyasa* are not merely personal values, they have a social aspect too. The values, which remain merely personal, cannot have strength.

When possessions increase in the society, their security becomes a concern. Therefore, *nyasa* implies decentralised production. A social scheme of *dana* involves continuous giving by individuals to the society, while a social scheme of *nyasa* involves decentralised production.

Importance of individual

It is argued that if ownership is abolished, importance of an individual will be diminished. Yes, it will happen, if ownership is abolished by force. Even if a good thing is done by force, it has an undesirable effect. But when a man relinquishes ownership after due reflection and with love, it is bound to result in his uplift. If one goes after money, it will enhance the importance of money; not that of the individual. That is what has happened. Money and many other things have gained importance, while importance of individuals has declined. An individual will grow in importance when he voluntarily relinquishes ownership.

Will an individual have more prestige if he clings to his ownership, or if he surrenders his property for the service of society? The answer is so obvious. Look at what happens in the family. If the father, the mother, the son, all cling to their separate earnings, will the family be

happy? Will that earn them approbation? A mother rises in dignity when she gives her all to her son. Whatever laws on property may say, parents feel that their property is for their offspring. Similarly, an individual's true dignity lies in surrendering his all to the society.

'Sacredness' of property

It is said that Roman Catholics consider private property sacred. This is a misconception. We should see what they mean by private property. If everyone in the family is supposed to have separate property, that family will not survive. We are not out to disrupt the institution of family; we seek its expansion instead. We are saying that the whole village should become one family. We want to expand the family and submerge private property in it. There is a famous story about Jesus Christ. Once a gentleman went to him and sought his guidance. When Jesus asked him to do certain things, he replied that he was already doing them, and he was seeking advanced instruction. Jesus thereupon told the gentleman, 'Distribute all your possessions to the poor and then come to me.' What does sacredness of private property really mean? It is true that one should not encroach on others' property. But what is the harm in voluntary surrender of property? Can any religion go against sacrifice? No religion can object to voluntary sacrifice.

I also believe that if some persons in the society possesses too much when others are hungry, the society has the right to take a part of their possessions for the benefit of society.

I fully agree that no one should encroach on what someone else has earned through honest efforts. Forcible expropriation is wrong. But if the property has been earned through improper means, does that property qualify to be called 'proper'ty in the true sense? Property earned through right means alone is entitled to be

considered sacred. If an individual earns through honest labour, he is entitled to his earnings. But if he relinquishes his claim in favour of his son, it will be considered a righteous act.

Private property is sacred. But its dissolution is even more sacred.

One must distinguish between private property and personal responsibility. The latter is necessary for the society, not the former.

Ownership is a fire

Fire of discontent is raging in the world. One of the reasons is that everyone looks after his own narrow self-interest and clings to his ownership. This inevitably results in clashes. Man desires ownership, because he wants to live on others' labour. Ownership over land is one of the major reasons for suffering in the world. Avoiding physical labour and exploiting others' labour is the second main reason for the woes of the world.

People say, "We do not own much land. Why should we relinquish it?" But if a fire begins to rage, everything that comes in its way is reduced to ashes, whether it is a bungalow or a hut. Individual ownership is like a fire. This fire is out to burn down the world. Therefore, let everyone surrender his property, whether it is big or small. If ownership is a fire, what is the point in arguing who should renounce it first?

Once we were climbing up a fort. We came to such a point wherefrom it was difficult to move ahead. We had our belongings in sacks on our backs. It was difficult to climb down either. If we had to climb up further, the only option was to throw away our sacks. That we did, and watched the sacks rolling down the hill with relief. The question before us today is the same: Should we cling to our sacks or save ourselves? Those who throw away

their sacks will be saved and proved to be wise.

Ownership of the Lord

Those who hate the rich also desire to own something. Neither big owners nor small owners are ready to renounce their properties. Small owners do not realise that they are clinging to something on account of which they hate the rich. They have attachment to the negligible property they have. I therefore, call upon small owners to give up attachment to their properties; the dissolution of the property of the big owners would then come about as a matter of course.

Let the spirit of ownership cease to exist and the spirit of compassion and righteousness get generated. Then all will think of sharing what they have. Then the wealth in India will grow and everyone's desires will be fulfilled. Economic problems owe their origin to self-centeredness of the people. When everyone thinks about himself and does not care for others, people lack the means for the growth of wealth.

There is a difference between social ownership and ownership of the Lord. If there is social ownership, an individual may have to suffer injustice. There is no such possibility when ownership belongs to the Lord. Provision of full scope to the development of individual by the society, voluntary surrender by individuals of all of their capacities to the society and ultimately the abolition of duality between society and individuals—all this is implied when we talk of the ownership of God. The very word 'Ishwar' (Sanskrit word for God) means the owner. If a human being claims ownership on any thing, he is practically opposing the overlordship of God.

Inevitable consummation

In India, dissolution of private ownership can come about, as the people here understand the idea. The saints

have taught that we do not own even our bodies. Does the house belong to you? Even rats claim that it is theirs. Everybody has equal entitlement. Indian people accept this. The idea of private property was brought in by the British law. Here, providing hospitality to even uninvited guests has been considered a duty. It means the right of all on what we have has been implicitly acknowledged.

I assert that the idea of ownership is bound to crumble in India, as it is being attacked from two sides. Indian people believe in the all-pervasiveness of the Self, and Self-knowledge does not recognise any ownership. Spirituality is thus attacking the idea of ownership from one side. And science is attacking it from the other side. Science today is against individual ownership. In the era of science, wealth cannot be created through the efforts of any one individual alone; it needs involvement and co-operation of innumerable people. It is necessary to bring about the confluence of science and spirituality and replace narrow self-interest with the common interest of the community.

It is not that an individual alone keeps private property. Societies do the same. Consequently, conflicts arise between them. Nations claim ownership and engage in conflict with other nations. But the whole earth belongs to all of her inhabitants. People are entitled to serve, not to own anything. Every common resource belongs to all. If private property persists in this era of science, peace is bound to elude us. Suppose one country has petroleum in abundance. It cannot remain its sole property to the exclusion of others. The world cannot be deprived of any resource, although it may fall within the geographical boundaries of one particular country. The wealth of the world belongs to the whole world, to all the sentient beings in the world.

Removal of casteism, deliverance of harijans (dalits),

peacemaking, advancement of women—we are engaged in many such tasks. But all of them are of secondary importance. Our main task is to dig out the roots of ownership, which have gone deep into the society, through love and reason. Spirituality does not recognise any kind of ownership, and science is also standing up against it. Through confluence of science and spirituality, we have to replace 'I' and 'mine' with 'we' and 'ours'.

6. *Kanchan-mukti*¹⁶

Distortion in economic structure

A questioner has asked, "You and the government, both are trying for material progress of the people; but what about moral degradation of the people, which is being witnessed?"

We will have to see where moral degradation is more. We have been observing since antiquity that desire, anger and attachment take hold of man and cause untold distress. But desire (for sensual pleasures) and anger do not appear to have the same force today that they had in the past. There has, however, been great increase in greed. Moral degradation is, therefore, mainly in the economic realm. It is there in all the countries of the world, but it is more in India because of higher incidence of poverty and inequality. Productivity of land is less and people do not have adequate work. Greed is rampant because of inequitable social order. The economic structure is distorted, and needs to be changed. If we can do this, many of the moral sins taking place today will disappear.

Today, we have entrusted the reins of our affairs to money and erected the edifice of social structure on the foundation of competition. Undesirable values have, therefore, taken the place of labour. This is the root of the present moral degradation.

Money on a pedestal

Peasants lack self-reliance and, therefore, have set money on a pedestal. And the government also, being dependent on other countries, has done the same. The government wants to import various things, and needs

money for the purpose. It is trapped in the same delusion in which the peasant is trapped. Traders, it goes without saying, are caught in this trap. Middle class is not involved in actual productive activity, and cannot survive without money. As a result, the traders, the middle class, the peasants, the government—all are singing the praise of money.

Such exalted is the status of money at present. A man in India is not satisfied with the things produced here. He is enamoured of things in other countries and wants them. As far as consumption is concerned, his outlook has indeed become global! For this purpose, he wants money; and for this very purpose, he favours competition.

Trickery of money

Money is a strange thing. While discussing the level of daily wages for spinning (in 1950), we found that they had increased from three annas (Rs. 0.18) to eight annas (Rs. 0.50) during the last fifteen years. But had they really increased? Fifteen years ago, you could get around 3 kg. grains in three annas, but now (in 1950) you can get not more than 1.75 kgs in eight annas. It means that there had been reduction in real wages. The wages had, in effect, been reduced, but no one was aware of it. How could such miracle happen?

This is the trickery of money. Had the wages been fixed in terms of the prices of food grains, such reduction would have been immediately noticed and would have caused uproar. But nothing of this sort happened and even people like me remained blissfully unaware of it. In fact, those responsible for disbursing wages to spinners must be under the impression that they have increased the wages to compensate for the rise in prices, at least partially. Such is the trickery of money, which is ruining all our work.

16. Literally, freedom from gold. By 'gold', money in the form of currency is meant here.

Money is a scoundrel

Many people say that people have become rogues, and corruption is rampant. But I do not think that the whole society could become degraded. Surely, it is the economic structure which is to be blamed. Money has been minted without any relation to labour and production. Artificially inflated money is a fallacious fabrication, which has spread falsity everywhere and made people dishonest. Money is a scoundrel. It has made all the people greedy.

The value of money fluctuates; that is why people have become dishonest. If you give me a loan of a thousand rupees and I repay it after ten years, it will not be full repayment. So, you will charge as much interest as you can, to receive proper repayment. Thus the dealings between people are vitiated because of the deceptive nature of money. People are not dishonest; it is the system that is dishonest.

Religions exhort against dishonesty. But the system is more responsible for dishonesty than the individuals.

Truth is the first and foremost moral value. But money has brought deceit and deviousness in mutual dealings. The whole human intercourse has become fraudulent because of money. A perverted economics has been constructed on the foundation of money, and consequently truth is the casualty. In fact, practice of truth is easy; resort to falsehood is difficult. Yet the former has become difficult.

Upanishads have said in unambiguous terms, अमृतत्वस्य न तु आशा अस्ति वित्तेन—money may give anything else, but surely eternal bliss cannot be expected from it. I believe in this dictum. It is based on experiential wisdom. It is money, which has brought ruin to the country.

I call money a trickster, because it speaks different

things at different times. And yet we are not only tolerating it, but have entrusted our affairs to its care. Can we then escape being duped?

Is it not a blatant injustice that land revenue is not taken in the form of agricultural produce, but is demanded in terms of money, which does not have a fixed value? To pay revenue in cash, the produce has to be sold. Thus, a thing with unchanging value is asked to be converted into a thing with fluctuating value. This is beyond my understanding. I asked renowned economists why this is so, but have not got a satisfactory answer. Some people cite difficulties in storing grains. But procurement of food grains is being done. Yet they talk of difficulties in collecting land revenue in the form of grains. This is nothing but infatuation with money, which has gripped everyone.

In Bhoodan-yajna, I accept land, wells, bullocks etc., but not money. People ask why I am not taking money, although Gandhiji used to take it. I say, “I do not take money, *because* Gandhiji used to take it.” He had done that experiment. A river does not flow in the same way in its course. I do not want to perpetuate the prestige of money. I want to tell the poor that it is they who are really rich, and tell the rich that they are really poor. Money is totally useless. It humiliates not only the poor, but also the rich. I look forward to the day when gold would be used for putting up embankments to check soil erosion from the fields. It is not a flight of fancy. This is bound to materialize one day.

I saw in the local temple coins nailed to the floor. What does this mean? This means that money is worthy of being trampled upon. Does it behove us to idolize it?

Money and wealth are different

There is difference between money and wealth. Money is a demon and Laxmi, that is wealth, is a

goddess. Equating money with wealth is the height of delusion.

Wealth is created through labour. Money can be minted as much as we want. It has no relation with production. Wealth, on the other hand, is the sign of true prosperity. It is a mark of God's grace. But what happens when money grows? Bhagavata says, money brings with it fifteen disastrous results; and it lists them: divisions, enmity, lack of trust, competition, evil habits etc.

Money is thus a thing fit to be thrown away, while land is worthy of being gifted. Good things are donated, not the rubbish.

Great challenge

A gentleman cautioned me, "Can we ever do away with money? It is futile to entertain such an idea. Money is all-pervasive." It is certainly very difficult to liberate ourselves from money. But my nature is such that difficult challenges spur me on to act. They enthuse me. I therefore call upon the people to banish money not only from their personal lives but also from village communities. A big segment of society needs to be freed from money. Only then will life be joyful.

The task calls for discretion. It is not a task that a single individual can accomplish. All must join in this endeavour. It is difficult; but only when we dare to undertake this task will the sarvodaya ideology spread, the nonviolence will spread. If we lack courage for it, we will have to concede that we would not become vehicles of a nonviolent revolution.

How to do away with money?

The social order would have to be based on labour instead of money, if commitment to truth is to be inculcated. Villages should have grains, fruits, milk in abundance, but not money. Everyone should have land,

shelter and implements for production.

When money becomes important, love vanishes. What should we prefer—love or money? This was the bone of contention between Yashoda and Krishna. Yashoda wanted to sell butter in the city of Mathura, while Krishna would contend that the village children should get the butter. Yashoda would say that selling butter would bring money. Krishna would counter with the argument that there was money in Mathura, but the evil king Kansa was also there; if you were lured by the money in Mathura, you would have to accept the rule of Kansa. If India wants love, she will have to free herself from money.

It is individual ownership, which is responsible for the present mess. It has enhanced the importance of money. If we consider the village as one family, dissolve individual ownership and bring the means of production under the ownership of village community, we can find a way out of the present impasse. Planning should be done at the village level. Raw materials should be processed at the village level to produce finished goods like cloth, oil, jaggery etc. A concerted endeavour for gram-swaraj is what is required.

To reduce the importance of money, self-sufficiency will have to be encouraged in many sectors. Villagers should not be dependent on market for the basic necessities of life. This needs a nation-wide plan for village industries.

An experiment in yarn currency

(A.I. Spinners Association resolved to try yarn currency on 15 August 1950. At the time of the inauguration of the scheme, Vinoba said—)

You have decided to begin with payment of 75% (of wages to the spinners) in yarn and 25% in money. As a beginning, it is okay, but we must never forget the

object—securing freedom from money. The yarn must not, therefore, be converted into money in any case. If one cannot use the yarn currency fully, one may give it to someone else, and may even burn it, but it must not be converted into money.

This is not just an experiment about yarn currency, it is an experiment for the transformation of life. We have to produce through labour and order our lives through cooperation. For this purpose, the experiment of yarn currency will have to be supplemented with plans for production.

This experiment will help us in identifying with the villagers. We have to carry out this experiment for a couple of years and make it succeed. Thereupon it has to be tried in the villages. We want to establish village self-rule by working alongside the villagers. This is the vision behind this experiment.

Labour currency

I am not in favour of barter. I will prefer paper currency, provided the number of labour-hours are noted on it, not the value in terms of money. In effect, it will be replacement of paper currency by labour currency.

It is argued that as the jobs differ, the kind of labour would also differ qualitatively; how can then we have the same standard of currency?

This question has arisen because of the capitalist society. In my plan, every man or woman's honest labour would have the same value irrespective of its kind.

After gramdan, the gramsabha can decide that it would adopt labour currency. One hour of labour will mean one hour of currency. It will certainly not be possible for the gramsabha to regulate prices of imported goods, but it can fix the rates for goods produced in the village. This labour currency would be a legal tender

within the jurisdiction of the village.

Gramsabha can do this. It can plan for the production of most of the basic necessities of life in the village. Then there will be little scope for corruption. This has revolutionary implications.

The question of interest

Today, charging interest is an established convention. At the most, it is said that one should not charge excessive interest. But the idea itself needs to be reconsidered. Islam has rejected interest in no uncertain terms. Society will have to uphold this rejection some day. That day should come early and should be brought early. If interest is eschewed, extent of hoarding would be considerably reduced.

If we give money to a needy person, we should be satisfied with the same amount of money in return. We may take a little less, but charging interest is downright wrong.

It is not sufficient not to charge interest. Kishorlalbhai (Mashruwala) had advocated that if we have no immediate use of our surplus money and we give it to someone who can make such use, then we should accept less money in return, particularly when the money has been used for purposes which are in the interest of the commonfolk, like village industries.

If an institution has more money, and it gives the same to another institution which needs it, the former charges interest, as it thinks that it would have got interest, had the money been kept in a bank. But a bank gives interest because it utilizes your money in some enterprises, which may not be in tune with your ideology. Thus, institutions have no objection to their money being used contrary to their objectives, but they would not give money to a like-minded institution without interest! In

fact, an institution which has money, should advertise the fact and give the money for a genuine cause, accepting, say 5%, less money in return. This is what should happen, although it appears silly today.

I suggested to the traders at Guskara (Burdwan, W. Bengal, 1963) not to charge interest on the money they give to the poor. They accepted, and declared the same in writing. Such incidents happened at quite a few other places also. Around 100 individuals signed this pledge.

I heard that the government also is charging interest on the loans given to the villages. How can this be justified? How wrong it is to charge interest on money, which has been taken from the people themselves! We have to extricate ourselves from interest. Interest is an enemy of democracy and nonviolence, and needs to be attacked. Revolution cannot take place unless wrong customs like interest are removed. People should raise their voice against such practices.

7. Land Problem and Bhoodan

Who owns land?

It is asked, 'Who owns land?' The question itself is wrong. Neither the peasant is immortal, nor the landlord. Both pass away, but the land continues to exist. In fact, it is the land which owns us. Who owns air? But, if a reply has to be given, it can be said that the land belongs to one who serves her. Nobody can own the land. Hence, there is no question of anyone holding more than necessary land and of talking about its ownership.¹⁷

Village industries are crumbling away. Land is the only support, the only succour to the people. If land-ownership persists, a means of production gets concentrated in a few hands. Through bhoodan, I want to impress on the people that land-ownership should end.

Equal right over land

Why should some people, who cannot cultivate land, hold it? They then employ labourers to cultivate it. And the labourers who know the job do not work with full dedication, as they have no right over the produce. This is affecting production.

Land hunger is present throughout Asia and population is increasing. If land is held by a few only, others remain discontented. Discontent fuels violence. Bhoodan removes this discontent and saves the world from a danger.

There is an aphorism in the science of yoga, on whose basis I have repeatedly said that you should do things in a proper order. If you want to cook rice, you should first put on the burner, then keep the utensil on it, then put rice

17. Vinoba was saying this in 1945, when India was under British rule.

and water in the utensil. Rice would not get cooked if you perform these actions in a different sequence. In the same way, land problem should be solved first; formation of *panchayats* and other schemes should come thereafter. Unless land problem is solved, other schemes are bound to lead to the exploitation of the poor.

Land is a gift of God. Not only human beings, but animals and birds also have right to it. Even poor Indian peasants acknowledge this. Once I was taking a walk in the morning. A peasant was sitting on a raised platform in his field to guard the crops. But birds were feasting on the crops and he was not shooing them away. When I asked why he was not doing so, he replied, "The sun is rising. This is an auspicious hour. Let the birds eat for some time." This shows how deep the Indian culture has struck roots.

Just as water and air are available to all, land should also be available to all. And it was so a hundred years ago. Village land belonged to the whole village collectively. Some people did farming, others did carpentry, smithy etc. But the latter were entitled to a fixed share in the agricultural produce irrespective of the actual work done by them. They got more if there was more production and less if there was less. Thus all shared in the fortune of the village. It meant that the land did not belong to the farmers only. These days, land is believed to belong to the landowner. Communists counter this contention and say that land belongs to the tiller. But this too is wrong. Some people cultivate land, some do other jobs. It is all for convenience. But it does not mean that those who do not cultivate land have no right over it. This is the difference between my idea and the communist and capitalist ideas. I hold that land belongs to all. When people appreciate this idea, moral stature of society will rise and it will pave the way for the economic uplift of the country.

Necessity of land distribution

Will to power does exist in human beings. To regulate and neutralise that will, power has to be decentralised, so that everyone feels assured that a part of power is with him. Same is the way to deal with selfishness and greed. An effort to make available means of comfort equally to all is necessary for its neutralisation. Ultimately it is land which provides for the fulfilment of our desires. Hence I have made a beginning from the land and declared that every landless must get land. His right to land must be acknowledged. This is a fundamental thought, which I am placing before the society. I have taken up the question of land first, but I hold that a lot of other things, which a human being needs, must be available to all equally. This is the way to neutralize man's will to consumption and enjoyment.

Land in the country is limited. It is, therefore, necessary that those who actually till it get land to work on.

Ideally, the number of labourers should be the least in the society; the number of self-employed like the agriculturists, traders, entrepreneurs, artisans etc. should be more than those engaged in other sectors. This is what our civilisation demands. It is necessary in this context that the landless get land.

Land invaluable

The value of land is real; that of other kinds of wealth is imaginary. They have value because people have accorded it to them. If people decide tomorrow not to give their produce in return for money or gold, the latter would become worthless. But this is not the case with land. Its value is real, not fictitious. As long as man needs food, this fact will not change. Land, therefore, is in the category of air, water and sunlight.

People quote value of land in terms of money. But will anything be produced if it rains on a wad of currency notes? Land cannot be valued in terms of money. It is invaluable. It is like our mother. And yet it has been brought in the market and its price is fixed!

My concern

I am not concerned with collection of land only. I want uplift of the whole society. The condition has so deteriorated that everyone is after amassing as much wealth as he can without any other thought. I want people to understand and follow the moral philosophy behind bhoodan. I do not just want that the poor should get land; I want them to get it through *yajna* (voluntary sacrifice). Transfer of land is not the problem; the problem is how to do it in a right manner.

The fundamental idea behind bhoodan is that it is the duty of individual to surrender his all to the society—it may be talent, wealth, intellect or any other capability, and take from the society what it gives as a mark of the grace of the Lord.

The land problem is a problem all over the world and different countries have adopted different ways to solve it. But I want to solve it in a nonviolent way. So, if people give land in bits, the poor will get some land, but that will not bring about revolution. That will not change the economic and social structure. The landless should be considered a part of our family.

Bhoodan tries to awaken compassion in the hearts of men and women. Compassion is another term for devotion. Devotion does not consist of formal rituals and prayer; it means active compassion.

I am not seeking alms for the poor; I seek to initiate people in a new way of life.

Bhoodan does not stop at giving land to the landless.

It hopes to bring about a change of attitude towards the question of ownership of property.

When I tell the landowners that land is to be given with eagerness and enthusiasm, and they should be prepared to live like the grantees of land, I do not mean that they should become servile. What I want is that we should consider the landless labourers equal right-holders and share enjoyments with them. This is the way to samyayoga.

I ask for one-sixth share in land from the average landholder. I expect more from the big landlords and accept with gratitude what small landholders give as a mark of grace. But everyone should give. Many poor persons have gifted me lands. These are the people who will be the vanguard of the economic revolution. The idea of ownership has taken hold of the people's minds. I want to attack this notion.

It is the triple transformation—transformation of hearts, transformation in lives, and consequent transformation in social structure—that I have in mind.

Transparent scheme

It has been laid down that the Bhoodan lands in a village would be distributed in open public meeting. There is thus no scope for any partiality. In the meeting, names of the landless would be sought and the choice of the allottees would be left to the landless themselves. They would decide by consensus who are the most deserving. It has also been stipulated that at least one-third of the lands would be given to the dalits. They could thereby hold their heads up high and it would mark the beginning of a social revolution.

Bhoodan and land reforms

Zamindars accepted Zamindari abolition without much demur. I think that the atmosphere created by Bhoodan-yajna is one factor that contributed to it.

Zamindari abolition has been accomplished now, tenants have become owners, but that has not solved the problem of landlessness. In fact, that has given rise to the problem of the new landless.¹⁸ When land is a marketable commodity, the number of landless is bound to increase. Law can accomplish little. Zamindari abolition has failed to give land to the landless. Besides, there is the question of compensation.¹⁹

Law can at most acquire land by giving compensation. But there is no question of compensation in the non-violent way. I hope to convince the zamindars and the big landlords that they should take only as much compensation as they need for their livelihood, not what the law offers. I seek donation of compensation amount also.

These days, land ceiling is being talked about. I do not understand it. If a family needs 5 acres, why should it be allowed to hold four or five times more? If I can bear the load of 20 kg on my head, why should I be burdened with five times more weight? Allowing people to hold more than sufficient land means depriving others from their rightful share in the land. I do not contest when people talk about ceiling. But my mission will remain unaccomplished unless and until everyone gets right to land.

18. Zamindari abolition laws were enacted in India after Independence, and zamindari was eventually abolished after protracted legal battles. Tenancy laws were also enacted for the protection of tenants. However, these measures brought in their wake large-scale evictions of sub-tenants and those without legal tenancy. Thus, the landless did not get land; rather their number increased.

19. Right to property was a fundamental right in the Indian Constitution; hence the landlords whose lands were taken—and later, the landowners whose lands were declared surplus and were acquired under Ceiling laws—had to be paid compensation.

I want not 'ceiling', but 'flooring'. You should first accept the principle that every family should at least get, say, five acres; then you may do whatever you want with the rest of the land. If the ceiling is low, the quantum of compensation would be substantial; if it is high, it will serve no purpose. We, therefore, say that all lands of the village should belong to the village community. Ceiling would create small robbers in the place of big ones. That would result only in swelling the ranks of robbers.

It should be realised that the government does not have the capacity to seize land and distribute it, because it has many landowners within its ranks. It is not possible that they would cut the branch of the tree on which they are sitting! (West) Bengal Government made a law (1955) to obtain 4,00,000 acres out of 12.5 million acres in the state. It only means that it intends to maintain the status quo. In fact, clever landholders distributed lands among their kith and kin when ceiling was in the air. So the governments got little through ceiling.

We do not obstruct laws; our work, in fact, facilitates legislation. But the law neither generates people's power nor arouses compassion. Rather, it creates bitterness. If the way of compassion succeeds in solving the problem to a great extent, and then the law puts the seal on it, that law would be acceptable to all. Otherwise, there are several defects in the way of legislation. I believe that if law, which represents indirect will of the people, can have results, then the exertion of people's direct will must give results, and that too quickly, easily and in an elegant manner.

Propagation of nonviolence

Land problem can be solved through law or violence. Both the ways have been tried in the world. But in India, we are attempting a third way. If we succeed in it, not only will the land problem in India be solved, but the

whole world will also find a way to solve various problems in peaceful and nonviolent ways. Those who look upon the Bhoodan movement as a way to solve the land problem only do not realise its distinctiveness and potency. We are moving all over the country on foot like *sannyasis*²⁰ not for the solution of a material problem only, we are also establishing the way of love as the paramount way of solving the problems. Lord Buddha took up the problem of animal sacrifice to spread nonviolence. I am following in his footsteps. Bhoodan is an instrument for propagation of nonviolence.

Repercussions of bhoodan

The Gita has said that desire, anger and greed are three terrible gates of hell (16.21). A human being possesses all the three vices, but greed is his worst enemy. There is no limit to a human being's acquisitiveness. There are animals and birds which surpass man in anger and lust, but none can equal man in greed. Bhoodan is a programme to get rid of greed.

Economic equality is the basic idea behind all efforts for reconstruction. Bhoodan is driving a wedge of this idea. Economic equality is not possible through legislation; it is possible only if the people's hearts are full of love.

People are considerably ardent when it is a question of taking back what belongs to them. We should be more earnest to give what is in our hands, but belongs to someone else. Let the landowners realise that the land they hold belongs to others, and they should keep only a part of it and gift the rest and thus be freed from a burden. This is what humanity and love for freedom

20. Those who have renounced the world in search of the Supreme. They used to be on the move continuously except in the rainy season.

dictate. If the landowners in India give land to the landless, they will demonstrate their love for freedom. And only then India can be considered Independent in the true sense.

Material and moral uplift can proceed simultaneously. There is no antagonism between the two. Bhoodan is achieving both. It will arouse goodness, leading to moral uplift, and when these lands are distributed and the grantees increase production, it will lead to material progress. Sacrifice is such a beautiful act that it brings about both the kinds of uplift simultaneously.

Any work with a vast scope has many aspects. Bhoodan can be seen as an effort to solve the land problem, increase food production, promote justice, organise villages, develop righteousness, arouse compassion and the attitude to sacrifice, and have a positive and wholesome effect on politics. It can also be looked upon as an endeavour, which is in consonance with the Indian ethos and also as a great labour movement.

True religiosity

I am moving from village to village and explaining a simple thing: we should share the joys and sorrows of our neighbours. This is what sets man apart from the animals. A man can derive joy from sacrifice for the sake of others. Pleasure of others makes him happy and misery of others pains him. This is not the case with animals. Suffering of a deer is a cause of delight for a tiger. It is not human nature to accumulate riches by robbing others; it is rather an animal instinct.

Sacrifice and compassion characterize true religiosity. The poor cannot be truly religious when they are starved. The rich cannot be truly religious when they feast amidst starving people. Bhoodan is opening the door of true devotion to both the rich and the poor. Both destitution

and prosperity are sins. And sharing joys and sorrows of neighbours constitutes merit. Bhoodan is inculcating this spirit. I have always held that Bhoodan would set in motion the wheel of righteousness. It is the task of founding a new religion.

Daily I witness incidents which reveal the pure hearts of the people. I have received extremely pure land-gifts. Even the blind have given me land. Bhoodan-yajna is, in fact, an effort to arouse noble sentiments in human beings. It is a programme for purification. It is a movement for the collective development of virtues.

Needless criticism

Some critics say that I have got only barren and uncultivable land. This is not true. I have received both good and bad lands. The lands that are now considered uncultivable have also been doggedly held by the owners. They must have derived some advantage from them. Now that benefit will accrue to the poor. In fact, no land is worthless. If it appears worthless to someone, it means that he lacks intelligence to use it.

I am presently asking for one-sixth of land. People ask, would it be sufficient? But I am not going to leave untouched the rest five-sixth part. If an engineer wants to take you to a height of five thousand feet, he does not construct the road with a steep gradient. He constructs the road in such a way that we traverse the road and reach the top without realising it. That is how nonviolence works. I would go on asking for one-sixth share of the land till the whole land gets redistributed. I will not be satisfied unless the ownership over land ends.

Some people object that bhoodan will fragment land. But what about the fragmentation of hearts, which is a reality? When hearts unite, so will the fragments of land. After giving land to the poor, it is not difficult to convince them to adopt the method of cooperation.

The debate whether big plots of land are more productive than small plots or not is needless. It is labour that increases production; size of plot does not matter. Moreover, smaller plots have been found to be more productive all over the world. If the labourer becomes the owner, he will definitely work with more enthusiasm and concern and the production is bound to increase. Everyone knows what happens to the lands of absentee landlords.

For people's power

I am seeking and obtaining land-gifts from the poor as well. Why? I want to organise them. The poor have to renounce ownership; ownership of the rich will then come to an end as a matter of course. When the spirit to give is generated, it will transform life.

Power of nonviolence will not become manifest unless private ownership is relinquished. There is no separate private property in a family. Has it caused misery or happiness? It is a source of delight. Let the scope of this experiment widen. Let ownership be surrendered to the village community.

Bhoodan-Yajna is basically a movement for developing people's power. Hence, it is not devoid of politics. Yet this movement is against conventional politics. That land will be redistributed through it will be its least gain; its most important result will be that people will realize their strength. They will be freed from the habit of expecting everything from the government and will begin to believe in their own capacities. This work is not merely for the solution of land problem, but also for elimination of the States from the whole world.

Population is going to increase continuously; so land redistribution would not be enough for the solution of land problem. Land in the village should belong to the village community. That is what gramdan seeks to

achieve. It means considering the whole village as a family and surrendering all that we have to it. As private property in land will cease to exist, land will not be sold or mortgaged, so farmers will not lose their lands. This is the way to solve the land problem. Land reforms done in a piecemeal fashion would achieve nothing.

In gramdan, a village will virtually become a State. It will make its own planning and decide which goods should be sold outside the village and which goods should be imported. Gramdan will bring in material prosperity and secure economic freedom.

When private property in land ends, ownership of factories is not going to last. There will be landslide, as everything stands on the land.

Experience corroborates faith

When I think what words I should use to describe my experiences during the Telangana tour (1951), the only word that occurs to me is '*sakshatkar*' (direct vision of the Supreme). I worked in the faith that human heart has goodness in it and it could be called out; and experiences corroborated that faith. If we believe in the innate goodness of human nature, it does reveal itself to us.²¹

21. For detailed history and assessment of the Bhoodan-Gramdan Movement, readers may refer to Parag Cholkar, 'The Earth is the Lord's' (Pavnar: Paramdham Prakashan, 2017)

8. Decentralisation and Self-sufficiency

Let every village be a Gokul²²

It is my desire that every village should become Gokul. All the villagers should consider the village as one family and live together with love and harmony. The village lands should belong to all. All should work together in fraternal spirit and share the produce. The village children should get milk, curd, butter in abundance like the children in Gokul. Today, the villagers produce milk, butter etc. but do not give them to their children, nor do they themselves consume them. They sell these products in the cities. In fact, these should first be given to the village children, and only surplus should be sold. But the villagers are compelled to sell their produce because they do not manufacture necessary goods like cloth. They produce cotton, but sell it and purchase mill cloth made in the cities. They produce sesame, but sell it and purchase oil made in cities. They produce sugarcane, but sell it and purchase sugar. Cloth, oil, jaggery—all these things should rather be manufactured in the villages. As the villagers do not make cloth today, they need money to buy it and are thus compelled to sell milk and butter. If they make their own cloth, they will not be forced to sell butter.

That is what I constantly plead for: Do not get tricked by the jugglery of money. Produce milk, butter, fruits and vegetables in abundance. Feed your children and yourselves first, and sell the surplus only. Presently the villagers go to the cities to sell their goods and have to sell them at low rates, as dictated by the town-dwellers, as they cannot return without selling them. But if they

22. The village in which Lord Krishna lived in his childhood. It is considered a model for an ideal and self-sufficient village.

make the village one family, set up industries in the village, live and work together, the town-dwellers will have to come to their doors for milk, butter etc.

We have hardly 0.7-acre per capita land (1951). To increase production, we will have to increase the productivity of land and motivate the people to produce their basic necessities from the raw materials they grow. We should concentrate our efforts on these two tasks. Then the village economy will be revolutionized and the rural people will be free from the clutches of money.

Produce food in abundance

The Vedas have ordained, कृषिं कृष्व—Be engaged in agriculture. The sages have ordained, अन्नं बहु कुर्वीत, तद् व्रतम्—‘Take a vow to produce food in abundance’. The Upanishads are treatises on spirituality, yet they give this command, because they know that shortage of food would adversely affect the level of compassion in the world.

Is food something to be sold? Everyone has right to be fed. If a child feels hungry while roaming on the streets, he/she should be able to go to any house and get food there. Just as air and water are available to all, land should also be available to all for this purpose.

Question of pricing

The villagers complain that khadi is costly. But, for them it is a thing to be sold, not a thing to be purchased. It should be dear, so that the peasants can get money. They cannot get much money by selling grains. And as the population goes on increasing, more and more land will have to be brought under food crops. Therefore, goods manufactured in villages should be sold in cities—and sold at high rates. The villagers should sell only the surplus, which the city-dwellers should buy at high rates. But the village industries presently lie in ruins.

Love implies that we should be concerned with the

well-being of one another. If we do not buy footwear from the village cobbler, he will be finished. We should buy footwear from him. We should buy oil from the village oil miller. But we say that the village cobbler's footwear is dear, village oil miller's oil is dear, village weaver's cloth is dear. What does this dearness mean? If the village cobbler buys oil from the village oil miller and the oil miller buys footwear from the cobbler, where does the question of dearness of oil or footwear arise? The money from the cobbler's pocket goes in the pocket of the oil miller and the money from the oil miller's pocket goes to the pocket of the cobbler.

Today, the price of any commodity is fixed according to the principle of demand and supply. If there is dearth of milk, its price shoots up. Only those who can afford to pay more can get it. This is a tragic situation. In case of shortage of any article, available stock should be distributed equitably. Prices of basic necessities of life should remain constant.

Five necessary things

Land is like the mother. It can sustain all. But it is not a means to earn money. That is the job of industries. However, land was made a means to earn money and consequently the rich grabbed the land of the poor. The poor were caught in the web of loans and had to lose their lands.

To bring happiness to the villages, five things need to be done: (i) Land should not be a means to earn money, (ii) The villagers should not need much money, (iii) If some money is needed, village industries should be built to take care of that, and their products should be sold outside the village,²³ (iv) Those products should be sold at high rates,

23. Of course, after consumption in the village, as Vinoba has repeatedly stressed.

and (v) All the people in the village should get land.

If you understand this village economics, you have understood the heart of bhoodan. Then you will give as much land to the poor as necessary, build village industries to produce important basic necessities and sell the surplus at high rates. All this will, of course, need organisation. If individuals sell their products independently, they would not get much return. You will have to build a well-knit organisation of the village.

How the villages were ruined

India is considered a poor country today, but 300-400 years ago, it was well known as a rich country. Traders from all over the world used to buy things here and take them to distant places as far away as Europe. In those days, means of communication were not much developed, there were no railways, yet the fame of India's prosperity was spread all over the world and it lured the British, the French, the Dutch and the Portuguese, who set out to discover India. They willingly suffered hardships for this. It was not an ordinary task to come here sailing eight to ten thousand miles, in the absence of big ships. Yet they came, established their trade and eventually their rule here. We all know that history. For one hundred and fifty years, they ruled over us and bled us white. The most painful part was that village industries were all ruined one by one.

In the times of East India Company, almost every village had its own school and a *panchayat*, which looked after the village affairs. As village industries were prospering, the *panchayats* had good income. When the industries were ruined, the *panchayats* too got disintegrated and the villages became illiterate in no time. The few people who could receive some education migrated to the cities and villages became devoid of education, knowledge and wealth. As a result, their condition went on worsening. The villagers lost everything except land to

rely upon, and pressure on land increased considerably because of the destruction of village industries. Small peasants could not break even and were forced to borrow money from moneylenders and their lands were consequently lost to the moneylenders. Distribution of land became terribly skewed.

With the advent of British Raj, our old civilization crumbled. Earlier, there were village assemblies. *Panchayat* used to look after village affairs. As the word '*Panchayat*' denotes, it involved cooperation of all the five segments of the society (four varnas and those outside the varna system). That was a sort of communitarian scheme. Land belonged to the *panchayats* and peasants were allotted land for cultivation. The whole structure collapsed during the British Raj and money started ruling the roost in society.

In earlier days, people used to fulfil one another's needs. Money was not at all involved in such transactions. Carpenter, washerman, barber—all these used to work for the peasants all the year round. There was no question of measuring the work they did, and paying them accordingly. Instead, everyone's share in the agricultural produce was fixed. If the production were less, everyone received less; if more, everyone received more. Thus, both joys and sorrows of the peasants were shared by all. Today, if someone is miserable, he alone is miserable. The society does not share his misery. Likewise, if someone becomes happy, he alone becomes happy. The society does not become happy. If the society does not share the misery and happiness of individuals, it is not at all a society in the true sense of the word.

The British surveyed the whole of India. They surveyed every village to find out how it could be exploited in the interest of British trade. That set in motion the process of exploitation of India. Rural life was ruined. There was no one to think of the village as a

whole. Lands of good quality came under cash crops. Money became the only consideration.

Freedom from market

I desire that raw materials produced in the villages should be processed there. Every village should become self-sufficient. Only then will the independence of the country be strengthened.

I want to warn you that you cannot stand against the market forces, if you do not establish gram-swaraj. And gram-swaraj can be established on the foundation of gramdan alone.

If the villagers cultivate only that much cotton which they need for their clothing, and make their own cloth, they would be saved from market fluctuations in the prices of cotton and cloth. This is true about other commodities also.

Return for agricultural produce is subject to the vagaries of monsoon as well as those of the market. If rains fail and yields fall, the peasants suffer; and if rains are adequate and the yields are good, they still suffer as market rates fall. If the peasant were to save himself from the vagaries of both the weather and the market, there are three remedies. First, irrigation facilities will have to be created. There should not be dependence on monsoon only. Secondly, village should have stocks of grains sufficient for two years. Only the surplus produce should be sold. And thirdly, our dealings should be above board, so that we could have the grace of the Lord. If we do these three things, we will be saved.

Village self-sufficiency is the panacea for saving ourselves from the tyranny of market. Let me give an example. We started wearing khadi in 1920. Since then, we have not bought cloth; not even khadi. We ourselves cultivated cotton in our ashram, spun yarn and wove the

cloth. We used the cloth that we had made, so we did not have to spend a single pie on cloth. The field was ours and so was the labour. We used to plant the cottonseed extracted in the previous year. We had, therefore, no idea of the fluctuation in the rates of cotton goods. The rates were said to have skyrocketed during the last World War (1939-45). Cloth was rationed for some time. People faced difficulties in getting adequate cloth. But we did not have to suffer. We never knew what the market rates were. If the villagers thus become self-sufficient through collective efforts, they would be saved from the clutches of the market to a significant extent, if not completely, as some things like kerosene would have to be bought from outside. Of course, gobar-gas plant is a good option to provide lighting. We can thus try to achieve self-sufficiency to the extent possible. Some things may have to be bought, but we must be self-sufficient at least as regards the basic necessities of life.

Protection of villages

What can be produced in the villages should be produced there and industries should be established in the cities for the purpose of import-substitution. Today, our cities are being exploited by the foreigners and our villages are being exploited by the cities. If the city people stand against the foreign goods, boycott them and protect the village industries, there would be cooperation between the cities and the villages, and the country would be strengthened. Some industries should be reserved for the villages; otherwise, the villages would become deserted and the villagers would pounce upon the cities. What would then be the plight of the cities? Even the self-interest of the cities demands that they should protect the villages.

Every village should become like a fort. The villagers should resolve to purchase only locally made goods.

Swadeshi movement in the past

We had two swadeshi movements in the past sixty years (before 1956), yet we have not fully grasped the concept of swadeshi. The reasons must be probed.

The idea of swadeshi first arose not out of love for the country, but as a means for removing the foreign rule. It was thus negative, not positive, in nature. It is not that there was no element of love for the country, but the main idea was to use economic boycott of foreign goods as a weapon to overthrow the British rule. First, only British goods were boycotted, not all foreign goods. Thus, Japan benefited from our swadeshi movement. Next came the idea of boycotting all foreign cotton goods. It benefited Indian mills. They minted money and took the nation for a ride. In short, the movement did not build up the power of the people. It remained restricted mainly to the middle and upper middle class. The idea of swadeshi at that time was thus faulty. It did not have deep thinking behind it.

The second swadeshi movement took place in Gandhiji's time. Gandhiji had perceived the faults in the previous movement. Therefore, he emphasised the need for village industries and declared that only the products of village industries were cent per cent swadeshi. It implied that the mill products made here were also acknowledged as swadeshi to some extent; they were not totally repudiated. But the perspective was corrected. However, the political aspect remained. The idea was connected to the country's Independence also—and it was a major reason for its attraction to the people—and not just to rural reconstruction. Therefore, it spread widely with the freedom struggle. But many of its adherents had not accepted it as an economic idea. Gandhiji used to emphasise its economic aspect, but the Congress, his main instrument, was not fully convinced about this aspect.

Congress leaders would often wonder what charkha (spinning wheel) had to do with independence. How could we gain independence through spinning? Was it some kind of a charm? It was difficult to realize that swaraj would not be attained through sword. But we did not have sword, so we swallowed this postulate. But it was difficult to understand that cotton yarn would lead us to swaraj. Yet many people took to the spinning wheel as a means for mass contact. Mass contact is always essential in a freedom struggle.

There was one more thing. Khadi work was useful in fanning discontent against the British. The people could be told about poverty etc. It was true that the British were responsible for the country's poverty. But the idea of using charkha to arouse anti-British sentiments was faulty. The result was that the people, who had accepted charkha for this purpose, felt that the role of the charkha was over after the attainment of Independence.

Swadeshi: a righteous duty

Gandhiji had taught us that just as truth is a righteous duty, nonviolence is a righteous duty, using the products made by our neighbours gladly is also such a duty. When we covet a distant thing, neglecting what is near, it is not love but material gain that we have in mind. If we have compassion, we would consider it a duty to remove the misery of people around us. Gandhiji tried to impress on us that swadeshi is a law of life, a sacred duty; it is a philosophy of life. We are yet to grasp this fully. Consequently, the idea of swadeshi has almost vanished in Independent idea.

Not self-reliance, but reliance on one another

I do not wish to blame anyone. It is not individual who is to be blamed. Incomplete understanding of ideas gives rise to flaws. If we want a nonviolent social order, we will have to understand some basic issues. Otherwise,

our activities would foment violence even though we may have nonviolence on our lips. One of the prerequisites for nonviolence is that communities should not put their burden on others; they should shoulder their own responsibility at the local level. We can call this the principle of self-reliance. Secondly, economic equality is essential.

Actually, we, the followers of sarvodaya, do not believe in the principle of self-reliance; we believe in the principle of reliance on one another. But it is of two types: one is that between able-bodied individuals, and the other is that between disabled individuals. You have eyes, ears, legs, everything; so I have. If we join hands and cooperate with each other, that will be reliance of able-bodied individuals on one another. But if you have eyes, but not ears and I have ears, but not eyes, cooperation between us would be dependence on disabled individuals on one another. This is prevalent today. Scriptures call this 'cooperation between the lame and the blind'.

The principle of self-reliance is restrictive. We do not, therefore, talk of self-reliance. We stand for mutual dependence; but the mutual dependence that we want is between able-bodied individuals. Everyone is equipped with all the organs. God has given intelligence to every being. Had he kept the stock of intelligence in a bank, what would have happened? People in need of intelligence would have been required to send a message to God and He would have to rush to give intelligence to the needy! What would have been the plight of God then? But He has given intelligence to all, and can sleep peacefully in the ocean of milk!²⁴ He has ordered the

24. Lord Vishnu is said to lie in the ocean of milk, resting on the cobra Shesh.

things so perfectly that some people even doubt His existence! He has made a perfectly decentralised arrangement.

The meaning of swadeshi

We do stand for mutual cooperation. If the soil in our area is not suitable for producing wheat, we will not insist on sowing wheat, nor will we seek to have wheat in our daily diet. Occasionally we may buy wheat from outside, if we so desire. The point is that we should not become a burden on others as far as basic necessities of life are concerned. This is what a nonviolent social order calls for, and this is what swadeshi means.

Trade with outsiders is not completely ruled out in a swadeshi order. It has quite a good scope. But the goods that can be produced in the villages should be produced in the villages themselves. Cloth is manufactured in mills in urban areas. But where is cotton produced? In the villages. So, why should not cloth be made in the villages? What is the sense in taking cotton to the cities and bringing cloth to the villages? What can easily be produced in villages or village clusters should be produced there. I will not insist on manufacturing watches in India at any cost. Switzerland is doing that well. Of course, I would not like people to wear wristwatches unnecessarily.

Adulteration has become a menace in the world. Even drugs are not free from it. This is a dangerous situation. This is the height of callousness. This happens because we do not follow swadeshi.

There is nothing wrong in taking help from one another whenever necessary. But we should do our work ourselves as far as possible. We should produce as many necessary goods as we can and get only the rest from others. The point is, we should be motivated by love and

compassion. Rejecting the goods made by our neighbours and preferring goods made far away betrays narrow self-interest and callousness.

There is no parochialism in swadeshi. We should be broad in our outlook. All human beings should be looked upon as our brothers/sisters. But we should tell them to take care of themselves. None of us is crippled. We do not stand for narrow self-reliance; we seek expansion of compassion.

The swadeshi movements so far have not been successful because the idea in its pure form was not impressed upon the people. It was Gandhiji alone, who put the idea of swadeshi in its pure form, without making any compromise.

We should love the whole world without harbouring any differences in the mind. We are world citizens. But we would serve our neighbourhood only. Swadeshi has two aspects: service to the neighbourhood and broad universal outlook in thinking.

Thus swadeshi has little place for parochial pride about caste, village, region, country or religion. Swadeshi should be purged of these things. If they persist, swadeshi is doomed. This is the pure vision of swadeshi, which we should place before the people.

The question of distribution

Disarmament is now being talked about. But it cannot take place if there is no plan for decentralised production.

Talking of disarmament only is insufficient. Sacrifice should be the universal basis for all endeavours. If disarmament is being sought, there should not be mass production at a few places. There should be decentralised production, and that should also be accompanied with immediate distribution of the produced goods. If there are big dams or big factories, their security becomes a major

concern. There should, therefore, be decentralised irrigation schemes. The method of production of wealth should be such that the distribution takes place simultaneously with production.

It is undoubtedly the duty of the government to make rural life self-sufficient to the extent possible. The matter is being delayed because the brains of our leaders are muddled. Many of them are often heard saying that the talk of distribution is meaningless unless production is increased first to a sufficiently high level. This is distorted thinking. To think of preferring production first is a mechanical way of thinking. Both production and distribution should proceed simultaneously.

Had there been no production, the question of distribution would not have arisen. But when even minimal production is taking place, the question of its distribution would have to be addressed. Even if there is great disparity in distribution, but the producers are getting more than the non-producers, although the latter are also getting something, that would have been a different matter. If the non-producers are getting much more than the producers, but the latter are also getting something, that too would have counselled patience. But the present condition just cannot be tolerated. In such a situation, raising the question whether increasing production is more important or distribution is more important is senseless; it is even harmful.

If we do not think of simultaneous production and distribution, and think of increasing production first, we are likely to adopt such methods of production, which would later make equal distribution impossible. The implements of production should be such that equal distribution would occur simultaneously with the production. Implements used in village industries are of such type. They appear to work slowly; but in reality, it

is our impatience, which slows down our work.

In our family, we do not think of increasing production first and feed the family members later. Nor do we think of feeding some members first and some members later. Why should then we think differently as regards the society? Those who argue for increasing production first either subscribe to the capitalist ideas or are deluded by those ideas.

The question of defence

Just as a question is raised about the priority between production and distribution, a question is raised whether defence should have priority over production. Some people favour priority to defence. Liaquat Ali, Prime Minister of Pakistan (1950), recently declared, "We may have to go hungry, but we cannot neglect the defence of the country." This is a way of talking in a politically correct manner. What it really means is that the poor in the country would have to go hungry. By this logic, defence is all-important. Mechanised industries follow in its wake. Who is then going to care for village industries?

Science should be welcomed

East India Company destroyed indigenous industries with the help of machines. The history of East India Company and the history of the machine age are coterminous. Technology was used to destroy indigenous industries. But it was not inevitable. Technology can very well help in building small industries. Science can be used in establishing decentralised industries through improvement in the implements of production and a systematic plan for organisation of such industries. But the British were not concerned with the interests of society in India. Hence they used technology for destroying indigenous industries. As a result, there is a widespread misconception in India that small industries cannot survive

in the age of science; in fact, small industries can not only survive very well, but they can also be strengthened with the aid of science. In Europe too, decentralised industries did not survive, as the Europeans were keen on robbing India. Had colonialism not been there, European countries could have used science in establishing decentralised industries. But science was coupled with greed and subsequently with military and many countries were conquered.

Science and machines are not identical. Science can be used in establishing an order without mechanisation. It is a delusion to identify science with the age of machines. It is wrong to think that human life would become more complex because of science. Science can make human life complex, but it can also make it simple. It is for us to decide the direction of scientific progress. It is difficult to fathom what is hidden in the womb of science.

Today, science is an ally of capitalism. But if the need for decentralisation is felt tomorrow, the direction of science would change. Just as life becomes simple with spiritual progress, life will become simple with scientific progress also. Simplicity of life does not mean hardships and deprivation. Life should have elementary facilities, but they should be accompanied with simplicity.

We should not, therefore, neglect science. But I find our colleagues are neglecting science. They think that implements must be small: ordinary charkha is better than Ambar charkha, takli is better than an ordinary charkha, and fingers are better than takli! But this is not a right outlook. We certainly do not want increase in unemployment and disorder in society, but we should welcome scientific inventions. This is not happening. We concern ourselves more with superficial observance of some rules than with the propagation of our basic philosophy.

Problem of unemployment

I am not worried about land hunger; I am worried about hunger. People want food. In some countries, their governments give dole to the unemployed, as all cannot get employment in mechanised industries. Our (Indian) government cannot do so, because it is the poor's government. Village communities should, therefore, undertake the responsibility to provide work to all. To eliminate hunger, everyone should be given work. And land is the most important means for this. Of course, agriculture has to be supplemented with village industries.

Even if all are given land, all of us would not be happy. In many villages, per capita availability of land is one acre or less. How can one acre of land provide all the basic necessities of life? Supplementary industries are thus a must. Land can at best enable one to survive; but for prosperity, industries are necessary.

Today, discontent is widespread. If often finds expression in violence on the grounds of religion, ethnicity or language. But it is unemployment that is at the root of it. Something needs to be done to alleviate it. How to go about it? We should not think in terms of any temporary expedient. The scheme of alleviation of unemployment should be an integral part of social life. The problem calls for vigilance on a regular basis.

The raw materials produced in the villages should be processed there. Mill cloth should not be allowed to enter the villages; only khadi should be there. Finished goods should be manufactured where raw materials are produced and they should be consumed in the villages themselves—This is the only permanently valid formula for alleviating unemployment. If we go in for a temporary measure, its effect will also be temporary and the problem will persist.

Destruction of village industries

It is a matter of great misfortune that village industries were systematically ruined. The British, of course, did it, but the process continued in Independent India as well. Sugar mills were started, whereby jaggery industry was finished. Mills for polishing rice were started and home polishing stopped. In this way, village industries were destroyed, and are being destroyed. Many native states in Assam were merged in India after Independence. It was a good development, but it opened up the market there to outside traders and the local people lost the protection they had enjoyed so far. The market for the products of village industries therefore went on shrinking. Protests against this were in vain. In Rajasthan too, native states were integrated in India. But, as a result, *ghee* became a rare commodity and the market was flooded with vegetable *ghee*. We are witnessing many such developments.

The process is going ahead with alarming speed. The government's help to khadi and village industries to stem the tide is appallingly negligible. Millions are being spent on centralised industries, while a few thousands are provided for khadi and village industries. The villagers themselves will have, therefore, to gird up their loins. They should not be dependent on the governments; they should prepare their own plans. Trying to curry favours with ministers and bureaucrats for a few crumbs will take us nowhere.

A new fad has taken hold of the policy-makers (1958)—powerlooms. The government is going to spend money to kill the age-old art of hand-weaving, for whose development the government did not have to spend a single pie! Millions will be thrown out of work when looms begin to be operated by electric power. Mills could not kill the handlooms, but the powerlooms will. The

government is thus strangulating village industries with one hand and giving aid to khadi and village industries with the other hand. It does not find any contradiction in this!

Village industries and nonviolence

Village industries is an essential component of a nonviolent plan. Nonviolence without village industries is like a river without water. I will put it this way: (i) Nonviolence will always be accompanied with village industries, (ii) Non-violence will not exist without village industries. However, it will be wrong to say that village industries will be invariably accompanied with nonviolence.

Construction of roads

Approach roads to villages are not in good condition. Many people are unhappy about this. The urban people say that good roads are the first step of development, and the credulous villagers nod in agreement! But will it be good for the villagers? Good roads do add to convenience. But of whom? It makes easier for the urban people to come to villages and loot them. With motorable roads, the village industries which are somehow surviving will breathe their last.

They say, "We will not make you unemployed. We will give you many other jobs. Why do you spin or polish rice? Why do you grind grains and extract oil? Construct roads. So many roads need to be constructed in India. If you construct roads, traders will not have difficulty in moving from one village to another. Doctor from cities will come to your village and treat you." The villagers are being told such things. But are these in the interest of the villagers?

Roads would, in any case, be constructed, sooner or later. But if the villagers remain alert, no one would be able to harm them. They should never let the village industries slip from their hands.

Not a temporary measure

As long as raw materials produced in the villages are not processed there, construction of roads and similar measures are bound to prove to be means of exploitation. It is to the processing industries that we should pay attention on priority. It must not be thought that promoting village industries is a temporary measure. The capitalists are telling the government, "You may promote village industries, but they are not going to last long." Thus, the capitalists are opposed to village industries, and on the other hand, the thinking of the protagonists of village industries is also befuddled. Many of them too consider village industries a measure for the immediate present only. But this is a misconception. Land to man ratio is going to go on falling; therefore, village industries will necessarily have a permanent place in the economy of this country.

Just as agriculture cannot be dispensed with, village industries too cannot be dispensed with, at least in India. In countries where population is less compared to the available land, machines may be used in agriculture. But in India, where population is more and land is less, one cannot think of mechanisation of agriculture, nor can one think of dispensing with village industries.

Just as agriculture is an integral part of people's lives, village industries are also an integral part, at least in India. There are only two options. One is that the government should disallow opening of new mills, as village industries cannot compete with them, and protect village industries. But this is not happening. So, the villages should resolve to make their own plan. They should have nothing to do with the plans forced from above. This is what people's power means.

Population is increasing and land-man ratio is falling; so availability of work in agriculture would decline. Will

the villagers then go to the cities en masse? Will the urban people welcome them? The villagers will not even get there a roof on their heads., not to speak of properly ventilated houses. They will fall prey to bad habits. Those who cannot bring their families along may even become licentious. The very idea of migrating to the cities is wrong. Work has to be found in the villages. And there is no alternative to village industries in this regard.

Improvement in Implements

Of course, it is necessary to improve the implements of production, and we have been engaged in it for the last twenty-five years (before 1956). Ambar Charkha is the fruit of experiments done for many years. But Ambar Charkha need not kill ordinary charkha and takli.

We do want improved instruments, which reduce human labour. But depriving a person of his instruments of production is quite different from improving the implements. If someone tells me that the sword in my hand is not of use in these days and I should have a pistol instead, I would certainly agree to it. But if he takes away my sword and does not give me pistol, and keeps it with himself, I will certainly be worse off. Pistol is decidedly better than sword. But is pistol in your hand is better than sword in my hand? Similarly, if I get a better charkha, it is fine; but if my present charkha is taken away from me and you have a better implement, can it be called improvement in my position?

Let no one be under the illusion that people will have to work more in the sarvodaya scheme. Sarvodaya is all for improvement in the implements. Its only condition is that they should be in the hands of peasants.

Systematic plan is necessary

Village industries cannot survive in isolation. There has to be a systematic plan by the villagers. Individual

efforts, in themselves, will hardly suffice. But to have a village plan made by all the villagers, elimination of inequality is a precondition. Equal distribution of land is necessary for the purpose. We can put it this way: (i) The village cannot prosper without village industries, (ii) Village industries cannot survive without a systematic plan, (iii) A systematic plan for the village cannot be made unless there is an institution of the village (gramsabha), and (iv) Such an institution cannot have acceptance unless there is equal distribution of land.

The peasant will have the taste of swaraj only when cloth is produced in every village like food grains, village industries produce other necessary goods, houses are built from local materials and implements necessary for work are also made at the village level.

The question of housing

I have mentioned building of houses here; it is worth giving a thought. Houses were essential for the refugees of Partition (1947-48), but no one was paying attention to the question of providing shelter to them, as our engineers could not think of constructing mud houses. When I carried out an experiment in this regard, it was found that the clay there was very good for this purpose. I have seen mud houses in Bihar. They last long in spite of heavy rains. But our Western education has made us incapable of comprehending simple things. When the question of housing comes up, it is cement which appears before our eyes.

I find tin sheets over houses an abominable sight. It is a common sight in Assam. I had talks with two state ministers. One of them told me, "If we speak against tin sheets, we would not get votes in elections, as everyone here demands tin sheets." But tin sheets have a bad effect on health. Their only advantage is that they are durable; one need not have to worry about roofing every year. But

this is a consideration which makes us lethargic. Government provides tin roofs to government schools in villages; and that becomes a model and everyone starts demanding tin sheets. Once, in Assam, I visited the hut of a poor woman. I asked her what she wanted. I had thought that she would ask for land; but no! she wanted tin sheets!

Aid of science

It is nearly impossible to provide work to all without the aid of science. But science is not capable of reducing exploitation. Reduction of exploitation needs a plan, which people have to formulate. Planning should be based on nonviolence and it should be coupled with science; only then will sarvodaya become a possibility.

India has a long tradition of spirituality; sarvodaya takes full benefit of science also. No ideology is more compatible with science than sarvodaya. If science progresses without sarvodaya, it will give importance to individual and destroy communities. Power will then get concentrated in the hands of a few selfish persons or groups. Capitalists developed science a lot, but it did not prove to be beneficial; rather, it exacerbated conflicts. But it is not science which should be blamed for this; it is because it has become an instrument in the hands of a few.

Science should be harnessed for the betterment of human life. Scientists should engage themselves in the invention of things necessary for people's lives.

Technology resulted in exploitation in the beginning. But I feel it has a place in the cosmic plan. It has sought to free man from labour. Industrialisation has many flaws, but it has certain positive features also, which we should be ready to acknowledge and adopt. Only then can we move ahead. We should see how we can derive benefit from it.

Discretion about machinery

I am not opposed to all machines. Machines are of three types: (1) Time-saving (2) Destructive and (3) Productive.

Time-saving machines neither produce nor destroy anything; they only save time. For example, motor car, railway, aeroplane. We want such machines within proper limits. I walk on foot, yet I want improvement in such machines. They should be used whenever really necessary. Bicycle is there for the aid of legs, not to replace legs. So, it should not be used where it is possible to walk.

Destructive machines like guns, bombs have absolutely no place in nonviolence. We do not want such machines.

As far as productive machines are concerned, they are of two types: complementary and injurious. Some machines help man, while some debilitate him, snatch his employment, stunt his intellectual development and deprive him of the joy in life. The former kind of machines is complementary, while the latter one is injurious. We want complementary machines, not the injurious ones.

But it cannot be decided once and for all which machine is complementary and which is injurious. It depends on time and place. In a country where there is large population and a machine is depriving many of their employment, that machine is injurious. But the same machine may not be so where population is less and work to be done is more. In India, tractors will inevitably increase unemployment; so they are injurious. But they may not be so in Russia and U.S.A. We, therefore, do not want to permanently brand any machine as injurious or complementary. We will use machines looking to their usefulness and appropriateness. Efficiency cannot be a criterion in all situations. We will have to exercise

discretion in adopting machines. There need not be any sort of attachment to the machines, nor should there be any aversion for them. We are not afraid of machines. What we want is that machines should be in the hands of man, not vice versa.

These days, division of labour is an accepted principle. It is said that a person should do a single work all through his life, whereby his efficiency and skill would get enhanced. But I do not buy this argument. If man is in the hands of machine, the vitality of his life will be sapped. Work should be enjoyable. There is no point in making one do uninteresting work during the day and 'supply' artificial entertainment in the form of films at night. One should have joy for twenty-four hours a day.

Every productive activity is done with the aid of five fingers. Of course, implements are needed to help them, but they should be secondary. A secondary thing should not take the place of a primary thing. It should not be given more importance than the primary thing. Will it do if bicycle becomes more important than legs and spectacles become more important than eyes? We must keep discriminating intellect intact. Implements cannot do anything without the organs. A telescope may be necessary to see the planets, but it cannot be more important than the eyes, as it cannot do anything without the eyes. The implements have their own importance, but they have a role subsidiary to the organs.

In a big country like India, we cannot insist on either village industries or mechanised industries exclusively. We will have to exercise discretion. Productive activities will have to be divided between these two sectors, demarcating the boundaries. Some areas should be reserved for village industries, while some may be entrusted to mechanised industries. Without a balanced approach, we will not be able to move ahead in this age of science.

Five fingers

In village industries, five factors are essential like five fingers of the hand.

The first finger is the researchers. Without them, village industries will be doomed to failure. Khadi and village industries have progressed because of new inventions. The class of researchers should, therefore, increase.

The second finger is the workers. Since years, workers have been working, but their number is insignificant. There should at least be one worker for every five thousand persons in the population.

The third finger is those engaged in the dissemination of thought. There is a comprehensive philosophy behind khadi and village industries. To propagate this philosophy, we need a large contingent of those devoted to its spread.

The fourth finger is the government. It too has a role. Presently the government's thinking lacks clarity. It can become helpful to the extent its thinking gains clarity.

The fifth finger is the people. It is the most important finger. People have to be educated in this regard, and that is what I have been doing. Village industries should receive protection from the people. They should have the people's will behind them. That is what gramdan seeks.

Just as we boycotted foreign goods during the freedom struggle and encouraged swadeshi products, we have to pay attention to the production of those goods in the villages, which can be made there, and boycott outside goods. To decide about the import in and export from the village through consensus and thereby regulate them is a fundamental right of the village.

The question of motive power

I am not against electricity. The only condition is that it should not make muscle power of humans and animals idle. If bullocks have full work, electric power may be used as per need. Electricity should not be used for the work which human beings can do. It can do work, which is beyond their capacity.

We want to give relief to the poor on priority basis. But electricity will first benefit the rich, then the middle class, and the poor will be the last to benefit from it. Distribution of electricity is, therefore, of crucial importance. Any kind of power should not be the monopoly of a few; that would make it a means of exploitation. This is what we are opposed to.

If electricity reaches a village, it should be of use to the village as a whole, not to some individuals only. The whole village should derive benefit from it. It should not cause exploitation within the village, nor should it become a means of exploiting other villages.

Any kind of power should not be individually owned. It should be owned by the whole village community and used for balanced development. I am not saying that electricity should not be used at all if it does not reach all the villages; but if it is going to reach the villages in a phased manner, it should reach those places first where the standard of living is the lowest. Thus, it should first reach the tribal hamlets in Odisha, and not Mumbai. Then only it will be beneficial to the last man.

9. Khadi

The purpose

A supplementary occupation is a must for the villagers. It can be nothing else than producing finished goods from the raw materials available in the villages.

There is unemployment even in advanced industrial countries. They have to give dole to millions of the unemployed. The governments in those countries consider it their duty to give such a dole. Can this policy be followed in the whole world? The countries which exploit other countries can afford to do so. But it is practically impossible to give dole to millions in India, even if we want.

The problem of underemployment is worse than that of unemployment. Peasants should have an occupation in which they can engage whenever they have spare time and which they can leave the moment they are required to resume agricultural work. Charkha (spinning wheel) can be plied even for a few minutes, whenever there is spare time. Such an occupation is essential for the Indian agriculturist.

Gandhiji was in search of a measure that could provide relief to the last man expeditiously. Through this search, he discovered the charkha. A drowning man has to be rescued right away; that cannot be postponed. The poorest need schemes designed solely for them, and that too, urgently. Khadi is such a scheme.

Clothing is the first and the foremost basic need of human beings; even food comes next. Clothing not only protects us from cold, it also protects our modesty. Protection from cold is a physical necessity, but covering our nakedness has a cultural dimension; it is a mark of humanity. One can starve, but one cannot go naked.

Cotton produced in India is usually of short staple. It is not of much use to textile mills. It has, therefore, to be exported and long-staple varieties of cotton have to be imported at huge cost. Often, they are in shortage. The question of transportation is also there. Many intermediaries are involved in this process. Khadi saves us from all these difficulties. Charkha can spin finer yarn with double the count than the mills from the same variety of cotton. Charkha can use short-staple varieties of cotton produced in India.

Suppose the world war starts and textile centres like Mumbai and Ahmedabad are bombarded. The labourers in mills would then run away to their villages. But if spinning is taught to every child in the country, the country will be saved in such a situation.

I am of the firm opinion that with the expertise we have gained so far, the requirement of clothing of India's villages can easily be met within two years, if we take to the spinning wheel.

Distinctive features

There is a world of difference between the old spinning wheel and the one we are seeking to introduce. The wheel in the past had no adversary pitted against it; people had to spin perforce to cover their bodies. Our charkha is different. It is the harbinger of a new age. The present age is called the 'age of machines'. When we seek to revive charkha in such a situation, we are unfurling a banner of revolt against the dominant ideology of the age. The place of charkha in our philosophy and world-view is, therefore, unique. For us, it symbolises nonviolence.

Charkha is a simple instrument, easy to operate. It requires little exertion to operate it. One can spin everywhere, even in a train. A child or a weak or an ailing man can also spin. Everyone can thus contribute to the production and generation of wealth. Substantial

production can take place without any fanfare. The entertainment and other benefits that spinning provides are added advantages.

Charkha has been found to have a healing effect also.

Charkha symbolises dignity of labour and commitment to labour. Exploitation has its roots in the will to live on others' labour. If everyone puts in labour, exploitation would cease to exist.

Khadi is certainly viable economically. Mill cloth appears cheaper because it hides several costs and also causes exploitation. That khadi can generate employment in other sectors like milk-production and oil-pressing is also a factor to be reckoned.

You have water taps in your house. But can they equal the raindrops in their utility? Raindrops may be small, but they fall everywhere. This is the beauty of charkha too. It can generate a little wealth in every home. Proper distribution of wealth is the most important principle in economics. More fairly the wealth is distributed, better it is for the society. Khadi brings about distribution of wealth on a wide scale. It benefits all, albeit to a small degree. Khadi has the divine quality of extensiveness like the raindrops.

The question of implements

The implements necessary for spinning, weaving etc. should be such as could be made and repaired in the villages by the village artisans from the materials which are locally available in sufficient quantities. This is the first requisite.

The second question is that of speed. The experiments to increase the speed of spinning will, of course, be limited by the capacity of our hands. If we go beyond this limit, we will enter the domain of machines. To go from implements to machines would be regression, not

progress. Implements should be within our control. So, although we should try to increase the speed of the implements as far as possible, we should never forget this aspect. Rather than speed, we should pay attention to the excellence and strength of the yarn. Our concern should be to augment the skills of the hands.

The third point is simplicity. Simpler the implements, more the scope for human skills. Look at our implements for cooking. They are so simple that everyone can easily cook. Another example is the pen. Everyone can write with the pen. Implements should be simple and useful for all.

The fourth point is what I call '*atma-darshan*'. I mean by it the generation of surplus equivalent to the cost of the implement. We should see how much time the generation of such surplus takes. A takli can recover its cost within eight hours. Thus, the takli's time for '*atma-darshan*' is a single day. A machine may cost thousands of rupees and take as much as a year to recover its cost. I will, therefore, consider a takli more efficient. '*Atma-darshan*' is one of the tests for the efficiency from the point of view of capital investment. Our implements should take as less time as possible for the recovery of their costs.

Maintenance becomes more and more difficult with increase in the number of spare parts. Implements should not have complicated and complex mechanisms. They should be such as could be easily understood by ordinary people. There is beauty in simplicity and trouble in complexity.

In short, our implements should be capable of being locally made, simple, easy to operate and able to recover their costs in as less time as possible. They should enhance the skill of our hands and should also help our mental growth.

I have applied my mind to make khadi acceptable to all. I do not disfavour experiments to increase the speed of spinning. But the experiments being done these days betray a defeatist mentality. We appear to think that the speed of the present implements is the main factor prohibiting the spread of khadi. This results in the loss of faith in the implements we now have and poses a danger to khadi.

Thirty six years after the discovery of charkha by Gandhiji (in 1920), Ambar Charkha has made its appearance. I find in it confluence of science and nonviolence. Its yarn is reasonably strong and its speed is fairly good. With its help, we can clothe the entire country with khadi.

Ambar Charkha is sufficient

Some people ask what is wrong if implements which could produce two or three times more than the Ambar Charkha are made and they are driven by electricity?

It is like asking why we should not go on adding salt to a vegetable, as a little salt adds to the taste of the vegetable! In our present condition, Ambar Charkha is sufficient for us. Any improvement in it should be done in the context of the situation in the countryside. It should be possible to repair this charkha in the village itself.

Now, Ambar Charkha with sixteen spindles has been developed. If we accept this charkha, why not accept the mill itself? When I approved of Ambar Charkha, some people had warned me that it might kill the ordinary charkha; there would be a tendency to increase its efficiency and it might be connected to electricity—many such things would happen, to our ultimate detriment. But I am for co-existence of both the kinds of charkha. Weaving could be done with warp of Ambar yarn and woof of the yarn of old charkha. There is a vision behind

this stand. If we go on increasing the number of spindles mindlessly, we would go astray. It should also be taken into account that the yarn would break more often, if the number of spindles is more. So, production would not be directly proportional to the number of spindles.

The maximum number of spindles should be such that frequent repairing of the charkha is not necessitated. If we go on increasing the number of spindles to increase production and make khadi cheaper, that would not help the last man.

I feel that Ambar Charkha is sufficient for our purpose today. We should strive to make villages self-sufficient through it. Let the charkha with one or two spindles reach every home for individual self-sufficiency in cloth and let six-spindle charkhas be introduced in every village for village self-sufficiency in cloth.

If Ambar Charkha can keep the mill-made articles away from a peasant's life, it should be welcome. It is true that it lacks some of the good features in the ordinary charkha. There is no question of abandoning the latter. But if mills are closed and a decentralised order established, then Ambar Charkha has a place in such a scheme, along with ordinary charkha. The latter is necessary for utilizing leisure and as a means of worship. Ambar Charkha cannot be used for this purpose.

Village-oriented khadi

So far, we have concentrated on producing khadi by paying wages to the labourers and selling it in cities. This approach needs to be changed now. The present pattern would not take us ahead; the work would instead go downhill. Should we resign ourselves to gradual death of khadi or take the risk, which may hasten death, but may also give a new lease of life to it?

Now individual self-sufficiency and self-reliance of the

villages should become the focus. Gramsabha (assembly of all the adult villagers) should become the instrument for khadi work. Khadi work needs to be decentralised. It needs to be done in conjunction with gramswaraj. I have, therefore, presented the programme of village-oriented khadi (in 1963).

Some people think that production of khadi in a decentralised way and provision of employment are two different things. But it is not true. Village-oriented khadi would give employment on a far greater scale. It may initially appear that the work has suffered, but in the long run it would certainly pick up. In a war, one has to retreat at times, but it is for the sake of eventual advance.

Khadi would live on only if it is taken up as a part of the triple programme of Gramdan, Shanti-sena²⁵ and village-oriented khadi. Khadi work would give us an opportunity to come in contact with the spinners, which could be utilized to bring about change in their thinking and lives. If we are able to do this, we would lay the foundation for khadi and create our cells. Let khadi workers fan out to villages for this purpose. Let charkha enter gramdan villages and let the spirit of building up the community be developed in the villages where khadi work is being done. This will be a two-pronged attack. Till it succeeds, I am ready to accept commercial production of khadi. But such production should go on decreasing and the extent of self-sufficiency should go on increasing correspondingly.

25. Literally, peace corps. Vinoba had called for raising a corps with one worker for every 5000 persons. These peace-soldiers were expected to serve the people in peacetime, maintain peace and restore peace at the time of disturbances even at the cost of their lives.

I do not mind if Ambar Charkha is used for village self-sufficiency in cloth; and even if it is moved by electric power. The only condition is that it should not become a means of exploitation; it should mainly be used for the sake of self-sufficiency. Cloth so produced must not be sold outside the village. I have termed such cloth '*Lok-vastra*' (people's cloth). If a village can become self-sufficient in cloth, it would lead to the formation of village community. If this could happen, this would mean that the people have taken over one function of the State and have contributed to the withering away of the State to that extent; in other words, the State would be freed from one of its worries and would be able to concentrate more on the security of the country. The scheme has such a revolutionary potential.

Polyster khadi is not Gandhiji's khadi. I can never give my consent to it. Taking the help of mills is bound to be detrimental to khadi.²⁶

26. The subject has been presented here in brief as Vinoba's book on khadi is available, which the interested readers may refer to: Vinoba, Khadi: the banner of our revolt (Pavnar: Paramdham Prakashan, 2018).

10. Industry and Trade

Industries for women

The urban people are snatching away industries from villages. In the same way, men are snatching away the occupations which hitherto belonged to women. Wherever weaving has been mentioned in the Vedas, feminine gender has been used. In English, man is called 'husband', that is, agriculturist; and woman is called 'wife', that is, weaver. However, men took over weaving in the course of time, and only secondary work was allotted to women. Similarly, women used to do sewing, but after the invention of sewing machine, the work was taken over by men. The jobs that women have been doing should, in fact, remain in the hands of women. Those should be reserved for them. It will add to their independent standing. Otherwise, they will always have to remain dependent on men.

Categorisation of industries

Some industries can be run by individuals, while some are cottage industries and some are village industries. Some industries can be taken up by clusters of villages. For example, tanning cannot be viable at the village level, but 20-25 villages together can undertake tanning.

If industries are categorised as individual, cottage, village, village cluster, urban and national industries and their areas clearly demarcated, villages can hold on against machines.

Sarvodaya believes that the jobs that can be done in the homes should be done there—like cooking and spinning; the basic necessities of life like oil and shoes should be produced at the village level, while big industries like steel, coal etc. should be owned by society, not by individuals.

In one village, constructive work was going on. A gentleman opened a flour mill there. The worker kept on explaining the benefits of home-grinding, but no one paid any heed to him. I asked him, "When the flour mill had anyway entered the village, why did it not occur to you to have the mill owned by the village, rather than an individual?"

Incentive to work

Big industries, where thousands work, must not be in the hands of a few individuals. It is dangerous. Some people contend that individuals would not apply themselves fully to the enterprise if they do not own it. If this is the case, it is a sign of moral decay. All religions say that the work one has to do for society should be done with full commitment. It is wrong to assume that people would not be motivated to render service or increase production without selfish motive. Such is not the human nature. I believe that a human being is motivated more by the spirit of sacrifice than by self-interest. The only thing that needs to be done is to extend the spirit of sacrifice from family to the entire village community.

Private and public sector

It is asked whether we support nationalization of industries. In fact, we had supported this measure long back. Sarvodaya plan has been published. It has been stated therein that big factories and mines should be owned by the nation.

But nationalisation need not prove to be very beneficial. Has not the government already has immense powers? It is not properly using them. What is the use of giving it more powers? Without persons of integrity, nothing will be successful. Corruption is already rampant. More powers to bureaucracy would worsen the situation. Purification of thinking process and character of the people are needed.

People talk of growth of public sector and reduction of private sector in the economy. I say that public sector should be 100% and private sector should also be 100%. In sarvodaya, there is no difference between the two. The work that is done by the hands is done by the fingers, and what is done by the fingers is done by the hands. There need not be any conflict between the two.

Whatever may the sector be, there should be participation of labourers in the running of industry.

Duty of the labour movement

I urge the labourers to work honestly. Work is worship. They should increase the production as much as possible. These days, people talk of reducing working days and working hours. It is wrong. I am of the opinion that one should not do the same work continuously, but one must work for eight hours a day. If the labourers have to oppose the owners, they may do anything that does not harm production. If the labourers are honest and sincere, they can do satyagraha against the owners in an effective way. Commitment to duty would generate moral strength in them, and it would have effect on the owners, on the government, as well as on the society. Labourers should act in such a way that their interests are well served without hampering production.

Do the trade unionists want the good of the labourers or do they want to derive political advantage for their party? This is the question. Communists made the beginning in linking trade union work to politics. This is not their fault. This is their principle. They want to strengthen themselves politically through control on the labourers. Because they think in this manner, other parties also follow suit. All parties want to exploit the misery of labourers for political gains. But trade unions linked to political parties will never benefit the labourers. Labourers should keep away from them and form a single non-

political organisation, which will not have to fight at all; its very presence will be sufficient.

I want cooperation between the trade unions and the gramdan movement. Gramdan movement is working for the betterment of the rural labourers, while trade unions work mostly among the labourers in mills in urban areas. If the latter go on strike, other labourers take their place. But after gramdan, labourers in villages would not be able to go to the cities without permission from the gramsabha. Factories will have to approach the gramsabhas to get labourers. Gramsabha can stipulate conditions. It will increase the bargaining power of the labourers.

As far as strikes are concerned, labourers certainly have the right to go on strike. But it has to be seen whether it is a duty also. I can go to Delhi; I have right to do so. But I will have to see whether it is also my duty to go to Delhi. Secondly, when essential services are involved, a step like strike must not be taken in haste. Sympathy of society should be secured first. Grievances should be expressed without stopping work.

Some people think that conflicts lead to progress. They do not know the ground realities in India. Here conflicts will have to be solved through love—and I believe that this is possible. Arbitration by non-partisan and respected persons is one way. It should not be difficult to find such persons.

Dignity of trade

In our country, trade has not been considered only a worldly occupation; it has a spiritual dimension as well. All religions in the world have said that business should be conducted honestly. Need for honesty and truthfulness has always been accepted, but it is only in this country that business is considered a righteous occupation, which should be dutifully followed. Scriptures have said that the

vaishyas should carry out business as a duty.

It has been said that a vaishya conducting business with detachment and the spirit of service would attain spiritual liberation like the one who studies the Vedas with detachment and absorption. Everyone knows that if a businessman is honest, people would trust him and the business would earn handsome profit. But it is only Hindu dharma, which says that such a businessman would attain spiritual liberation also. This is a unique idea. It gives equal weight to different forms of service to society. The businessmen enjoyed such a high respect in India, and a great responsibility has been assigned to them.

Business and non-possession

It is the duty of a businessman to conduct business, not to make money. Business presently results in accumulation of money, because of the nature of the present social order. But a business need not invariably result in the accumulation of money. The Gita has said that trade is a moral duty for the vaishya (varna-dharma) (18.44); she has not said that accumulation of money is their moral duty. Non-possession is a vow for all sections of society and is, therefore, applicable to the businessmen also. Moreover, immoral ways cannot be accepted. It cannot be said that you may make money in whatever manner and then utilize it in the spirit of trusteeship. And when immoral ways are rejected, accumulation automatically gets curtailed.

As trade is considered a moral duty, there should neither be excessive profit nor loss in it. A trader should get only the reasonable return for his labours. More than reasonable profit should not be there, nor should there be loss, as it would be a reflection of negligence in the performance of duty.

Agriculture, service of cows and trade are noted as the occupations of the vaishyas. As agriculture and service of cows are primary needs of all the people, most of the vaishyas should be engaged in them. Trade is a secondary occupation, which can have a role only after production. Production is the main work; exchange is subordinate. Vaishyas naturally cannot expect to earn more than the agriculturists, who are primary producers. If one says that the traders have to use their intellect more and should, therefore, earn more, this contention cannot be proved. It cannot be said that exchange needs more intelligence than production. Besides, everyone's basic necessities of life are the same.

However, true vaishyas have become extinct in India. Vaishyas only assist the agriculturists, yet they are richer than the latter. How can there be respect for the traders in such a situation? Today, traders appear to be intent on duping the customers. Once someone observed that black market was thriving in India, whereupon I commented that I was unhappier about the 'white' market than the 'black' market!

Historical sin

Modern Indian history shows that traders were responsible for the establishment of British rule in India. It was the shortsightedness of the businessmen and their callous attitude towards the commonfolk that contributed to slavery. The higher castes, including the businessmen, were looking down upon the people; that is why British traders could establish themselves here. Indian traders were exploiting the people. Had there been cordial relations and mutual trust between the traders and others, had both of them followed their legitimate duties, the British would never have been able to get foothold here. The traders cared little for the production, the development of industries etc.

I have, therefore, appealed to the traders to engage themselves in serving the people. Trade, too, is a form of service. If they work with such a spirit, their trade would prosper and people's power would get built up.

Qualities of businessmen

In India, business communities are prominent among those who have eschewed non-vegetarian diet out of compassion. It is not an insignificant matter. It is a great experiment. This is the result of the trust reposed by the scriptures in the business community. The social order, particularly the economic order, has been so vitiated that a person becomes hardhearted, even against his will. This has happened to the businessmen also; yet they are fairly compassionate.

An important characteristic of businessmen is their organisational capacity. With this capacity and compassion, they can do much for the country.

Appeal to the businessmen

Businessmen should become fearless. Today, they have money, but they do not have weapons. Defence was supposed to be the duty of the kshatriyas. Businessmen are, therefore, the first to demand more army and police. It is my appeal to them to take up the work of Shantisena.

I do not expect only sampatti-dan from businessmen; I expect more from them. I want them to shoulder the responsibility of doing whatever is necessary for the success of bhoodan.

If businessmen rise to the occasion, they would rise in the estimation of people. In olden times, people used to go on pilgrimage, entrusting all their wealth to the care of businessmen without any written documentation. Such trust exists no more, because businessmen have lost the dignity that Hindu dharma had given to them.

I claim that my work is for the good of the rich and businessmen, as much as it is for the good of the poor. I have as much love for the rich as for the poor. If businessmen take up this (sarvodaya) work, they would become leaders of the society.

In gramdan, people have surrendered their ownership of land. The businessmen in gramdan villages should also make some sacrifice. First, they should refrain from adulteration. Money earned through deception can never do good to them. Secondly, they should lend money to the gramsabhas without charging interest. They should rather agree to get back less money.

Businessmen should never give donations to political parties. Does a trader quote different prices for the same thing to persons belonging to different political parties? Businessmen should serve all equally without any discrimination. There is, therefore, no point in giving donation to a particular party only. Some of them told me that such a step would be suicidal for them; they would be harassed, denied licences, and their businesses would come to a standstill. But I appeal to them to follow their moral duties even at the cost of life. They should cooperate in the building of people's power, rather than contributing to the strengthening of the State.

11. Agriculture : a *Brahmakarma*

Labour related to agriculture is the best among all the kinds of manual labour. It fulfils the most primary need of human beings. It fulfils the need of human mind as well. Plants, animals, birds, human beings—all these together constitute the great family of a farmer. The sweetness and the brotherliness that it engenders impart a divine quality to the agriculturist's life.

The vast expanse of the sky (*akash*) is the source of happiness; in fact, its availability defines happiness. *Sukha*, the Sanskrit word for pleasure, etymologically means easy and ample availability of *akash* (अ = easy, आ = *akash*). The Vedas say that life would be devoid of any charm in the absence of the delight that *akash* gives. One should never lose contact with *akash*. In agriculture, one gets such contact in generous measure. Everyone should, therefore, engage himself in agriculture for at least a short time. Everyone should get an opportunity for this.

Rootedness in land

Uprooting from the land is the most dangerous thing for a human being. Just as every tree is rooted in the land, every human being should also be so rooted. To sever a human being from the land is like uprooting a tree. I recently read about the prevalence of mental diseases in U.S.A. It is the consequence of severing the connection of human beings with land. Service to the land is an essential component of a perfect life.

One gets open air and sunlight while working in the fields; it makes one healthy. Farming gives mental joy and sharpens the intellect. Agriculture is the best means of devotion to the Lord. Peace and contentment in society depend on the proportion of people associated with agriculture, as they have opportunity for a fulfilling life. Everyone should, in this view, have at least one-fourth of

an acre, for a farm is a means of service and a source of knowledge.

I, therefore, desire that everyone should be connected with nature. It is essential for an ideal social order. If every individual works on the farm for four hours a day and enjoys clean air, sunlight, service of land as the mother and the songs of birds, he would feel invigorated. It would also ease the practice of brahmacharya. It is, therefore, a crime to keep anyone away from agriculture, just as it is a sin to prevent anyone from entering a temple. Vedas have ordained, कृषिमित् कृषस्व वित्ते रमस्व बहु मन्यमानः—‘One should do farming and consider what one gets from nature more than sufficient’. Let us realize that farming is everyman’s moral duty.

Participation by all

I have done weaving and several other activities for eight hours a day for the sake of research. But I would refuse to do any single work for eight hours every day. Four hours’ work in the fields and four hours’ other work is an ideal arrangement. In my scheme, everyone would do farming for some time. Even the Prime Minister should do it for say, one hour. One should at least grow vegetables and fruits. Some people say that production is less on small pieces of land. They do not have actual experience. I have done agricultural work for many years and know that production is more on such farms.

Development of qualities

In our society, different qualities have been developed in different classes. Such skewed distribution of qualities is perhaps everywhere in the world to some extent, but it is more marked in India. But everyone should imbibe all the qualities. Development of qualities should become universal. It is necessary for the creation of a strong society. I find that agriculture is an occupation which

facilitates development of all the qualities. It helps one identify with nature and with animals, inculcates willingness to cooperate and commitment to labour. It enhances practical skills also as it involves several activities like keeping the accounts.

Real production

Agriculture is verily a *Brahma-karma*, that is, a creative work. Economists call it a productive work, but that does not convey its full significance. ‘*Brahma-karma*’ is the most appropriate term for it. *Brahma-karma* means the act of Brahmadeva, the Creator. Production in nature is an act of the Creator. Currently, some occupations offer little scope for the broadening of mental horizon. But nature is generous. When we sow one seed, we reap thousands. This is not man’s doing. This is the work of God. Human beings are only instrumental in the process.

Suppose, I make a watch. It is my work. Of course, it is because of the intellect given to me by God, but watch-making is not God’s direct work. But what happens in a surgical operation? A doctor performs a surgery, but who heals the wounds? That is God’s doing. Similarly, in agriculture, one sows in a favourable climate—that is the only thing one does. Then one awaits the result. It is God, who makes thousands of grains out of a few. It is He, who causes rains. It is He, who makes the soil fertile. Agriculture is verily God’s work.

One comes in contact with Him while farming, and that is why it can lead to the development of all qualities.

Significance of agriculture

Human beings used to live on hunting. Violence was inevitable for them, just as it was for other animals in the jungle. It was in India that human beings discovered a way whereby they could get out of violence. This way was agriculture. We do not realize today its spiritual

import. But it was agriculture which produced hundreds of grains out of a handful of grains and enabled human beings to live as they pleased.

Agriculture is the foundation of morality. An agriculturist produces first and then consumes; he does not rob anyone. He does productive work and creates wealth. His conduct is thus inherently moral.

I say on the basis of my own experience that agriculture is the purest means of livelihood. Profiteering in trade is injurious to society. Paid employment makes one lose moral sheen. One of our proverbs expresses the same thing: it says that agriculture is the best occupation, next comes business, and employment comes in the last.

In India, revolution would not be brought about by factory workers; it would be a peasant revolution.

Development of agriculture

The genius in our peasants is far from ordinary. They have been farming reasonably well for thousands of years, even without any help from science. There is no doubt that they are hard-working. They do farming even in difficult terrains. They should be helped in every way. New knowledge should be given to them. Deficiencies in the land should be made up with the aid of science. It is science alone, which can help us in the provision of water, manures and seeds.

In the Sabhaparva of Mahabharata, there is an incident of Narad's meeting with King Yudhishtira. Narad asked several questions to the king; one of them was whether agriculture in his kingdom was dependent on rains only. The rainfall is bound to vary. Villages should plan, taking this fact in view. I propose that in every marriage, people should give the gift of a well to the bridegroom—dig well on his farm. If the bride's parents are poor, let others help them in this work.

Pandit Nehru called Bhakra Nangal dam a place of pilgrimage. I said that it would be a place of pilgrimage only if the beneficiaries gift one-sixth of land to the poor. The beneficiaries would not lose anything thereby, for their production is going to increase because of irrigation. Had the government stipulated such a condition, there would not have been the uproar, which the issue of betterment levy provoked in Punjab.

Composting provides good manure to the farms. People should be made acquainted with the techniques of composting.

For the development of Indian agriculture, ecological factors should be given due attention. Secondly, in the greed for more and more production, we should not erode the fertility of soil. That would harm future generations. Chemical fertilizers will benefit us, but not future generations. Human excreta should be fully utilized. You should read 'Farmers of forty centuries'. Ecology should be studied.

Forests are being destroyed. If forests are depleted, it would affect the rainfall. Forests should, therefore, be protected and forest cover should be extended.

It must, however, be kept in mind that while production should increase, compassion should also increase in the society. If compassion is not aroused in people's hearts, the poor will not be benefited. We do not want material progress only; we want both, material and moral progress to proceed simultaneously.

Collectivization and cooperation

Many fear that in gramdan, no one would be an owner, everyone would become a labourer and there would be collectivization of the Russian pattern and an individual would lose initiative. This fear is unfounded. In fact, the whole village would be a sort of cooperative

society in gramdan.

Good individuals nowadays are not much enthused by the cooperatives. It appears like a decentralised scheme of exploitation. Without equitable distribution of land, people would not have enthusiasm for cooperatives.

There is a difference between cooperative farming and collective farming. I do not recommend collective farming. It kills initiative. If collective farming is imposed, a class of managers would arise. This is a great danger. In bhoodan, I had first stipulated that land granted should be cultivated collectively. But I soon realised the dangers inherent in it. Cooperation should follow equitable land-distribution. Cooperative farming is desirable, but it should not be imposed.

Rather than collective farming, small cooperative societies should be formed for specific purposes like marketing, irrigation, night vigilance etc. I am in favour of service cooperatives, not cooperative farming. Secondly, peasants should be taught arithmetic before reading and writing. That would facilitate cooperative effort.

No to 'farmdari'

Zamindari has been abolished, but a new 'farmdari' has started. Big farms have been formed, wherein labourers are no better than bullocks; all powers are in the hands of managers. The intellect of labourers is not put to any use. I do not think that it is enough if the labourers are materially well-off; their intellect should also develop.

Three necessary things

Three things are necessary in India today:

- i) Efforts should be made to increase production, keeping the fertility of soil intact.
- ii) The production should benefit all.
- iii) There should be no bar on the movement of food

grains. Every village should have stock of food grains sufficient for two years.

Question of prices

Food is an essential item for everyone. So, it has to be affordable to all. In fact, the very idea of the price of food should itself be discarded. Like air and water, food should be available to all free of cost. If this is not possible, one should get it at as less price as possible. But if food grains are so priced, farmers would be at a disadvantage. So, some middle way has to be found.

Peasants also know that they cannot earn much from food crops, although they demand higher prices for food grains. Therefore, they prefer cultivation of cash crops like tobacco, sugarcane, jute, cotton or turmeric. But this cannot go on, as population is increasing. Cultivation of other crops means less area under food grains, and the country cannot afford it.

The people having money are often stupid and addicted to bad habits. Therefore, they give more price to tobacco than to food grains, which makes the cultivation of tobacco more profitable to the peasants. But cultivation of such crops has to be avoided in the interest of self-sufficiency in food.

We must never depend for food on other countries. Secondly, there should not be restriction on free movement of food grains within the country.

Revenue in the form of food grains

I have also suggested that government servants be given a part of their salaries in the form of food grains. This should be made mandatory for businesses also. If this measure were adopted, the government would have a stock of food grains. This practice would then be followed elsewhere too. Labourers in villages would be paid wages in the form of food grains. Prices of food grains would

not then undergo much fluctuation, and the fluctuation will not affect most of the people.

***Rishi-kheti* : the philosophy**

The *rishi-kheti*²⁷ at Paramdham ashram (Pavnar) is attracting wide attention (1952). Seasoned farmers get fascinated by this experiment on observing it and declare their intention to adopt it.

Rishi-sheti has a place in countries where land is less compared to population. As population increases and land-man ratio falls, rishi-kheti would have to be increasingly adopted. If one per cent of village land is reserved for rishi-kheti, unemployment can be reduced to a large extent.

Even in a country like U.S.A., where land is in abundance and mechanized farming is in vogue, many prefer rishi-kheti. This is no fad; this is an indication of a quest for purpose in life. There is a deep-rooted philosophy behind rishi-kheti. I note the following aspects in this connection:

(1) Every human being, wherever he may reside and whatever work he may be engaged in, should have contact with agriculture. Contact with nature will improve everyone's life.

(2) Rishi-kheti can be beneficial from the point of view of physical exercise and nature cure, and it can be done in every village.

(3) Rishi-kheti provides scope for study and research in agriculture, which could benefit farming with bullocks as well as mechanized farming. Thus, rishi-kheti can prove

27. Literally, farming by sages of yore. Vinoba used the term for farming with human muscle-power only, without the aid of machines and even bullocks.

to be a kind of laboratory.

(4) Rishi-kheti can be useful to enable all to have contact with agriculture. This would result in the harnessing of the intellect of all the people, resulting in all kinds of improvements in agriculture.

(5) It would be in the fitness of things that basic education schools are provided with a farm for rishi-kheti. Students can produce in it vegetables, cotton etc. needed by them.

(6) Rishi-kheti can be a remedy for the alleviation of unemployment.

(7) It is an experience that rishi-kheti helps greatly in the elimination of passions and mental distortions.

(8) Reduction in dependence on draught animals could prove to be the next step in the development of nonviolence. Rishi-kheti can prepare us for this.

Of course, it will have to be demonstrated that rishi-kheti can actually achieve all this. Report of the Paramdham experiment for the first year shows that it can achieve this. The experience has been encouraging.

It has to be noted here that rishi-kheti is not opposed to farming with the aid of bullocks. At Paramdham, we are practising both kinds of farming (1952). We are even using an engine to lift river-water. I am not generally in favour of installing engines everywhere, rendering the bullocks redundant. Yet I have consented to the use of engine as an exceptional measure to derive full use of the river water.

Bullocks are an integral part of our families. Keeping this in mind, we should undertake rishi-kheti on one hand and on the other hand use modern improved implements within appropriate limits. I have no doubt what these limits are.

Rishi-kheti: the actual experiment

It was in 1935-36. The disgust in my mind about money was at its height. I had been keeping my personal life free from money, but this time I was keen on carrying out the experiment of freeing public institutions from money; I was even feeling like laying down my life for this cause. I also exhorted my colleagues to try this experiment.

The saints have spurned money for the sake of spiritual progress. I think it is equally necessary to spurn money for the purification of worldly life. With this perspective, we began our experiment of kanchan-mukti.

Beginning was made by targetting self-sufficiency in vegetables. We started to grow vegetables. To water the field, we used to draw water from a well with a Persian wheel. Everyone would join in rotating the wheel. We used to have our prayers also while doing this work. Once Jayaprakash Narayan had come to meet me. He also joined in, and was considerably impressed.

Our experience for two years (1951-53) clearly showed that rishi-kheti does not need excessive exertion and the production was about 50% more than the production in conventional agriculture, even though we worked on inferior land.

If we restrict ourselves to thinking about and writing on sarvodaya, that would not suffice. We will have to work for its success. Only when we can demonstrate that a social order free from money and competition is a distinct possibility—even if on a small scale—we would be able to fight against communism and stop its advance. I, therefore, firmly believe that this experiment of kanchan-mukti at Pavnar was the foundation of the bhoodan work in Telangana.

12. Planning

On First Five-year Plan

(Gist of Vinoba's comments on the Draft First Five-year Plan and discussion with R.K. Patil, a member of the Planning Commission at Pavnar on 10 August 1951.)

Your plan does not seek to provide food and employment to all. If you accept the principle that food and employment should be provided to all and plan accordingly, the whole approach would change. I have recently seen in Telangana how people are addicted to liquor. But your report does not even mention this problem. Planning commission has no concern for the uplift of those people. You should commit yourselves to provide employment to all by a particular date. If those saddled with this responsibility find it impossible, they should better resign.

You ask the village industries to stand on their own legs, after cutting their legs! You say, 'How is it possible to do today what could not be done in twenty-five years by a man like Gandhiji?' But you forget that Gandhiji worked under a foreign regime under adverse circumstances. How much more should be possible now?

You had resolved to achieve food self-sufficiency by 1951. But you have broken the vow. Do you realize what would happen in case of a war? If you import food, you would have to bow to the exporters' dictates.

You have snatched away occupations from villagers, and are encouraging mills. We firmly hold that raw materials produced in the villages should be processed there, and such processing industries should be reserved for the villagers.

You do not mention ban on cow-slaughter, although you do not dare to say that slaughter of cows should

continue. You should realize that cow-slaughter cannot go on in this country. We stand for the ban on cow-slaughter. We can use the urine and excreta and bones etc. of the cattle; there need not be any economic burden of them. And as for the Muslims, I can give you in writing that they do not want cow-slaughter. Jawaharlalji (Prime Minister) recently said that banning cow-slaughter through issuing a decree from Delhi would not be proper. Well, there is no question of forcing a decision from above. But if the prime minister represents public opinion, who else but he should speak about such ban?

Planning should have place for basic education schools and it should have a scheme to make them economically viable.

You have suggested separate hostels and ashrams for harijans (dalits). I am against it. Education should be provided to them in conjunction with the removal of untouchability. So, they should be given admission in hostels etc. meant for all.

You say that production is less on small plots. You will have to prove this. I have seen how the government-run projects of collective agriculture have failed. They cannot succeed so long as people are illiterate.

The debate about economic or uneconomic holdings arises because of bullocks. But four families can have a pair of bullocks in common. Let the farmers cooperate with each other in as many respects as possible, but everyone who wants to do farming and demands land, must have it.

Dependence on rains will not do. I have calculated that if a well is dug for every marriage, millions of wells would be dug in forty years.

The lands of those who have more land should be distributed to those who seek land and have no other

source of livelihood. But the question of compensation prevents you from doing anything in this regard.

(After Vinoba's incisive comments, discussion followed.)

Patil : How to distribute the land?

Vinoba : That will depend on the local situation.

Patil : What should be the maximum landholding?

Vinoba : It is not a pertinent question. We should compute the available per capita land in the village and give that much land to every landless family. We would tell the landlords that we do not accept that you have any special right over land; we are distributing your land to save you from any danger in future. Importance of bhoodan should be impressed on them. They should be left with only as much land as they need for their livelihood.

Patil : How to distribute the land and by what calculation? There are differences in landholding and quality of soil from region to region. We cannot give a particular area everywhere.

Vinoba : That will vary, depending on the condition in the village. You will have to decide on the basic unit. If you have difficulty in taking village as a basic unit, you may take a district or a state as the basic unit.

Patil : Presently, more than three acres per capita land is available nowhere. Government does not have money to dig wells. Conditions are favourable for the farmer, yet agriculture is not prospering.

Vinoba : What is your answer for it?

Patil : Big landlords have got land, and money too. But they do not spend on land. One option is that government should take their lands and give these lands to experienced cultivators. But the question of

compensation arises in this case. Should compensation be given? And if so, how much? To whom land should be distributed? Distribution is likely to give rise to disputes. Rather than generating disputes, is it not better to maintain status quo? Nothing will be possible without the cooperation of the villagers.

Vinoba : Does it not show that people distrust the government? That is why people are not ready to entrust agriculture or industries to the government. Government should, therefore, conduct experiments in small units. If they succeed, they could be presented to the people for acceptance.

Anyway, distribute the lands of big landlords to the poor.

Patil : This does not appear feasible now.

Vinoba : It should be made feasible. I have urgency in this respect. Do whatever you can. The rest is for me to do.

Patil : But we do not have sufficient land.

Vinoba : Land is not sufficient, food is not sufficient, clothing is not sufficient! I say, let the people get what is available. If land is not sufficient, give us industries; and give protection to those industries. But you are not doing this.

Patil : Even if we think of fulfilling the need for clothing through khadi, it does not seem feasible in the next ten years.

Vinoba : I can clad the whole country in khadi in two years. If I fail in this, hang me! But if you do not want khadi, that is another matter. Make it compulsory to learn spinning. Adopt the basic education model in schools, whereby charkhas would be plied there. If government decides upon some policy, how can it not be

implemented? If you find it difficult, but have will, write to Charkha Sangh, entrust a tehsil²⁸ to them and give them all facilities for propagation of khadi.

Patil : You say that everyone should be given work. How is this possible today?

Vinoba : Why can't it be possible? Agriculture and village industries can remove unemployment in the villages. I would open a cooperative shop in every village. Every villager would have a share in it. Through this shop, I would come to know about the kinds and quantities of the goods needed by the villagers. Then concerned industries can be started in the village. The villagers should be as less dependent on money as possible, and their basic necessities of life should be fulfilled in the village itself. If these two postulates are accepted, it is not impossible to provide work to all.

To reduce dependence on money, I have been suggesting that land revenue should be collected in the form of grains. Why do you not accept it?

Patil : The question of storing grains would then arise. Ministers in all the states oppose this idea. The practice has been discontinued in areas where it was prevalent earlier.

Vinoba : This means that you prefer paper over gold. Even today, you have to store grains. Now you can take grains from big owners only; if you start collecting land revenue in the form of grains, you will get grains from every farmer. Why can't you arrange payment of major portion of wages to labourers in the form of grains?

Patil : How can it be done through legislation?

28. A part of a district.

Vinoba : Why not? If you can impose control (on food grains, for rationing), why can't you do this?

Patil : But how can this solve the problem of unemployment?

Vinoba : But will it not solve the problem of food? The food needed by the villagers will remain in the village. Let us think of other needs and then come to the problem of unemployment. Cotton is sent outside the village; why can't it be sent out after ginning? But you have opened ginning presses and destroyed home-ginning. Village industries have not died natural death; they have been killed. Ministers inaugurate new mills. You destroy cottage industries and introduce machines. Thus, you create unemployment and then ask how it is possible to give work to all. For example, village *ghanis* have been killed by introducing expellers.

Patil : We give permits to expellers, because it is an efficient means of production.

Vinoba : I do not want your 'efficiency'. Do you make any arrangement to tackle unemployment before introducing expellers? Do you take villagers into confidence?

Patil : Such industries were there in the past. But it is not that everybody had work and there was no unemployment. People were miserable in the past too.

Vinoba : It is a sheer speculation. People were happier earlier. A single evidence is sufficient: the rate of increase in population was less at that time. There is no ground for your assumptions. That is why I told you to make a firm resolve to give work to all. Then appropriate economic measures would follow automatically.

Patil : India's economic stagnation is due to stagnation in agricultural production.

Vinoba : We do want increase in agricultural production. Agriculture is the main occupation. Industries are subsidiary.

Mills used to produce 17 yards (per person), now production has come down to 12 yards. Why?

Patil : Mills do not get sufficient quantity of cotton.

Vinoba : They do not get sufficient cotton of the variety they want. That variety is not produced here; and the variety that is produced here is of no use to them.

Patil : But khadi cannot become widespread.

Vinoba : This is a mistaken impression. Even while Gandhiji was alive, we had claimed that within two years, we could clad the country with khadi. Our challenge still stands. The fact is that the government is out of its wits. Refugees (of Partition) had demanded grindstones instead of flour. The government agreed, and we purchased a few grindstones. But it was then said that contract for flour had already been given, so wheat could not be made available. Two villages near Pavnar had submitted a petition to the government that they did not want mill cloth; they should be taught spinning. No action was taken on their petition.

Patil : Do you think that khadi etc. can solve the problem of unemployment fully?

Vinoba : May be partially, if not fully. But there is no other way.

Patil : How to sell the khadi?

Vinoba : Why should it be sold? Khadi is not something to be sold; it is for use.

Patil : But a farmer does need cash to purchase other goods.

Vinoba : He should not need cash. Whatever he

needs can be, and should be, produced in the village.

Patil : Do you think nothing should be said about population control?

Vinoba : Artificial measures would not be conducive to a lasting change in life, and family planning is essentially a question of transformation in life. Artificial measures would lead to the erosion of moral values. If you say that you are not concerned about moral values, I have nothing to say.

(Vinoba also touched some other issues, particularly that of vegetable ghee).

Vinoba : Vegetable *ghee* is killing real *ghee*. Thus, it is harmful to the interest of cows. We had suggested that it should, at least, be coloured. A man like Rajaji argues that milk is adulterated with water; so should water be coloured? This is a senseless argument. In Rajasthan, vegetable *ghee* was not widely used; the situation has changed after the integration of native states. In Baroda, Gujarati was the official language and in Hyderabad, Urdu was the official language. After integration of these native states, English became the official language.

We do not want to fight on every issue. At least, you should stick to your resolve of achieving food self-sufficiency.

(Vinoba subsequently had detailed discussion with the Planning Commission at Delhi. After these discussions, he said in a press conference on 23 November 1951 –)

Both Planning Commission and I care for the good of our countrymen. But there is a fundamental difference between our approaches. Planning commission should accept the responsibility of providing food and work to all the countrymen. If they do not accept this responsibility, their planning would be partial, not for the whole country. And to provide work to all, villages must be

made self-reliant, which means establishment of industries therein to produce basic necessities of life from raw materials produced in the villages.

Let partiality be for the poor

(Vinoba continued to have discussions with members of Planning Commission from time to time and he continued to express his opinions in this regard.)

I asked the planners that planning might result in increase in the standard of living in the country in general, but what about the standard of living of the poor? They said that when the standard of living would increase in general, that of the poor would also increase to some extent. I call this 'theory of percolation'. If it rains on the surface of the soil, some water will trickle down. But, sometimes there are rocks, which prevent such trickling. In India, there are several rocks like caste differences and economic inequality.

I have experience of farming. We had a well, which was at a little higher level than the field. To take water to the field, we had dug a canal. We found that water used to get soaked in the canal; nothing reached the field. This is the condition. The poor are not getting any relief. Something must be done specifically for them so that they get at least the bare minimum to keep the body and soul together.

I found that the aid given by the government during relief operations could not reach the real needy. Some others siphon it off. Millions of rupees have been spent, but the condition of the lowest strata has not improved.

A member of Planning Commission once told me that it was not national planning, it was partial planning; some people would have to suffer in the process. I commented, "If it is partial planning, let partiality be for the poor!" If sacrifice is needed, we should sacrifice ourselves; we

should not sacrifice others.

Planning should have something concrete for the poorest strata. For example, does it have any scheme for the sweepers? How much money is being spent for the poorest and for small villages?

First Plan had emphasis on agriculture. In Second Plan, it was said that emphasis on agriculture was not needed. If we erect the whole structure of planning on such a postulate, we would deceive ourselves. Whatsoever the plan may be about, agriculture has to be considered the foundation.

Village planning

The brains of planners are filled with imported ideas. They sit in Delhi and decide what is to be done for all the villages in the country. They do not ask the villagers what they want, and foist their plan on the villages. Whether the people agree to it or not, new taxes are imposed on them. But plans imposed from Delhi cannot be successfully implemented in the villages.

Every village should have a different plan. Every village is different. But Delhi planners do not know the differences between villages. They make a single plan and ask all to adjust to it. But can a single drug work for all the diseases? Should shoes be made for the feet or should feet be made according to the shoes? Even if it is granted that the planners are intelligent and selfless, it is dangerous to let a handful of individuals plan for five hundred thousand villages. If every village plans for itself, the faults in one plan, if any, would not affect other villages. Intellects of all would get developed. But if there is a flaw in the plan made by the Planning Commission, it adversely affects all the villages in the country.

The programme of centralised planning has failed, even if intentions were good. So, instead of national planning,

there should be village planning. In fact, it is better to say that village planning should itself be national planning. People in Delhi should do only as much as is necessary for helping village planning. The government's help should be like the support provided to the arches; that support is removed when the arches are firmly in place.

Every gramsabha should prepare plan for the village, with the aim of providing a minimum standard of living, which should include adequate nutritious food, sufficient clothing, provision for education and health facilities, housing and wholesome entertainment. No one should be required to work for more than eight hours a day.

The plan made by the government, which is based on coercive power and is incapable of taking any radical measure, would surely not match with the plan of our conception. But as a nonviolent thinker, I consider it my duty to give my consent to the good portion therein, while putting before the people our plan, which would seek decentralisation through regional self-sufficiency, with a view to achieve eventually freedom from the State.

And it has to be realized that economic development is not enough. U.S.A. has achieved economic development to a great extent, yet no other country perhaps has more incidence of psychological disorders. Economic development should be under the control of spirituality.

Basic principles of nonviolent planning

Nonviolence need not be identified with a particular economic structure. Suppose, U.S.A. wants to build a social order on the basis of nonviolence and I tell them that everyone of them would have to spin for half an hour daily, that would be a narrow approach. We would have to take into account the local conditions. The economic scheme that we would implement in India would not be applicable to America. Even in India, the

scheme implemented today would have to be changed after fifty years. Flexibility is necessary in economic thinking. If we are dogmatic, we will face opposition at every step.

Only if we are not dogmatic, we can explore how to plan after grandan. Once the people accept our thoughts in general, we should not mind their making some changes. We may make any experiment, provided we keep untouched some basic economic theorems.

One such basic theorem is that human beings should have relationship with the soil. Just as plants are rooted in the soil, human beings should also be so rooted. Everyone should have some land, say 5 or 10 per cent of an acre and should work for two hours every day on the land. As long as human beings are not able to draw their sustenance from air, this economic theorem will hold good. Another principle is that tools should not become more important than the organs, which they are supposed to aid.

The life today has become extremely artificial. God has created darkness at night for peace, but man has set it on fire! Instead of beholding the beauty of starry sky, he switches on artificial lights, sees movies in closed and crowded theatres! Diseases are also spreading. This artificial life is not going to last long. To come out of it, man needs to have contact with the soil.

We want all kinds of progress, but in conjunction with three basic principles: (1) Man should have relationship with the nature. The joy of identification with nature is the greatest joy in human life, and human beings should have it; (2) Industries connected with agriculture should not lead to inequality and exploitation, and (3) Production should be equitably distributed. We want to make the villages prosperous, while sticking to these three premises.

13. Cow service

Meaning of cow service

We talk of cow service. But it may be asked, 'If your service means raising cows to increase milk yield and breed good bullocks, where is service to cows in it? You are serving your own interests!'

We should understand that there need not always be conflict between service and usefulness. We cannot serve an animal, which is not useful to us—that is our limitation. We will utilize the cow to the extent possible. Service of an animal means increasing its usefulness. That is what we do in respect of our children.

Just as we cannot serve someone without any utility, we should not use someone without service. This is what the word 'service' means, when we talk of service to cows. It means that we would not make use of the cow without serving her. This we do to some extent today also, but not as scientifically as we should, because we lack scientific approach. We may take the help of experts in this connection, but we should not leave everything to them. We should serve the cow directly. When we do it, the science of cow service would gradually get developed.

In brief, service to the cow means to give place to the cow in the human family for the sake of development of humanity, look after her well and make her economically viable through scientific approach, so that she does not become a burden on anyone, even while using her for our benefit.

Cow service means extending the power of love to the whole world.

Cow is a symbol. To understand its significance, purity of heart is needed.

Approach towards cow service

There can be two approaches towards cow service. The first one is ingrained in the Hindu mind: a sense of reverence for the cow. However, neglect of cows here is perhaps unmatched. What could be the reason? The reason is that the sense of reverence is not backed by a scientific mind. Unscientific faith is worthless. To believe that all the deities reside in a cow is not tenable in this age. Such extreme idol worship is nothing but stupidity.

We revere the cow, but she is looked after better in the West. We revere the cow; we do not love her. Westerners love the cow. We need to work scientifically. Our cow service should be tested on economic criteria. We will have to prove that cow is useful for human society economically.

These are two approaches, which often collide with each other, because of their one-sidedness. Merely economic approach implies that cows should be protected only as long as they are giving milk; thereafter they should be slaughtered. That the hide of slaughtered cattle fetches more price, is also a factor. Merely economic viewpoint can lead to nothing else. And that is what Westerners follow.

What should we do then? There is a third approach also, which may be called the approach of Indian socialism. We have given a place to cow in our families, and we have also thought over her usefulness before giving her such a place. Socialism enjoins that every person should be given work appropriate for him, full work should be taken from him and all of his basic needs should be provided for. This can be done in India for only one animal—cow. Therefore, Indian socialism has decided to include the cow in our society. By this decision, it has taken upon itself a great responsibility. We should have a clear idea of that responsibility.

Worship of cows

Go-palan (breeding and rearing of cows) is quite an ordinary concept. *Go-seva* (Cow service) is a humble word. 'Cow protection' smacks of vanity. I would, therefore, like to use the term 'cow worship'. Cow worship is a significant contribution of Indian culture to the whole world. I will not be satisfied with the practice of cow service and cow worship in India alone; the place of cow in human life is unique and I will be satisfied only when the whole world accepts the cow as a part of the human family and takes up cow service and cow worship.

We undertook several constructive programmes and carried them out to the best of our capacities. But in no work, purity of heart was found to be as necessary as in cow service. Cow servants should inculcate in themselves the qualities in a cow. They should become as harmless as a cow, humble and loving. They should also be pure in speech and alert in mind. Only then their work would attain the status of worship. Otherwise, their work would be nothing but *go-palan* (rearing of cows). It is done in other countries as well; and in a much better way. But it is we, who worship the cows.

Cow worship is a distinctive feature of Hindu dharma and of the Indian culture. If someone asks me whether I would insist on khadi in America, I would probably say, 'No'. But cow worship should be practised everywhere. I hold that it is the highest idea in Hindu dharma. And that puts special responsibility on us.

Economic aspect

We have looked upon cow as a member of our family. Cows and bullocks are the centre of rural economy in the society we dream of. Those who talk of rearing cows for the sake of milk and its products only are not aware of this.

India is a predominantly agricultural country. Indian agriculture is dependent on bullocks, and bullocks are the progeny of cows. To look after the cows is the real remedy for improving Indian agriculture. Cows should also be put to some work to improve their health. Improvement in the breed of cows should be done intelligently and through planned efforts, taking advantage of science. It is not sufficient to keep some barren land for grazing. Such land should be brought under cultivation and nutritious varieties of grass should be grown there.

Dung should not be used as fuel. From dung and urine, good manure can be prepared and the productivity of land can be enhanced. Gobar-gas plants can help much economically. Doing all this is also a form of cow service. Hide, bones, flesh, bones and other organs of dead cattle have various uses. Footwear and many other things can be prepared from hide. Bones and flesh also are good sources of manure. Toys and several other things can be prepared from horns. All this should be explored. Then old cows and bullocks would not appear economically burdensome. It would also improve the economy. This will be the true service of cows.

The Gita has listed agriculture, animal husbandry and trade as the occupations of the vaishyas, in this order. This order is significant. It shows how society should be organised.

It may be asked, 'Why insist on bullocks? Why can't we use tractors?' But then what would happen to bullocks? 'We can kill them and eat their meat', it can be replied. I believe that this is not possible in India. Moreover, landholdings are small here. Tractors can be utilized for low and fallow land, but to use it to till the land which can be ploughed by the bullocks will not be proper. It will not be an economic proposition here. A

tractor neither eats grass, nor gives manure. It requires crude oil. As long as crude oil needs to be imported, we cannot think of tractors here.

Why cow milk?

The Go-seva Sangh has directed its members to take a vow to use cow milk only (1942). Such a vow implies efforts to increase the yield of milk. It is often said that such a vow may inconvenience the people we visit. But I have seen that we cannot do anything worthwhile unless we make a firm resolve in that regard. And why should we be so formal? Wherever the sun goes, it goes with his rays. He does not bother whether his rays please people or torment them. Just as the sun goes everywhere with his rays, we should go everywhere with our principles. If I abandon my principles, I abandon my distinctive personality. It cannot be said that it would please our hosts either. A vow must, therefore, be taken.

Buffaloes also give milk, but we get bullocks only from the cows. Bullocks are essential for our agriculture. We should therefore pay special attention to cows in the interest of agriculture. It need not be thought that cows and buffaloes are opposed to each other. But we have to begin from cow service. In fact, we are raising buffaloes because of greed only. Buffaloes cannot bear the scorching heat, as a buffalo is not fully a land animal; it is amphibious. A buffalo bull is practically useless except in a few regions. It is not thus advisable to prefer buffaloes over cows.

Cow milk is the source of good protein. Milk is essential for vegetarians. As population increases, non-vegetarianism would have to be discouraged.

It is my prophesy that as population increases, people would increasingly prefer milk over meat. In India, it is milk that has freed many communities from meat-eating. That is the ground for the sacredness attached to milk. It

is scientifically proved that a non-vegetarian person needs four times more land than a vegetarian person. It is, therefore, necessary to give up meat-eating and adopt vegetarianism.

Milking cows is a discovery by human beings. We do not find in nature any animal consuming the milk of another animal. Tigers do not drink the milk of lionesses. But human beings drink the milk of cows, buffaloes, she-goats etc. Like agriculture, consumption of cow milk is a result of exploration in nonviolence.

Approach about breeding

No doubt, the breeds of cows in India need to be improved to increase the yield of milk. I agree with the idea of cross breeding—servicing by strong bullocks, but I am against artificial insemination. There is love in the union of male and female. Therefore, the progeny gets love right from the birth. Can we think of artificial insemination in humans? The same yardstick should apply to both, human beings and cows; for cow is not just one of the animals; it has been venerated since Vedic times. Milk of the cows produced through artificial insemination would be spiritually worthless.

I saw in an exhibition fat cows, which were to said to yield 80 pounds (36 kg) milk. I asked whether they could run. 'No', I was told. It is said in the medical science that cow milk obtained in the evening is better, because the cows have good exercise in the open when they graze during the day. These days, machines are used for milking. What is this going on? How can we stop such things? Where would the neglect of spiritual considerations in the quest for material progress alone take us?

I am sure that this 'progress' would take us to a point where eating human flesh would be considered perfectly right!

Celibacy necessary

Gandhiji had told Manibhai (Desai, of Uruli Kanchan), "You have to practise brahmacharya if you want to serve the cow." I explained the purport of this statement to Manibhai. We have included the cow in our family. If human population continues to grow unabated, human beings and cows would come in conflict with each other, as we would have to grow food on all the available land and nothing would be left for the cows. Human beings would start eating cows in such an eventuality. To protect the cows, human beings need to keep their numbers in check. That is why brahmacharya is essential.

Our responsibility

When we have taken the cow within the fold of our family, we have undertaken a responsibility to create a different social order. You can model your society on the Western pattern only if you decide to eat beef.

If we have taken the responsibility of looking after old cows also, which do not give milk.

If we have to progress in some matter or make new explorations, we have to engage ourselves in the concerned work. Only then new ideas can occur to us. We should ourselves do the work of milking cows, cleaning cow pens, feeding the cows etc. India will witness a revolution only when her leaders are seen engaged in milking cows or ploughing fields or carpentry. So long as the educated remain distanced from the uneducated, we cannot hope for a revolution here. You have to become a labourer if you want to bring about revolution.

We should have a holistic perspective: Khadi-wearers do not care to have cow milk and servants of cow do not wear khadi. This will not do. Khadi, village industries, cow service—no work will survive in isolation.

We should take a vow to use only cow milk.

Protection of cows

It is argued that our land is fragmented, so tractors are not an economic proposition and we would have to use bullocks; therefore, cows should be protected. But this is a weak argument, as it would not be valid when this weakness (fragmentation of land) is removed—and it has to be removed. Our argument should be just the reverse. We should argue that Indian society has integrated cow in the family and we cannot protect her so long we do not use her fully; if we use tractors, we cannot give full work to bullocks; and therefore cow protection is necessary. This is the right argument.

That the land is fragmented is a fact, but that condition needs to be remedied. I hold that all the land in the village should be pooled together in the interest of the village. Today, every farmer remains awake at night to guard his field. This will not be necessary if the village land is pooled together. Most of the farmers cannot even afford a pair of bullocks, not to speak of tractors. Therefore, pooling of land is the only way.

As far as cow protection is concerned, it should be done at both governmental and non-governmental levels. There should be legislation banning the slaughter of both cows and bullocks. But mere legislation will not suffice. Efforts are needed to ensure that a cow never becomes a burden. If farmers feel that old cattle are burdensome, cattle stalls—institutions to take care of dry and old cows—should be established. Businessmen should come forward for this purpose.

Gramdan appears to be the only option to protect cows, as the village land would be communally owned after gramdan. The village can then decide how much land should be reserved for grazing. Our farmers know the science of agriculture, but not the science of rearing the cows. Cow service should be done collectively, and

not on individual level. Only gramdan can provide the basis for a communitarian scheme of cow service. This work needs collective efforts, perhaps more than any other work. Gramsabha is, therefore, the proper institution for shouldering this responsibility.

I believe that India's culture enjoins that cows must be protected in India. If we cannot protect cows here, we have as good as lost our Independence.

It is good that India has a secular State. But that is not in conflict with cow protection. It would have been so, had one religion considered cow-slaughter a sin, and another religion considered it an act of merit. But such is not the case. I have studied the Quran and the Bible deeply and reverentially, just as I have studied the Vedas. I can, therefore, say on behalf of Islam and Christianity that they do not prescribe sacrifice of the cow. Sacrifice of animals is a part of those religions, and it is also a part of Hindu dharma; but no religion prescribes sacrifice of cows only. I have studied the Quran no less than any maulana. Islam asks its followers to respect the sensibilities of their neighbours. Hadith prescribes consumption of cow milk. All the Muslim members had supported ban on cow-slaughter in the Constituent Assembly. It may also be noted that Emperor Akbar had banned cow-slaughter. Saint Paul has said, "I will eat no flesh - - - lest I make my brother to offend." Christians believe that God is love. And it is our experience that domestic animals can feel the touch of love. Basis of this experience is that God resides in them. Therefore, cows should be protected in our secular State.

Cow protection Acts often distinguish between cows and bullocks. This is not right. I am told that our Constitution provides for the protection of cows and calves alone. I am not a constitutional expert. But why are cows sought to be protected? Is it from an exclusively

economic angle or because it is a demand of our culture? If it is from an economic angle alone, we would not have undertaken the responsibility of feeding old, weak and decrepit cows. If it is accepted because it is a demand of our culture, then bullocks also must be protected. In the Vedas, a cow is called '*aghnya*' and a bullock is called '*aghneya*'. Both the words mean that they should not be killed.

We should, therefore, ban cow-slaughter with immediate effect, open institutions for looking after the cattle, which have not remained useful for agriculture or as a source of milk. They should be allowed to die their natural death there. Their urine, excreta, hide, bones etc. should be fully utilized.

Cow is like our mother. Killing a cow is like killing our own mother. Ban on cow-slaughter is enjoined by India's culture. Indian Constitution has accepted this principle and Government of India is bound by its promise to enforce it. Indian parliament has also resolved in its favour. Cow-slaughter should, therefore, be banned immediately. I have taken the path of compassion for redistribution of land through bhoodan. Human beings can do that. But cows cannot do anything for ban on their slaughter I, therefore, stand for a legal ban on it.²⁹



29. Vinoba resolved to fast twice, in 1976 and 1979, and actually fasted once for ban on cow-slaughter. In 1982, he directed his followers to undertake satyagraha at Deonar abattoir in Mumbai for ban on the slaughter of both cows and bullocks. The satyagraha went on for many years and created a record.